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₹4.3 lakh crore disbursed under PM-KISAN, ₹26+ lakh crore worth of procurement at MSP, ₹2 lakh crore crop insurance, 8 crore Kisan Credit Cards - together these initiatives are strengthening the nation's Annadatas

12 Saal Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-kalyan ke

Government of India

CELEBRATIONS AT BHARAT MANDAPAM

NDA turns 12 today, meets to mark Modi crossing Nehru stint

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 9

LEADERS OF NDA constituents will meet at the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi Wednesday to celebrate the completion of 12 years of the BJP-led government and Prime Minister Narendra Modi reaching a personal milestone by becoming the longest continuously serving elected Prime Minister, bettering the record of Jawaharlal Nehru.

On Wednesday, Modi will complete 4,399 consecutive days in office as Prime Minister, one more than the 4,398 days of Nehru as a directly elected Prime Minister who entered office on May 13, 1952 and served until his death on May 27, 1964. The 1952 general election was the first since Independence when Nehru was chosen Prime Minister.

Speaking to reporters Tues-

EDITORIAL PAGE

4,399 DAYS, THE LONG ARC OF LEADERSHIP
BY M VENKAIAH NAIDU P 10

THE IDEAS PAGE

MODI MILESTONE IS AFFIRMATION OF STRENGTH, OPENNESS OF DEMOCRACY

BY NITISH KUMAR

MODI'S CHALLENGES: DIVERSITY, DISSENT, DELIMITATION P 11

day, BJP president Nitin Nabin said, "These 12 years under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership have been

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

BJP leaders see CJP protests as 'part of democracy', say Gen Z not anti-establishment

Liz Mathew & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, June 9

AS THE newly formed Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) draws support for its campaign against paper leaks and other exam controversies, the BJP will take an accommodating stand. Amid the clamour for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign, senior BJP leaders stressed here Tuesday that youth should not be "defamed for their aggressive stand over issues".

Noting that he had "serious reservations about Gen Z being termed as anti-establishment",

EXPLAINED

CAN COCKROACH BE USED AS POLITICAL PARTY SYMBOL P 13

a top BJP leader said: "There are youngsters who are involved in stone-pelting in Jammu and Kashmir, but it's also thanks to them that the Union Territory won the Ranji Trophy for the first time. Similarly, the Gen Z that is making the Start Up drive a success is also protesting over errors in the education sector."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



THE BIG PICTURE

A-I CRASH: TWO MEN & A PHONE CALL

• BIGGEST WORLD CUP IN HISTORY BEGINS THIS WEEK UNDER SHADOW OF U.S. VISA RESTRICTIONS, ICE THREAT

The football world is coming to America, but not everyone is welcome this time



Sandip G
New York, June 9

THE BILLBOARD finds you before you find it. Step out of the subway at Times Square and there it is — three storeys of France's Kylian Mbappé, his

face stretched, jaw set, eyes fixed on something beyond the frame. Next to him, is the Brazilian, Vinicius Jr. Football's global stars are sparkling from the Manhattan skyline.

This is New York in the days before the FIFA World Cup 2026, which begins on June 11, and the city is doing what it always does with the world's attention — absorbing it, amplifying it, making it feel like it was always meant to be here.

"Back in the day, it was all about supporting the country

NO SIGN OF PRICE DIP, DOMESTIC PRODUCTION BEING RAMPED UP

Fertiliser subsidy burden set to double on global supply crunch

PSUs float tenders for imports, Govt plans to tap Russia to meet demand

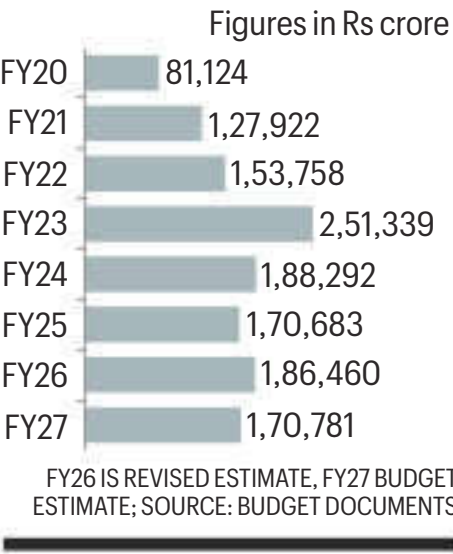
Siddharth Upasani & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, June 9

RISING GLOBAL costs of fertilisers amid a supply crunch is likely to result in a subsidy burden of almost Rs 3.4 lakh crore, or an almost 100 per cent increase compared with the Budget estimate of Rs 1.7 lakh crore, according to top government sources.

"We are still selling fertiliser at a subsidised price of around

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• Fertiliser subsidy



Breakthrough at Zojila

Vehicles pass through the Zojila tunnel after its breakthrough ceremony at Meenamarg in Ladakh, Tuesday. The 13.153-km tunnel, which connects Kashmir Valley to Ladakh, forms the centrepiece of the Zojila project, which is aimed at ensuring year-round access to the region. AP REPORT, PAGE 7

Fish trader with crypto links to Cambodia fresh catch in digital scam

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, June 9

A 45-YEAR-OLD man who took premature retirement as a hawdardar from the Army about 10 years ago; a father of two who is now a fish trader in Andhra Pradesh's East Godavari district; a cyber crime operator who had been jailed earlier in Gujarat — and whose phone allegedly contains details of cryptocurrency worth Rs 40 lakh.



The Express report on digital arrests dated June 30, 2025

These are the multiple strands in the police profile of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Seven killed in PoK unrest, India says Pak must be held accountable

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 9

WITH AT least seven persons reported to have been killed in police action on protesters in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), India on Tuesday flagged the "severe police brutality" and called on the international community to hold Islamabad accountable for its "misdeeds and abuses".

According to a report in Pakistan daily Dawn, at least 11 people, including four police personnel, were killed in Rawalakot on Sunday as security personnel cracked down on protesters from the banned Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC).

Responding to a question on Tuesday, the Ministry of

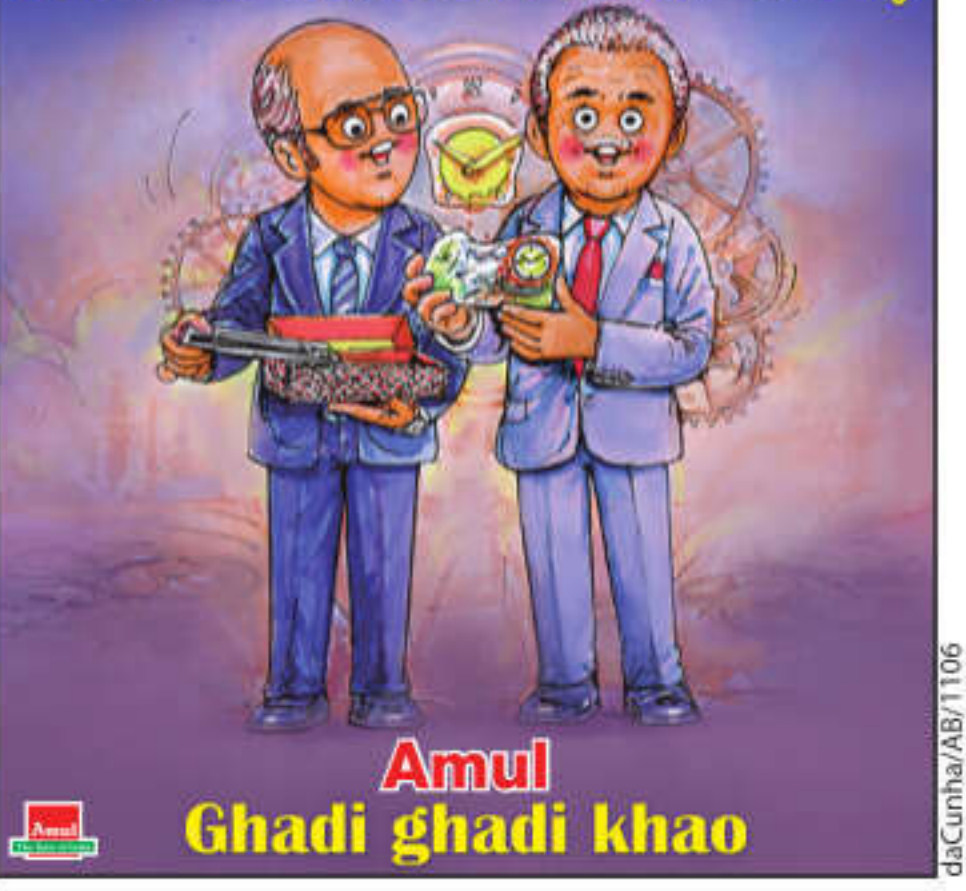
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

• TOP OFFICIALS OF the Health and Education ministries, the NTA and the National Medical Commission will brief a House panel on the NEET-UG retest.

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Made in India-A Bitin' Story



PARTY FLIES OUT MLAs IN VAIN

Natarajan's RS papers rejected, Cong cries foul, to meet EC today

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 9



Meenakshi Natarajan

WHAT BEGAN as a battle over whether Congress could keep its Madhya Pradesh legislators together ended with the party losing its Rajya Sabha candidate altogether. On Tuesday, Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination to the Upper House of Parliament was rejected, delivering a significant victory to the BJP after days of political manoeuvring, legal challenges and an aggressive campaign that put the opposition on the defensive.

The rejection comes days after the BJP upended the election by fielding a third candi-

date, Mahesh Kewat, against Natarajan and then mounting a legal challenge to her nomination papers.

The development came after the Congress spent much of Tuesday focused on moving its legislators to Karnataka, where it is in power. The party leadership had decided to shift

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

Maharashtra govt considers adding 5.75 lakh farmers to loan waiver scheme

Shubhangi Khapre
Mumbai, June 9

THE MAHARASHTRA government is considering widening the scope of the Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Shetkari Karj mukti Yojana 2026 to include around 5.75 lakh farmers who were left out of the farm loan waiver schemes announced in 2017 and 2019.

At the weekly Cabinet meeting Tuesday, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis asked Agriculture Department to prepare a proposal to extend the benefits of the newly announced loan waiver scheme to these farmers.

Highly placed sources in the Agriculture Department said accommodating the additional beneficiaries would impose an estimated burden of Rs 1,400 crore on the state exchequer, over and above the Rs 36,585-crore outlay already announced under the scheme.

The development comes two days after *The Indian Express* reported that the state government's own Cabinet note had acknowledged that the scheme's eligibility restrictions would reduce the eventual financial burden on the state by limiting the number of beneficiaries. The note had lent weight to Opposition allegations that a large number of distressed farmers could be left out of the scheme.

A day after the report, Agriculture Minister Dattatraya Bhanne had indicated that the government was open to revisiting some of the eligibility conditions and said the issue could be discussed in the Cabinet to ensure that more farmers benefited from the scheme.

"The proposal was discussed in the Cabinet meeting and the Chief Minister asked the Agriculture Department to work out the details. Around 5.75 lakh farmers who were left out of the previous loan waiver schemes are proposed to be included. The additional financial implication is es-



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis. FILE

estimated at around Rs 1,400 crore," a senior official said.

According to sources, the issue was raised by a Shiv Sena minister during the meeting. The proposal seeks to address complaints that several farmers were excluded from the 2017 and 2019 farm loan waiver schemes despite being eligible.

The discussion assumes significance as the state government faces mounting criticism from Opposition parties and farmer leaders over the eligibility conditions attached to the newly announced loan waiver scheme.

Congress state president Harshvardhan Sapkal has also criticised the eligibility criteria, claiming that a large number of distressed farmers would remain outside the scheme's ambit. On June 2, the state Cabinet approved the Rs 36,585-crore Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Shetkari Karj mukti Yojana, which is expected to benefit around 55.72 lakh farmers.

Under the scheme, crop loans availed between April 1, 2019, and March 31, 2025, are eligible for consideration. Farmers with outstanding crop loan arrears as of September 30, 2025, can receive a waiver of up to Rs 2 lakh. Farmers who have regularly repaid their loans will be eligible for an incentive of up to Rs 50,000. Farmers with outstanding loans exceeding Rs 2 lakh will have to repay the amount above threshold, following which the government will waive the remaining amount up to Rs 2 lakh.

Coaching centre firing case: Patna court stays arrest of Faizal Khan

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 9

A PATNA court on Tuesday granted interim protection from arrest to educator and YouTuber Faizal Khan, popularly known as 'Khan Sir', in a case related to a firing incident outside his coaching institute in the city last week, his lawyers said. The anticipatory bail matter came up before the principal district and sessions judge, who, after hearing the case, issued a stay on Khan's arrest and fixed June 20 as the next date of hearing.

"Interim protection has been granted to Khan Sir," the YouTuber's counsel, advocate Arvind Kumar Mouar, said, adding that the court sought his "criminal antecedents and an updated case diary" from the police. Khan has been accused of asking his security guards to fire at a crowd after violence outside his Khan Global Studies (KGS) coaching centre.

The order comes amid questions over why he had not been arrested despite being named in a First Information Report (FIR) registered under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) relating to an attempt to murder and sections of the Arms Act. Raushan Anand, director of Gyan Bindu Coaching Institute and an accused in the counter-

FIR linked to the same incident, was arrested shortly after the case against him was registered.

The Indian Express had on Monday sought responses from Patna Senior Superintendent of Police Kartikeya K Sharma and City SP (Central) Diksha on the status of the investigation and the reasons for Khan's non-arrest, but no response was received. The case stems from violence that broke out outside the KGS coaching centre in Patna's Musallahpur Haat area on the night of June 2. According to police, a group of 15 to 20 people allegedly related to Gyan Bindu Coaching vandalised the institute, hurled stones, and assaulted a security guard, Chun Chun, who sustained a head injury.

The original FIR, lodged on the complaint of KGS manager Kanhaiya Kumar Singh, named Anand, Prince, Abhishek, Gaurav and several unidentified persons. The complaint alleged that the accused assaulted the guard, damaged property, tore down signboards and threatened to "blow up" the coaching institute within two days. It also claimed that tensions had arisen after the Bihar Police constable recruitment results, in which KGS allegedly recorded a higher number of successful candidates.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Fertiliser subsidy bill

Rs 300 per sack even though the cost has gone up from around Rs 2,900 post Covid to around Rs 4,500 now. So, the subsidy (bill) may be 100% more than the Budget estimate," a source, who did not wish to be named, said.

"It's a very complex situation. Global suppliers, including China, are holding on to their stock due to the Iran war. The government is looking at Russia to meet more of its imports," another senior government official told *The Indian Express*.

Another concern that the government is keen to address relates to diversion of fertilisers meant for farmers to the industry. The official said this issue is being discussed at the highest levels of ministries concerned — agriculture, fertilisers and finance.

On May 27, state-owned National Fertilizers Ltd issued a global tender to buy 17 lakh metric tonnes (LMT) of urea. Before that, in early April, Indian Potash Ltd had issued a tender to import 25 LMT of urea.

According to sources, the government does not see signs of fertiliser prices coming down and is trying to ramp up domestic production.

The government had esti-

mated it would need to spend Rs 1.71 lakh crore on fertiliser subsidy in 2026-27. Latest data from the Controller General of Accounts shows the Centre spent Rs 22,033 crore as subsidy in April for urea and nutrient based fertilisers, roughly 13% of the full-year estimate.

For 2025-26, the government raised the revised estimate for fertiliser subsidy to Rs 1.86 lakh crore from Rs 1.68 lakh crore. However, provisional data from the Controller General of Accounts shows the actual amount spent on fertiliser subsidy last fiscal was Rs 2.11 lakh crore — Rs 24,920 crore more than the revised estimate. This is 22% higher than 2024-25.

In addition to the stress on the government finances from the rising fertiliser subsidy, pressure is also coming from elevated fuel prices, with about Rs 1.23 lakh crore lost in the form of revenue foregone due to the Rs 10 per litre excise duty cut announced in March and under-recoveries of public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs), sources said. Prior to the excise duty cut, OMCs were losing about Rs 1,000 crore a day. That figure has now come down to around Rs 650 crore.

While the Centre managed to meet its fiscal deficit target of

4.4 per cent of GDP for 2025-26, the deficit in April surged to a 26-month high of Rs 3.62 lakh crore, accounting for 21.4 per cent of the entire 2026-27 target.

The war in West Asia and the closure of the key waterway of the Strait of Hormuz has led to a huge jump in fertiliser prices, with India's latest purchases of urea from abroad having been at a cost-plus-freight price of \$935-\$959 per tonne, more than double the year-ago figure of \$410-\$420.

Fertiliser was one of the '3 Fs' cited by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman last month — along with fuel and foreign exchange to buy gold — that required a focus amid pressures exerted on the rupee by the ongoing conflict as all these three items had to be paid for in foreign currencies and not rupees on account of them being imported.

Government officials also expressed concern about the diversion of subsidised fertiliser for farmers to industry.

"States have been told that fertiliser to farmers should be provided such that if the requirement, for example, is one sack, they should be given two sacks if needed. But in some states, five and even seven sacks are being given. How can that much fertiliser be even used? Clearly, it is going somewhere else," an official said.

Ports

imposed by port authorities. The country's top export promotion council, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO), has flagged this in a mis-

The alarm raised by exporters comes after weeks of delays in container evacuation, persistent and heavy congestion across western ports such as Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT), Kandla and Mundra, which together form India's biggest container gateway. Congestion at the port began to swell last month after the heavy influx of stranded West Asia-bound shipments began in the backdrop of the Iran-US ceasefire announced in April.

The FIEO told the government that a Directorate General of Shipping (DGS) advisory issued on March 9, asking stakeholders to "refrain from predatory, non-transparent and opportunistic pricing practices, including levy of exorbitant charges", is not being followed on the ground. "Based on industry feedback, exporters continue to report instances of unilateral and non-transparent levy of charges such as detention, demurrage, War Risk Surcharge, additional freight and related surcharges. In this regard, the

possibility of suitable monitoring of audit mechanisms may kindly be examined to assess implementation of the DGS advisory at the ground level and to discourage any non-transparent or opportunistic pricing practices impacting trade," the FIEO wrote on May 19.

In response to a query by *The Indian Express*, a Shipping Ministry representative said Sarbajit Sonowal, Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, has been reviewing the situation and has met various stakeholders, including importers, exporters, the shipping lines and port officials. "He also warned stakeholders not to try extra profit-making by taking advantage of the situation," the representative said. A query mailed to the Commerce and Industry Ministry did not elicit a response.

The Shipping Ministry representative said that in March 2026 and early April 2026, certain containers destined for West Asia had been diverted to Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA) and were given temporary storage at the western port on a transshipment basis. "These containers have later been shipped out to West Asia through the ports of Khor Fakkan, Sohar, and Salalah. Currently, there are no such instances of stranded containers destined to West Asia lying in the port," the representative said.

Exporters said a shortage of transport workers has added to

the challenges of the ports and led to a sharp spike in transport costs. An advisory issued by JNPA on May 15 said the recent development of a shortage of trailer drivers due to the vacation season, compounded with elections and other factors, has created a serious impediment in shifting the import containers from terminals to Container Freight Station (CFS).

The Shipping Ministry representative said there has been no strike at JNPA in the past year. "However, there has been a shortage of drivers in April and May, due to drivers taking an annual vacation every year during this period. This year, due to various other issues, including the West Asian crisis, more drivers (above 50%) have gone on leave to their native places. This has caused a certain delay in the evacuation of import containers to CFS. Currently, this issue is also under control," the representative said.

Khalid Khan, former Vice President & Regional Chairman, FIEO, said, "There is a high backlog at ports, and several containers are not able to get in or come out. This resulted in a huge traffic jam at the western ports. And the cost of this traffic jam is borne squarely by the exporters. During a crisis, relief measures should be announced, but even charges for services like lift-on or lift-off charges have gone up several times."

NDA turns 12 today

underlined by Vishwas, Vikas and Jan Kalyan (trust, development and public welfare). This era will be recorded in history as one of Bharat's economic empowerment, of the rise in its honour and respect on the global stage. We believe and can say with pride that we have fulfilled our sankalp (resolve)... with a new thought process, a collective commitment and collective dreams. Prime Minister Nar-

endra Modi is taking the nation forward."

The Ministry of External Affairs hailed the strengthening of what it called Brand India. "Over the last 12 years, India's foreign policy has witnessed a remarkable transformation, strengthening both Brand India and India's standing on the global stage under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on X.

7 killed

External Affairs (MEA) official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said: "We continue to see in this context, a pattern of fake news and videos emanating from Pakistan. It is a desperate attempt by Pakistan to cover up its own failings and deflect attention away from its human rights abuses. There are reports of severe police brutality in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir in which several protesters have been killed and many injured. We hope the international community will hold Pakistan accountable for its misdeeds and abuses."

According to *Dawn*, "The situation started deteriorating after a trader affiliated with the JAAC was reportedly shot in an altercation with law enforcers on Saturday. The following day, protesters and law enforcement agencies clashed outside a Rawalakot hospital... resulting in the deaths of at least four policemen and seven protesters."

Football

Men dressed as Clutch the Bald Eagle waddled through concourses shaking hands with strangers. Nike's Rip The Script advertisement, featuring the who's who of world football, plays on loop.

The NBA Finals — San Antonio Spurs against the local New York Knicks — runs in the backdrop but has not deflected the gaze from what is coming. Two evenings ago, the Netherlands squad made a pilgrimage to Times Square before flying to their training base in Missouri — as if this intersection was a required stop, a place where you confirm to the world that you have arrived.

Forty-eight teams. A hundred and four matches. Three host countries with distinct sensibilities — and not all too cordial relations. Sixteen venues across multiple time zones. It is, as US President Donald Trump puts it in his drawing

"From being the voice of the Global South to First Responder in times of crisis, from championing climate action through initiatives including International Solar Alliance to driving digital public goods such as UPI across borders, India has combined national interest with global good," he said.

Union Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said Modi has infused "speed and scale" to government schemes to enhance benefits for people. According to a PTI report from Bhubaneswar, Meghwal told a press confer-

ence: "Schemes existed before 2014, but after Modi assumed charge that year, he infused speed and scale to those."

Senior BJP leader and former Union Minister Ravi Shankar Prasad told *The Indian Express*, "Prime Minister Modi has several firsts to his commendable record. In 2014, he won the first clear majority after 30 years. Be it Digital India, the fact that the world is watching the growth of the Indian economy and our technology, women's empowerment... the PM's work speaks for itself. In this series of firsts that

staccato, "a once in a lifetime opportunity".

Sections of the local press have called him "America's first soccer President" -- in office when the bid was won, back in the White House for kick-off. At the draw ceremony, FIFA president Gianni Infantino handed him FIFA's first-ever peace prize — days before the US launched attacks on Iran, one of the teams that will play here, training in Mexico while competing on American soil. He will not retreat to the wings once the games begin.

But the tournament's real story is not on the billboards.

Walk from Times Square to 46th Street and you are, within blocks, in Little Brazil — nearly a lakh Brazilians call this part of Midtown home. Head north and the streets carry the rhythms of Accra. The Lower East Side has Germans. Roosevelt Avenue belongs to Ecuadorians.

Jones is Welsh by origin, American by allegiance, grieving quietly that his country did not qualify, but buoyed by what

surrounds him. "Suppose Brazil is playing in Los Angeles," he says. "Brazilians in every city and town will huddle into the local pub. Same when Ghana or Senegal or Japan or Croatia play."

What makes this World Cup unlike any before it is not the scale, though the scale is staggering. It is this: the communities who will fill these streets — who will wave flags, weep and sing in a dozen languages, who will turn a pub on Roosevelt Avenue into a corner of Quito — are the very people this government has spent two years trying to remove.

The geopolitics is heavy. Iran is at war with the US and will play here anyway. Relations with Iraq are frosty. Haiti and Algeria face visa restrictions. Several African nations are managing an Ebola outbreak. Traditions between co-hosts Mexico and Canada are strained. Hunter drones, robot dogs, X-ray trucks and AI cameras now patrol public space.

A Somali referee — the first from his country ever appointed to a World Cup — was turned

away at Miami airport days before the tournament began. ICE (Immigration and Customs Enforcement) agents, meanwhile, have not been prohibited from making arrests at stadiums. And yet the countdown clock ticks.

The 1994 World Cup on these shores was described by its architect Alan Rothenberg as "football's ground zero in the States". It still holds the joint record for the highest average attendance in tournament history. "I wasn't sure how much Americans would take to it," he wrote in his book *The Big Bounce*. "What we did know was Americans love a big event — so we'd make it into a big event."

What exists now is different. It is a nation that Don Garber, commissioner of Major League Soccer, calls "the ATM of world football". It now understands the game and wants to own it. Whether it can also feel it — in its bones, in its streets — is the question 41 days will answer.

Outside, the city makes no promises. The billboards blaze on.

Natarajan

MLAs out of Madhya Pradesh amid concerns that BJP leaders were attempting to contact them before the Rajya Sabha election. But the flight to Karnataka was delayed by several hours, and the legislators had to wait outside the Raja Bhoj airport with their suitcases. By the time they got permission to board in the evening, the BJP had dealt the blow, and the legis-

lators had to return from the airport.

A total of 62 Congress legislators were supposed to fly out to Karnataka. While the BJP currently has 165 MLAs in the Assembly, sufficient to win two seats, to ensure Kewat's victory in the third seat, it needed to secure 9 to 11 additional votes.

At the centre of the row was an objection filed by BJP state general secretary Rahul Kothari, who alleged Natarajan had failed to fully disclose details of

a case in the affidavit submitted with her nomination papers.

In a representation to the Returning Officer, Kothari pointed to a private complaint pending before a court in Hyderabad.

Returning Officer Arvind Sharma, in his order rejecting Natarajan's nomination, recorded that Natarajan "submitted an incomplete affidavit in Form 26 and concealed material facts" related to the court case. "This amounts to withholding complete information

about the candidate from voters, and it stands established that incomplete information was presented in lieu of full disclosure," the order read.

Natarajan accused BJP of "clearly attempting to manipulate the Rajya Sabha election just as they previously subverted elections in Madhya Pradesh."

Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal said the allegations against Natarajan were baseless and politically motivated.

Fish trader

Swamy Ayyappa Naravula, arrested by a Gurugram Special Investigation Team (SIT) on May 25 from Hyderabad for his alleged role as the "main link" and "mediator" in the Rs 5.85-crore digital arrest scam involving a top private sector executive.

The scam was at the centre of a series of investigative reports published by *The Indian Express* in July last year on how digital scamsters moved crores in minutes through a maze of 141 deposits in 23 banks across 15 states.

According to investigators tracking the Gurugram case, the recovery of Ayyappa's phone from police in Gujarat, where he was arrested in October 2025 before obtaining bail, has confirmed that cyber gangs have been erasing their banking trails

currency and effect a recovery for the complainant."

In the Gurugram case — just one of the 1.23 lakh such crimes reported in 2024, involving a total of Rs 1,935 crore in stolen money — *The Indian Express* had reported that scamsters routed Rs 5.85 crore from the victim's HDFC Bank accounts through three layers: the ICICI Bank account of Piyyush, a resident of Subana village in Hajjar district, Haryana; 25 other accounts in 10 banks across the country; and onward to 141 more accounts.

This newspaper also reported that the second layer of 25 accounts included at least 11 in the Sreenivasa Padmavathi Co-operative Urban Bank in Hyderabad. The account-holders included a tailor and a carpenter who told police that Samudrala Venkateswarlu, one of the bank's directors, had allegedly made them sign blank cheque books and withdrawal

forms on the pretext of getting them jobs.

Piyyush and a group of associates were arrested and are on bail. Samudrala was arrested on April 29 by the SIT. During interrogation, Samudrala allegedly told police that the "Hyderabad gang" used to withdraw money from mule accounts, convert it to USDT, and transfer the cryptocurrency to Ayyappa.

"That made Ayyappa a prime suspect in the case and his ongoing interrogation is now expected to give more valuable leads on solving this and other digital arrest cases," Yadav said.

The Indian Express had reported that the SIT was alerted by the Union Home Ministry's cyber fraud unit, the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), that the 11 Hyderabad accounts are also allegedly at the heart of 181 other such complaints. According to one complaint, Rs 21 crore had allegedly passed through these ac-

counts in just three months.

Surendra Rohilla, the Investigating Officer of the Gurugram case who led the team that arrested Ayyappa, told *The Indian Express* that during interrogation, it emerged that USDT and Telegram chats linked to the case were allegedly in his phone that was confiscated by the Gujarat police.

"Ayyappa was the main middleman and mediator in the deal. After everybody was paid and their cuts, the USDT would be routed to cyber gangs in Cambodia. In all, Ayyappa has confessed that he earned commissions of over Rs 1.5 crore since October last year from various cyber crimes, including this one," Rohilla said.

Police records show that Ayyappa, who hails from Tadepalligudem town in Godavari, recently started a business in fish trading. At least 16 cases were lodged against him between 2024 and 2025, many by

the cyber police in Ahmedabad. While several have been dismissed, there are three "active" cases lodged against him by the cyber police at Shahibaug in Ahmedabad. He was on bail when the Gurugram SIT arrested him.

"Once Ayyappa confessed that all Telegram chats connected to the Gurugram case and the record of his USDT deposits were in the confiscated phone, the team obtained a court order and got it transferred as case evidence," Rohilla said. Ayyappa had allegedly not told Gujarat police about the cryptocurrency transactions and USDT details on his phone, linked to the Gurugram case, he said.

Meanwhile, the Gurugram executive has recovered Rs 1.05 crore of the stolen money — some from banks used in the scam and some in cash recovered from Samudrala at the time of his arrest.

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—Shri Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister of India

ASSOCHAM congratulates Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji on completing 12 years of exemplary lok seva and achieving the historic milestone of becoming India's longest serving Prime Minister.

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HC order on removal of encroachment in ‘O Zone’ pertains to new constructions: CM

91 unauthorised colonies to enjoy temporary protection from punitive action until December 31, HC said in May

Gayathri Mani & Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 9

DELHI CHIEF Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday said that a recent Delhi High Court order related to the removal of encroachment in the ‘O Zone’ — eco-sensitive areas along the Yamuna river where construction is prohibited — pertained only to new constructions and not the existing ones.

On May 23, the HC had observed that residential colonies in Yamuna floodplain area, classified as O Zone, are “completely impermissible”, while noting that 91 unauthorised colonies in the area continue to enjoy temporary protection from punitive action until December 31, 2026 under the National Capital Territory of Delhi Laws (Special Provisions) Second Act, 2011. This was after the Centre submitted that occupants of the 91 unauthorised

colonies are protected from demolition until December 31.

In a meeting attended by several MPs, including Ramvir Singh Bidhuri and Manoj Tiwari, Gupta said on Tuesday that the HC had not made any observations regarding constructions that had already been completed, but raised concerns about ongoing construction activities.

Bidhuri told *The Indian Express* that Delhi government will soon meet the Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal to discuss the matter. “The HC has said that the 91 unauthorised colonies will not be demolished until December 31. In the meantime, we will meet the Union Minister to discuss the matter,” he added.

On May 23, the HC had directed Additional Secretary (MoHUA) D Thara to ensure that a meeting is held on June 8 between officials of MoHUA, including Thara, MCD and

DDA, and to place an action taken report on record “by the next date of hearing showing how further unauthorised construction is stopped and how the unauthorised construction is being demolished”.

“The Chief Minister clarified that no demolition will be carried out on existing structures in these colonies...,” the CMO said in a statement. Notably, the HC, while observing that DDA is the responsible agency, had also recorded that DDA will ensure that “no fresh construction takes place in Zone O, including in these colonies even under the garb of repair or renovation”.

Maintaining that the HC order specifically mandate the demolition of only new or ongoing constructions, the CMO referred to signboards erected across areas in O Zone, informing residents about restrictions on construction and discourage fresh encroachments. “...residents are apprehensive due to



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at the meeting on Tuesday. ANI

signage installed by the administration. However, public representatives, after studying court orders and government records, have concluded that existing structures in these colonies face no threat,” it added.

Speaking to mediapersons, Bidhuri, after the meeting with the CM, said that the 91 colonies had already been regularised on March 24, 2008, and at that time, they fell under the F Zone.

“However, on August 10, 2010, the Congress governments at the Centre and in Delhi placed these areas within the Yamuna O Zone. Following

public objections, the DDA issued a draft notification on September 28, 2013, proposing to shift these colonies back from the O Zone to the F Zone. The draft notification had received approval from then Union urban development minister, but the final notification has still not been issued,” he said.

He added that an expert committee had concluded that these villages and colonies do not adversely affect the river’s flow or ecological quality.

He further said that the DDA has put Delhi Secretariat, Akshardham, colonies developed

by its own department in Madanpur Khadar, among others, under O Zone. “So, the court on (April 18) said that no new construction can take place. So, if any new construction will take place, it will be demolished but the colonies and villages, which are developed decades ago, have been regularised in 2008. Even NGT disposed off a related case and directed the DDA to carry out proper demarcation,” said Bidhuri.

As of April 17, as informed by DDA to the court, it had undertaken the removal of illegal construction and encroachment in the villages of Madanpur Khadar and Jhangola as well as under revenue estate Indra-prastha, to reclaim around 7.03 acres. On April 18, the court had directed, “It is made clear that similar encroachment, removal and demolition programs shall continue to be carried out by the DDA in Zone O area.”

“DDA and MCD have been directed to ensure that no existing house in O Zone suffers any harm. Only new constructions would be subject to compliance with the court’s directions,” Tiwari said.

• Skywatch



Forecast: June 10, 2026

Partly cloudy sky, possibility of thundery developments

MAX: 43-45

5°C above normal

MIN: 29-31

3.4°C above normal

• *Sunrise: 5:23 AM (June 11)*

• *Sunset: 7:19 PM (June 10)*

• *Moonrise: 1:50 AM (June 11)*

• *Moonset: 2:09 PM (June 10)*

• AQI Tracker



Anand Vihar

Very Poor
AQI: 382



Bawana

Moderate
AQI: 176



IIT

Poor
AQI: 202



ITO

Moderate
AQI: 152

- Good (0-50)
- Satisfactory (51-100)
- Moderate (101-200)
- Poor (201-300)
- Very Poor (301-400)
- Severe (401-500)

• BRIEFLY



Water pots installed at Connaught Place in Delhi to provide commuters relief from heat, on Tuesday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

HEATWAVE ACTION PLAN

Expand mobile relief vans, cooling centres across Delhi, directs LG

DELHI LIEUTENANT Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday directed departments to expand mobile relief vans and cooling centres across Delhi, directing agencies to ensure swift public relief amid the heatwave. Sandhu headed a review meeting with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on the roll out of the heat wave action plan. The LG and the CM pointed out that since Delhi has a massive population, having just one mobile relief van per district may not be enough. They asked departments to increase the number of mobile relief vans and cooling centres, particularly in areas with large concentrations of street vendors, labourers, homeless persons and markets with heavy footfall. ENS

70% desilting work done: DDA

WITH MONSOON approaching, DDA on Tuesday said it has completed around 70% of the desilting work related to storm water drains. It added that LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed it to finish the remaining work by June 15, before the onset of the monsoon. According to the DDA, the desilting exercise is being carried out to improve the flow of rainwater and reduce the risk of waterlogging. ENS

10% incentive in travel allowance

THE DELHI government will offer 10% extra incentive in travel allowance to employees who use Common Mobility card for commuting on Metro and DTC buses. If any employee utilises at least 25% of monthly transport allowance, excluding DA, towards purchase or recharge of a Common Mobility card of DTC, they will be eligible for an incentive of 10% of admissible transport allowance, to be provided with salary. ENS

Mutation to be automatic with property registration in Haryana

Express News Service
Chandigarh, June 9

THE HARYANA government has decided to introduce an auto-mutation system that will automatically update land records whenever a property is registered, removing the need for citizens to submit a separate mutation application.

Until now, after purchasing or registering a property, one was required to apply separately to update ownership details in government land records.

With the introduction of the new system, this update will take place automatically at the time of registration, officials said.

Sumita Misra, Financial Commissioner Revenue and Disaster Management Department, said, “Under the new system, property registered in the state will automatically generate a corresponding mutation entry in the revenue records, removing the requirement for citizens to submit a separate application after registration.”

She added that the reform is expected to save time and effort for lakhs of property owners by eliminating an additional procedural step that often led to delays and repeated visits to revenue offices.

Officials said the Haryana government has already substantially revamped its land records administration, reducing pending mutation cases by more than 90% within six months.

Students’ rights at DPS Dwarka: NCPCR reopens inquiry after Delhi HC order

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 9

THE NATIONAL Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) has initiated a fresh inquiry into allegations concerning the rights of students at Delhi Public School (DPS), Dwarka, following directions from the Delhi High Court (HC) and has asked both the school management and a group of parents to submit detailed written statements by June 30.

In a notice issued on Tuesday, the Commission informed the school and a group of parents led by Divya Mathey that the inquiry is being conducted pursuant to the HC’s judgment dated April 16 in the case Delhi Public School Dwarka vs National Commission for Protection of Child Rights & Ors.

The court had set aside a communication issued by the NCPCR on July 18, 2024, holding that it had been issued without complying with the principles of natural justice. At the same time, the court granted liberty to the Commission to undertake a fresh inquiry.

The Commission noted that the HC had observed that the dispute stemmed from allegations relating to the rights of students.

“The veracity of the allegations made against the school or the justification of the conduct, cannot be gone into directly... unless the Commission hears all stakeholders and forms an opinion,” the court had observed.

ACCUSED PROMISED PERMANENT RESIDENCY OR WORK VISA

‘Posh office, accent’: How Delhi family lost Rs 1.8 crore chasing the Canadian dream

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 9

RICHA AND Prem Ahuja were a successful couple running a profitable business in Delhi. Around 2019, they began exploring the possibility of getting a Permanent Residency (PR) in Canada. Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Richa said, “I craved a fresh start. My daughter was born in 2019. I wanted to move away from the pollution and all.”

But then Covid-19 struck, and international travel came to a standstill. In 2021, as restrictions began easing, Richa and Prem arrived at GIES Immigration Inc in East Delhi’s Laxmi Nagar, where they met one Dharmendra Sharma.

“I asked him how long it would take. He said years. I asked what’s the shortest way to get in. He said PR,” said Richa.

Five years later, however, the couple is still in their Malviya Nagar apartment. They were allegedly conned of Rs 1.8 crore, after investing in a restaurant, in what police now describe as an elaborate fraud. On Richa’s complaint, Delhi Police registered an FIR and arrested Dharmendra in May.

Police said GIES Immigration, a Nysa Group offshoot, helps clients settle abroad through work visas or PR. Police said Dharmendra, listed on Nysa’s website as Director, Canada Immigration, told the Ahujas that a Canadian PR would take time.

As per the FIR, Richa was willing to wait. “Dharmendra said I needed to own a business in Canada to bolster my chances for a PR... I had already paid about 30,000 CAD (Canadian dollars) as service fees,” she said.

Police said Dharmendra and GIES’s Canada-based representative, Gaurav Verma, advised the couple to establish a

• THE SCAM

● Richa and Prem arrived at GIES Immigration Inc in East Delhi for a Permanent Residency (PR) in Canada. They met Dharmendra.

● Dharmendra told them they needed to own a business in Canada to bolster chances for a PR

● Dharmendra and GIES’s Canada-based representative, Gaurav Verma, advised the couple to establish a Canadian firm which would acquire a restaurant in Ontario.

● The restaurant was run by local businessman Dan Cuzak.

● Couple transferred money to an account in Canada.

● Couple was told they would get a work visa, not a PR

Canadian firm that would employ local residents, strengthening their immigration application. The Ahujas incorporated Aadya Hospitality, named after their daughter.

As per the FIR, the company was to acquire a restaurant, Gong’s Grill, on Brady Street in Sudbury, Ontario. The restaurant was owned by Cuzak Hospitality, run by local businessman, Dan Cuzak, the FIR stated.

“Dharmendra introduced me to Cuzak. We had multiple meetings on Zoom,” said Richa. “The restaurant seemed to be running at a loss. But my husband felt we could turn it around. We negotiated a deal,” she said.

As per the FIR, under the proposed arrangement, the Ahujas would pay 250,000 CAD (around Rs 1.73 crore) to acquire the restaurant. The money was deposited into an account in Canada. Cuzak was expected to reinvest 50% of it into Aadya Hospitality and become a partner in the venture.

“The documents relating to



Dharmendra Sharma was arrested last month.

- They faced repeated visa rejections
- They asked for refunds, but in vain
- Funds transferred were allegedly siphoned off, transfers routed through multiple accounts.

these transactions were overseen by a Canadian law firm, but were not shared with the Ahujas. An application was submitted to the Canadian embassy,” said a police officer.

“He (Dharmendra) had been assuring us of a PR. Then he said we would get a work visa. We were disheartened... but I said fine. At the start of 2022, he told us the visa would come in 10 days,” Richa said.

But it didn’t.

Dharmendra became difficult to reach, she claimed. According to the FIR, the couple’s application was rejected by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) on July 6, 2022.

Police said Gaurav allegedly told them there must have been a mix-up and filed a reconsideration request on July 12. That was also rejected.

The FIR states that another application was submitted on January 28, 2023, but it too was denied. Dejected, the Ahujas, on May 17 that year, sought a refund of 250,000 CAD invested

• FAMILY STAYED AT MALVIYA NAGAR B&B TO BE NEAR RADHE SHYAM AGGARWAL WHO WAS ADMITTED IN HOSPITAL

‘Died without knowing 8 of his own were killed in B&B fire’

Drishti Jain
New Delhi, June 9

DAYS AFTER eight members of his extended family died in a fire at a South Delhi Bed & Breakfast (B&B) establishment, Radhe Shyam Aggarwal passed away at Max Hospital in Saket around noon on Tuesday.

He did not know that his wife, son, daughter-in-law, two granddaughters, along with three members of his extended family had perished in the fire at Flourish Stays B&B on June 3.

Vijay Aggarwal (53), a relative, confirmed his passing. With nobody left in his immediate family, the last rites were conducted by Radhe

Shyam’s brother’s sons.

Radhe Shyam, in his 70s, had been suffering from a heart ailment and was on ventilator support for the past few days, a close relative said. He had been admitted to the hospital just three days before the deadly fire that claimed 22 lives, including 13 foreign nationals.

The family, including Radhe Shyam’s son Vivek, had travelled to Delhi and checked into Flourish Stays B&B after doctors informed them that his condition was critical.

“We did not tell him about the tragedy... He died without knowing that eight members of his family have been killed in the fire. Vivek was his only



Outside the family’s home in Gurgaon. FILE

child,” said a relative.

“Agar hum unko batate toh vo aur toot jaate (If we had told him, he would have been devastated).”

We wanted him to recover so that at least one member of the family remained with us. If he got better, he could

have decided what to do with the family’s properties and other resources... to donate to a trust or an NGO, whatever he felt was right,” the relative added.

“Their house in Gurgaon is completely empty now,” the relative said, adding that the family was scheduled to travel to Ahmedabad for a wedding next month.

“We were all happy. Now everything is gone.”

Last week, Vivek had rented rooms at Flourish Stays B&B in Hauz Rani, located just minutes from the Max Hospital Saket. He was staying there with his mother Premmata, wife Tarjani and their two daughters, Jivisha and Varya.

Also staying at the hotel were Vivek’s maternal uncle Ashok Goyal from Kishangarh, and his mother’s sister Kamla and her husband Jimri, who had also come to Delhi to be near Radhe Shyam.

The family had chosen the hotel because of its proximity to the hospital. “They wanted to be near Radhe Shyam...,” Prem Bansal, Tarjani’s father, had said earlier.

The family, the close ones remember, had always been warm in hosting. “Even when a child is coming from Kishangarh to study, they always find a home in Gurgaon. There is a vacuum created now,” said a relative.

ONE STATION FOR 4.6 LAKH RESIDENTS: DISASTER AUTHORITY DOCUMENT

‘71 fire stations in Capital for over 3.3 crore people’

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 9

FACED WITH challenges of high population density and congested colonies, Delhi’s fire-fighting infrastructure remains stretched, with only 71 fire stations serving a population of over 3.3 crore, or roughly one station for 4.6 lakh residents.

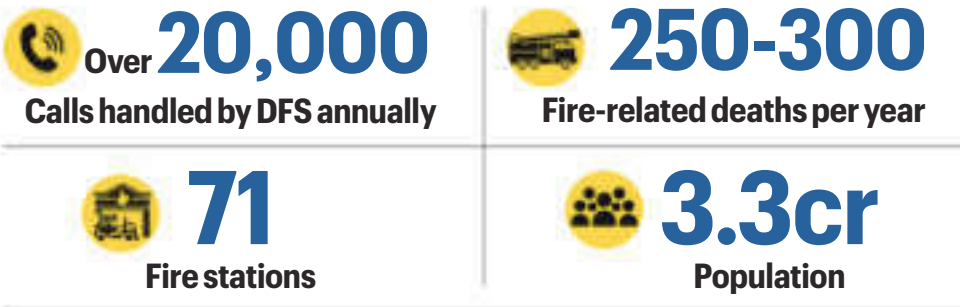
These 71 fire stations also face severe staff crunch. According to an internal Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) document, an additional 9,123 personnel are required immediately to fully operationalise all the 71 fire stations.

In a DDMA meeting held on Monday – chaired by Lieutenant Governor (LG) Taranjit Singh Sandhu – key issues flagged were electrical overloading, illegal storage of inflammable materials and violations of fire safety norms resulting in major blazes, as well as delayed access to the site of fire allowing flames to spread before rescue teams can reach the spot.

The meeting was held to review the working of the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), its manpower and fire infrastructure required to tackle blazes, following the Malviya Nagar B&B fire that claimed 22 lives. It was also attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta as well as other ministers and officials.

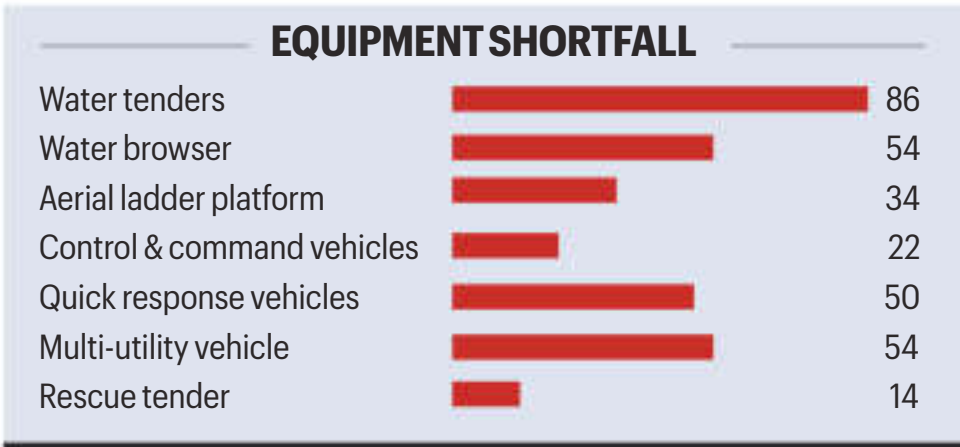
“Delhi’s density (11,320/km²) makes fire spread

• Delhi’s fire-fighting infra



CAUSES OF FIRE: High density, narrow lanes, unauthorised colonies, violations, illegal inflammable storage, electrical overloading
FIREFIGHTING EQUIPMENT: 78%

of 334-unit fleet operational.
VEHICLES: 89 await repair, 15 condemned, due for replacement
KEY GAP: 4 of 38 aerial ladder platforms available



extreme in unauthorised colonies; response often exceeds the critical 4-minute window; rule violations, illegal inflammable storage and electrical overloading remain leading causes,” read the internal DDMA document presented at the meeting.

According to the document, DFS handles over 20,000 fire-related calls annually while Delhi records 250 to 300 deaths due to fire every year.

Further, as per the docu-

ment, the Fire department is operating with significant equipment shortages, including an 89% deficit in aerial ladder platforms used for rescuing people and combating fires in high-rise buildings.

According to official data, DFS has only four aerial ladder platforms against a requirement of 38. There is also a shortfall of 86 water tenders and 54 water browsers and 57 multi-utility vehicles and 22 control-and-command vehicles.

“Only 78% of the 334-unit fleet (260) are operational, while 89 vehicles await repair and 15 are condemned and due for replacement, straining day-to-day deployment,” the internal document read.

The DFS also faces a severe manpower crunch. According to official data, of the total 3,363 sanctioned posts in the DFS, 74% of operational staff posts are vacant. Further, 20% posts of station officers, 86% posts of leading firemen and 18% posts of workshop staff are vacant.

To address the huge manpower shortage, the LG suggested at the meeting that vacant posts be filled with former Agniveers.

During the meeting, DFS and Home department officials informed the LG and the CM about the steps being taken to address critical operational gaps and strengthen DFS. These include upgrading communication systems, digitising service delivery through a single-window platform, restructuring the cadre, augmenting firefighting equipment and vehicles, improving coordination with the police, and expanding firefighting training to Home Guards, said officials.

“These initiatives aim to enhance preparedness, improve resource management and ensure swifter and more effective responses to fire and emergency incidents in the future,” said an official.

Man who crashed through Assembly gate in SUV hid in Speaker’s car before fleeing: Police

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 9

WEEKS AFTER a 37-year-old man forced his way through the VIP entrance to the Delhi Assembly complex in an SUV, police said that the accused hid in the Speaker’s official vehicle before fleeing the spot in his own car.

Delhi Police filed a charge-sheet in the case last week.

Police said that when accused Sarabjeet Singh — who is currently in jail — reached the Assembly, he found Gate No. 2 closed and security personnel stationed there. He allegedly crashed through the boom barrier at the gate, drove his Tata Sierra car to the porch area, got off and put down a bouquet of red flowers.

When security officials H C Jai Prakash (CRPF) and ASI Raj Kumar (Security) tried to stop



The accused allegedly crashed through the boom barrier at Gate No. 2 of the Delhi Assembly in April. FILE

him, he allegedly attempted to run them over with his vehicle, police said. They said that he hid in the Speaker’s vehicle, got back into his own car shortly after and sped away.

Police said investigation revealed that the accused’s nephew, Harman, had gone missing from New Delhi on April 1. Extensive efforts to lo-

cate him went in vain.

Police also stated that Singh held the administration responsible for his nephew’s disappearance, and also believed that proper action was not taken.

Police said that the investigation revealed that he wanted to draw the attention of the government so that serious ef-

forts are made to find his missing nephew.

He travelled to Delhi from Punjab on April 6, the day of the incident, in his car, police said, adding that he bought the bouquet near Panipat that he intended to present to a senior official in the Assembly while expressing his anguish.

The chargesheet, police said, is based on 44 witnesses, CCTV footage, witness statements, and medical reports.

Following the security breach in the Assembly, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta had chaired a high-level meeting.

Measures, including enhanced coordination and real-time information sharing among agencies, a dedicated mobile patrol vehicle for rapid response, and strengthening access-control infrastructure to prevent forcible entry attempts, were proposed.

Twisha case: Claims of ‘VIP treatment’ for ex-judge in prison, deputy jailer transferred

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 9

FRESH QUESTIONS have emerged over the treatment extended to retired district judge Giribala Singh inside Bhopal Central Jail, with prison authorities transferring a deputy jailer after allegations that the two accused in the Twisha Sharma death case — Giribala Singh and her son Samarth Singh — were provided preferential facilities in violation of prison rules.

Bhopal Jail Superintendent Rakesh Bhangre told The Indian Express that Giribala Singh was not provided any preferential treatment and that the concerned officer was shifted to the administrative department.

“There was no preferential treatment given to the inmate. Giribala Singh is housed in a ward that is usually reserved for sick or pregnant inmates, but this is not a medical ward. Since allegations were being raised of VIP treatment, I shifted the concerned jailer. The jail authority was only following the court directions, which stipu-



Twisha’s mother-in-law Giribala

lated that Giribala be housed in a separate ward,” he said.

The development has cast renewed attention on the incarceration of Giribala Singh and her son, who were sent to 14 days’ judicial custody after the CBI completed its custodial questioning and chose not to seek a further remand.

Soon after entering prison, Giribala Singh was accommodated in the women’s medical wing, while Samarth Singh was admitted to the jail’s medical ward, citing a leg injury.

Their prison stint had drawn scrutiny from the start after reports emerged that Giribala had sought permission to enter the prison premises by vehicle and was being

housed separately from ordinary inmates.

According to officials, however, Giribala Singh is now subject to the same daily schedule governing all inmates inside the central jail. She has been issued standard prison utensils, bedding and clothing allowances available under jail rules, officials said.

They said Giribala Singh starts her day with morning prayers and has remained “composed during interactions with jail officials”.

According to prison officials, Giribala Singh has so far followed the standard daily routine prescribed for inmates. She wakes up with the morning roll call and is served tea around 6 am, followed by breakfast at 7 am. On her first full day in jail, she ate the same breakfast provided to other in-

mates — “salted dalia (porridge) and tea”. Lunch is served between 11 am and noon, followed by evening tea at 3 pm and dinner at around 6 pm. On the evening she entered jail, officials said she was “served kadhi, pakoras and rotis”.

An official said, “Giribala Singh also has canteen facilities available, and eats toast, fruits and namkeen. She has also asked for permission to read newspapers in jail, and this has been granted.”

Twisha Sharma, who was an actor and model, married Samarth Singh on December 9, 2025. She died less than six months later, and the case has garnered widespread public attention.

The investigation was eventually transferred to the CBI following allegations of a shoddy probe by Bhopal police.

NEET UG leak accused seeks interim bail for retest

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, June 9

AFTER HE sought permission to get books in judicial custody so he could study for the NEET retest scheduled on June 21, Yash Yadav, an accused in the NEET UG paper leak case, has now moved a Delhi court seeking interim bail to appear for the examination.

The court had earlier granted him permission to get books in judicial custody.

Yash, from Gurgaon, is a 20-year-old student at Uttarakhand

Ayurveda University and a NEET aspirant who appeared in the now-cancelled May 3 exam.

Seeking 15-day interim bail, he cited the retest as well as his sister’s wedding. The court of Special Judge Ajay Gupta has asked the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to file a reply in the matter. The matter will now be heard on June 12.

According to the CBI, which is investigating the case, Yash allegedly received PDF files of leaked question papers through Telegram and sold them for Rs 10 lakh. The agency

claimed he was instrumental in distributing the “leaked” paper.

The CBI said a “guess paper” of 150 pages with 410 questions was circulated to some aspirants. Of those 410 questions, about 120 questions appeared in the chemistry paper of the exam. The “guess paper” was with students weeks before the examination, the agency has claimed.

Till date, the agency has made 13 arrests in the case including various teachers and students from Delhi, Jaipur, Gurgaon, Nashik, Pune, Latur and Ahilyanagar.

The CBI has claimed that National Testing Agency (NTA) sources were behind the leak. P V Kulkarni, a retired chemistry teacher who was “associated with NTA” was earlier arrested by the agency from Pune.

The NTA is an agency under the Union Ministry of Education that administers the NEET for admission to UG medical colleges every year.

More than 22.7 lakh aspirants appeared for this year’s exam on May 3. The NTA announced the leak and cancelled the exam on May 12.

Saidulajab collapse case: 2 builders held

New Delhi: Two persons, allegedly involved in the construction of the building in Saidulajab that collapsed on May 30, killing six persons, were arrested on Tuesday.

Police identified them as Manish Khatri and Avinash Gupta, who were allegedly awarded the contract to construct two additional illegal floors around three months ago.

The two men were arrested from Southwest Delhi’s Vasant Kunj. Earlier, the owner of the building, Karambir Sejwal, had been arrested in connection with the case.

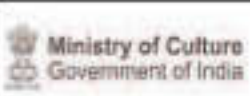
According to sources in the police, Khatri is the relative of Sejwal — who was arrested from his farmhouse in Green Avenue in Vasant Kunj on Monday — and has allegedly been involved in several illegal construction projects in Saidulajab

and nearby areas.

Police said the probe so far has found that the building had been constructed eight years ago and that its basement was not structurally capable of bearing the additional load of two more floors. “One extra floor had already been constructed, while work on another was underway. However, construction had reportedly been halted for several days due to a payment dispute when the building collapsed,” said a source.

A few days before the building collapsed, excavation work was carried out in its basement to install a water tank. The police suspect that this may have further weakened the structure.

The deceased included five medical and engineering graduates and a woman who ran a makeshift eatery next to the building. ENS



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Teen Murti House, New Delhi

All are Welcome.

Those wishing to have their names added to the email list may please email us at:-
rajnishpmml@gmail.com

CBC- 09142/11/0015/2627



Kendriya Vidyalaya Lohaghat

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E-Mail:- lothagatkv@gmail.com
CBSE School Code-84079, CBSE Affiliation Code-3500039

NOTICE

Applications are invited for admission to Kendriya Vidyalaya Lohaghat for the Academic Session 2026-27 against the few vacant seats available in the following classes:
Class I - Few vacancies available exclusively for Scheduled Tribe (ST) category students.
Classes II and VIII - Few vacancies are available.
Parents of interested and eligible students may obtain the registration form from the vidyalay and submit the duly filled form as per the Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan Admission Guidelines 2026-27. Registration forms will be available from 10 June 2026 to 15 June 2026 on all working days between 11:30 AM and 02:00 PM.
The completed registration form must be submitted to the vidyalaya office by 15 June 2026 (up to 02:30 PM).
Sd/-
पञ्जाक- फा 1928/केरिओ लोहाघाट/2026-27
दिनांक 09.06.2026
Principal
Kendriya Vidyalaya Lohaghat

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A copy of the said Environmental Clearance Letter is available on the website of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change at <https://parivesh.nic.in/>.

Date: 10-06-2026
Place: Gurugram, Haryana



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Punch Line

AS CBSE and NTA find themselves in a soup over flawed marking and paper leak allegations, Congress MP and communication in-charge Jairam Ramesh has chosen the humour route to flag the twin controversies before the media. When journalists send him text messages or make a call to seek specifics of party meetings and other related issues, he diverts the query saying he is not “associated with CBSE or NTA”. The leader cracked the same joke on Monday when mediapersons inquired about the INDIA bloc meeting in Delhi. “I am neither NTA nor CBSE,” said the leader, leaving many in splits.

Setting a Record

WITH NARENDRA Modi set to become the country’s longest-serving elected Prime Minister on Wednesday, surpassing the record of 4,398 uninterrupted days held by Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, the BJP has planned special events across the country to commemorate the milestone. Over 70 leaders of the NDA have been invited to a gathering at Bharat Mandapam, where they are expected to pass a resolution congratulating PM Modi on the achievement. The BJP has also planned special puja ceremonies at the Char Dham shrines of Gangotri, Yamunotri, Badrinath and Kedarnath, besides temples and ghats along the Ganga in Uttarakhand. Sources said prayers will also be offered at dargahs in different parts of the country. Last year, PM Modi overtook Indira Gandhi’s record to become the second-longest-serving PM in consecutive terms.

All’s Bhel

AFTER JHAL-MURI made its political debut during recently held West Bengal Assembly elections, “bhel puri” has become the latest snack to enter political conversations in the Capital. As INDIA bloc allies assembled in Delhi on Monday, Shiv Sena (UBT) leaders Uddhav Thackeray and Sanjay Raut joined the meeting virtually as they were busy with a family function in Maharashtra. During the discussions, Raut was spotted munching on something, which many thought was Mumbai’s popular snack — bhel-puri. A TMC leader jokingly remarked that the Sena (UBT) leader was enjoying bhel-puri alone. Raut didn’t say much during the meeting, but later texted the TMC leader that he was not having bhel-puri, but another famous Maharashtra snack — poha.

Santosh Singh
Patna, June 9

BJP ALLY and Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) chief Upendra Kushwaha’s son Deepak Prakash is set to lose his position as Bihar minister after the NDA did not nominate him for the MLC elections on June 18. This came at a time when Kushwaha, a Rajya Sabha MP, has made it clear that he will not merge his party with the BJP.

Of the 10 vacant MLC posts, the NDA is set to win nine, given that it has 202 MLAs in the 243-strong Assembly. There are 75 seats in the Legislative Council. While the JD(U) and the BJP have announced candidates for

CID searches offices of Abhishek, TMC in ‘signature forgery’ case

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, June 9

THE WEST Bengal CID on Tuesday conducted searches at the Trinamool Congress’s central party office in Kolkata’s Kalighat and at the office of TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Camac Street as part of its investigation into an alleged signature forgery case.

The searches came on a day when Abhishek Banerjee skipped a third summons issued by the Crime Investigation Department (CID), citing pending proceedings before the Calcutta High Court and his absence from the city. Investigators are probing allegations that signatures of several TMC MLAs were forged on a letter sent to Assembly Speaker Biman Banerjee regarding the appointment of the Leader of Opposition.

A CID team, accompanied by personnel from the Kalighat Police Station and central forces, reached the TMC office at 30B Harish Chatterjee Street in the afternoon. The premises is located adjacent to the residence of former chief minister and TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee.

According to sources, CID officers were initially prevented from entering the premises and had to wait outside for nearly an hour. TMC treasurer and former MP Subhasish Chakraborty told the officers that both Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee were in New Delhi and that he could not permit entry without their authorisation. The officers, however, told Chakraborty that he did not have the authority to prevent them from entering.

The team eventually entered the premises shortly after 4 pm. The entire process was video-graphed, and officers were searched before entering the building, sources said.

The searches were concluded by 6.15 pm.

The CID also searched Abhishek Banerjee’s office on Camac Street. According to sources, officers faced initial resistance there as well before being allowed to enter and carry out the search.

TMC leader and Rajya Sabha MP Derek O’Brien slammed the CID action, saying a post on X: “Political vendetta shamelessly timed! Exactly at the same time as AITC (All India Trinamool Congress) chairperson Mamata Banerjee was having a meeting today in Delhi with Mrs Sonia Gandhi, CID was forcefully trying to enter the AITC party HQ adjoining residence in Kolkata. First loot vote, now loot files of a political rival. Democracy?”

The case stems from a complaint filed by rebel TMC MLAs Ritabrata Banerjee and Sandipan Saha, who alleged that a resolution nominating Sovandeb Chattopadhyay as Leader of Opposition in the West Bengal Assembly, purportedly adopted on May 6, was fabricated and that signatures of several legislators on the document were forged.

Following a preliminary inquiry by the Assembly Secretariat, an FIR was registered at Hare Street Police Station, and the investigation was subsequently handed over to the CID. The CID has so far recorded statements from 13 TMC MLAs. Three of them, Baharul Islam, Arup Roy, and Subhasis Das, have reportedly disowned the signatures attributed to them on the document.

It has constituted a special investigation team (SIT) headed by a DIG-rank officer to probe the allegations.

In the midst of the controversy, the Speaker last week appointed Ritabrata Banerjee as the Leader of Opposition. The TMC, however, moved the Calcutta High Court on Monday, challenging the Speaker’s decision.

Meanwhile, sources said the CID had issued a summons to Abhishek Banerjee, asking him to appear before the agency on Tuesday. However, he wrote to the CID seeking more time, stating that the matter is pending before the Calcutta High Court and is scheduled to be heard on June 10. He also informed investigators that he was in New Delhi for political engagements.

He has challenged the CID summons before the Calcutta High Court.



A CID team during one of the searches in Kolkata on Tuesday. ANI

Amid scrutiny and rebellion, Mamata meets Sonia in Delhi

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, June 9

AS THE West Bengal CID Tuesday conducted searches at the Trinamool Congress’s central party office in Kolkata’s Kalighat and at the office of its national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Camac Street as part of its investigation into the alleged Assembly signature forgery case, party chief Mamata Banerjee met Congress Parliamentary chairperson Sonia Gandhi at the latter’s residence in Delhi.

Sources in the TMC said Mamata’s meeting was to discuss coordination among the INDIA bloc parties. The meeting at Sonia’s 10, Janpath, residence in Delhi lasted an hour.

“The meeting was about the INDIA bloc working together in unity,” said a senior party MP.

“Sonija ji and our leader (Mamata) have a strong personal relationship that goes back decades. If they meet, it is natural. If Didi is in Delhi, she will meet allies and Sonija ji is the senior-most among Opposition leaders so she met her,” said another senior party MP, considered close to Mamata.

In a statement, TMC leader in the Rajya Sabha Derek O’Brien said: “Political vendetta shamelessly timed! Exactly at the same time as TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee was having a meeting today in Delhi with Mrs Sonia Gandhi, CID was forcefully trying to enter the AITC party headquarters adjoining residence in Kolkata. First loot vote, now loot files of a political rival. Democracy? Main entrance overloaded with CRPF.”

Earlier in the day, the TMC said that it was not worried by the exits of its leaders and that while the BJP may have power and government, it has “*Maa, Maati and Maanush*” (mother, soil, people) by its side.

The Mamata Banerjee-led party is facing a major crisis. A rebel group, led by senior Trinamool leader Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, wrote to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday, saying they want to join the NDA. This group claims it has the support of 20 Lok Sabha MPs, a claim the party leadership has contested, saying the rebels were 12 in number. This comes days after 60 of the

party’s 80 MLAs rebelled and challenged Mamata Banerjee’s choice of Sovandeb Chattopadhyay as their leader in the Assembly.

At a press conference in Delhi on Tuesday, Trinamool MP Kalyan Banerjee, who was accompanied by party colleague Kirti Azad, said, “We are not worried about who leaves. We need fresh blood, committed workers and leaders who stand by the party during difficult times. Our leader is Mamata Banerjee. Our symbol is the Trinamool Congress symbol. Our strength comes from our workers and the people of Bengal. You may have power, money, government machinery, agencies, vehicles, security and property. We have Maa, Maati and Maanush.”

Kalyan Banerjee said the rebel MPs who went to Bhupender Yadav’s residence on Monday and held meetings with Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari have effectively become BJP. “Today, their leader is Narendra Modi. They may use different words, but the people of Bengal understand exactly what is happening,” he said.

Natarajan: Rahul loyalist at centre of RS poll row in Madhya Pradesh

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, June 9

AT THE centre of a brewing political storm after her candidature to the Rajya Sabha was rejected on Tuesday, Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan is a known Rahul Gandhi associate both praised for her simplicity by her colleagues and is a divisive figure in party circles.

Born in Ratlam district, the 52-year-old first made a mark in the Congress by serving as the president of NSUI from 1999 to 2002 and the state Youth Congress president for the following three years. Her rise through the party ranks continued as Rahul Gandhi brought her into his core team of young leaders in 2008 after being appointed AICC general secretary the year before. The others who were part of that group include Praveen Chakravarty, who is set to enter the Rajya Sabha after winning the seat in Tamil Nadu.

Natarajan was appointed an



Meenakshi Natarajan in Bhopal on Tuesday. PTI

AICC secretary in 2008 and the following year, Gandhi hand-picked her to contest the Lok Sabha election from Mandasaur. Natarajan defeated BJP veteran Laxminarayan Pandey. Five years later, the story was different as a Narendra Modi wave swept away the Congress across the country. Natarajan lost by a massive 3.03 lakh votes. She at-

ASSEMBLY ELECTIONS IN MIND



BJP chief Nitin Nabin inaugurates an exhibition of achievements of the Modi government, in New Delhi on Tuesday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Nabin set to rejig his team as BJP banks on Opp flux to see key Bills sail through LS

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, June 9

BJP PRESIDENT Nitin Nabin is expected to reconstitute his team in the second half of June for the next year’s crucial Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat and Karnataka, among others. Besides the national office-bearers, Nabin is likely to reconstitute the parliamentary board, the apex decision-making body of the party. “It will be a mix of fresh and young faces and experienced,” said a source.

Nabin took over as the national president in January but couldn’t reconstitute his team due to Assembly elections. There is also speculation about a Cabinet reshuffle as the government has completed two years.

Sources said the government is set to take up some Bills again in the Monsoon Session. Top in the list of priorities for the government would be the Demarcation Bill, which could not get cleared in the Lok Sabha as the NDA government lacked the two-thirds majority required for a constitutional amendment.

The government started its efforts to get the required support for the Bills immediately after the April-May Assembly election results were announced, sources added. Following the elections which dealt a severe jolt to the TMC and

DMK in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, respectively, the government has reached out to both the parties.

The Indian Express on June 1 reported that efforts were on within the government to revive the legislation and also bring in ‘One Nation One Election’ Bill before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections. Sources said, BJP leaders have been in talks with the DMK leadership and former CM M K Stalin apparently asked the government to redraft the Bill to make it acceptable to the southern region, and the revolt in the TMC has given hope to the ruling coalition. The DMK, according to sources, is ready to extend an issue-based support to the BJP-led government at the Centre, it is learnt.

“If we get the majority, we will immediately bring the Bill to get it cleared,” said a top leader.

Some TMC MPs reached out to the BJP in the national capital on Monday and the new group is learnt to have expressed its willingness to extend support to the NDA government for the crucial legislation. As the TMC has 28 members in the Lok Sabha, the rebel faction should have at least 20 MPs from the Mamata Banerjee-led parent party for recognition as a separate bloc and avoid disqualification.

People paying price for Modi’s crumbling economy: Rahul

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 9

AS THE Modi government completes 12 years at the Centre, Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday asked if “workers, farmers, women, and middle class will only pay the price for this crumbling economy built by” Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Rahul said that 12 years of “anti-poor economic policies” and a “compromised foreign policy” have today pushed the country into such a dire situation where millions of poor families and women have been forced towards the poisonous smoke of firewood stoves.

“The number of subsidised cylinders under the Ujjwala scheme has been reduced from 9 to 4. On top of that, the price of domestic LPG cylinders has been increased by ₹89 in the last three months — meaning, first hike the prices, then cut the subsidy, and snuff out the poor’s hearth. The lifeline of migrant workers, the 5 kg cylinder, has also been made ₹323 more expensive — what will they earn, what will they eat, and what will they save?” said Rahul. He alleged that “arranging debt waivers worth millions of crores for billionaire friends and passing the bill of your failures onto the poor is Modi’s loot model”. “Mr Modi, will only the poor bear the burden of your failures? Will only the workers, farmers, women, and middle class pay the price for this crumbling economy you’ve built?” he said.

The Congress on Tuesday also released a “promise versus reality” document and said that over the last 12 years, promises have been accompanied by big announcements, grand statements and headlines but in reality none of that translated into transforming people’s lives.

Kushwaha resists BJP merger push as son is set to lose ministership

Santosh Singh
Patna, June 9

BJP ALLY and Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) chief Upendra Kushwaha’s son Deepak Prakash is set to lose his position as Bihar minister after the NDA did not nominate him for the MLC elections on June 18. This came at a time when Kushwaha, a Rajya Sabha MP, has made it clear that he will not merge his party with the BJP.

Of the 10 vacant MLC posts, the NDA is set to win nine, given that it has 202 MLAs in the 243-strong Assembly. There are 75 seats in the Legislative Council. While the JD(U) and the BJP have announced candidates for

four seats each, the other berth has gone to the Chirag Paswan-led Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas). The other seat will go to the RJD’s Sunil Kumar Singh, whose term was set to expire in this cycle. With neither the ruling alliance nor the Opposition fielding any extra candidates, no elections will be required.

Asked how he felt that he was now set to lose his ministership, Prakash told The Indian Express, “I was reinducted into the Cabinet only due to the blessings of the NDA leadership. I was made minister as per provisions of the Constitution. I will continue to be a minister as long as I enjoy the NDA leadership’s blessings. I won’t talk about (not getting)

the MLC berth.”

BJP sources claimed that Kushwaha had been renominated to the Rajya Sabha earlier this year after he assured he would merge the RLM with the BJP. “BJP’s central leadership had reminded Kushwaha about the merger while considering the reinduction of Kushwaha’s son Deepak Prakash as minister in CM Samrat Choudhary’s Cabinet,” said a BJP insider.

Toughening his stance, Kushwaha told The Indian Express that he cannot merge his party with the BJP “for one position”.

“The RLM has been a separate political entity and will continue to remain so. But let me re-



The RLM has been a separate political entity, will continue to remain so, says Kushwaha. ANI

iterate that we are very much part of the NDA. I am still hopeful of getting an MLC berth for Deepak,” he said. The former

Union Minister had said similar things at an RLM meeting on Sunday.

Kushwaha’s decision to get Prakash inducted as a minister in the Nitish Kumar government ran into problems from his own party last December after three of its four MLAs accused him of “blatantly promoting” his family despite once being a staunch opponent of dynasty politics. They pointed out that while the party chief was in the Rajya Sabha, his wife Snehlata Kushwaha is the fourth MLA of the party, and his son had been made a minister despite not holding a position in the Legislative Council or being elected to the Assembly. A month before that, seven RLM

leaders, including some senior functionaries, had quit the party in protest against the decision to make Prakash the minister.

The BJP source also said that the three MLAs — Alok Kumar Singh (Dinara), Rameshwar Mahto (Bajpatti), and Madhav Anand (Madhubani) — were in touch with the party.

Considered a pan-Bihar Kushwaha (OBC Koeri) leader, Upendra Kushwaha has been increasingly marginalised in the NDA after the BJP elevated fellow Kushwaha leader Samrat Choudhary as CM. Kushwaha was a protégé of JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar but fell out with the former CM over his ambition to carve a niche for himself. In the

Strategic 13-km Zojila tunnel connecting Kashmir & Ladakh achieves breakthrough

Sabah Virani
Sonmarg, June 9

A FINAL 2.5-metre of rock inside the strategically significant Zojila Tunnel was blasted away on Tuesday, marking a major breakthrough in the construction of the 13.153-km tunnel on the National Highway-01 (NH-01) that will provide all-weather road connectivity between Sonamarg (J&K) and Meenamarg (Ladakh).

Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari performed the breakthrough blasting of the main tunnel being constructed at an altitude of 11,578 feet above sea level, around 24 km from Sonamarg and 103 km from Srinagar. Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah were also present on the occasion. A breakthrough is the point or moment when a tunnel being excavated from both ends finally connects, marking the completion of a critical work. Officials of the National Highways & Infrastructure Development Corporation Limited (NHIDCL) said the breakthrough is six months ahead of schedule.

The Zojila Tunnel is set to become the world's longest bi-directional single-tube road tunnel at such a height. The tunnel forms the centerpiece of the 30.894-km Zojila project, which includes roads, bridges and tunnels aimed at ensuring year-



Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, J&K L-G Manoj Sinha and CM Omar Abdullah at Meenamarg on Tuesday. PTI

round access to Ladakh. The 13-km tunnel, one of the most difficult road projects undertaken in India, is scheduled to be completed by February 2028. This is part of a 33-km project undertaken by NHIDCL, where apart from this tunnel, a road from Z-Morh tunnel to the Zojila tunnel is being built. The cost of both projects is around Rs 7,000 crore.

After the tunnel breakthrough, Gadkari said the project will prove to be a lifeline for Ladakh. "This tunnel is situated at almost 3,000 metres above (from the sea level). Workers, engineers, contractors, NHIDCL team have worked at this place at -4 degree Celsius or below

temperature. 80% of the workers here were from this area. For about six months, there is no connectivity in the region. But with this tunnel, connectivity of Srinagar, Ganderbal, Sonamarg, Dras, Kargil, Ladakh will get a new boost," he said.

The project is expected to transform connectivity for residents, tourists and security forces travelling between Kashmir and Ladakh. Travel time will drop from over 2 hours to 15 minutes. Despite the breakthrough, significant work remains before the tunnel can be opened. Officials said overall physical progress stands at 68.55%, with around 4 km of

final lining yet to be completed, along with emergency tunnel infrastructure and associated road works.

The tunnel is expected to be ready for military use by December 2026. While the official target for opening it to civilian traffic is February 2028, Gadkari suggested efforts are underway to advance the timeline.

Calling the breakthrough a long-awaited milestone, Omar said improved connectivity would boost transport, tourism and economic opportunities across Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, and expressed hope that the remaining work would be completed swiftly.

'50-year demand' nears fulfilment — Ladakh closer to all-weather connectivity

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, June 9

LEADERS IN Ladakh expressed joy as engineers on Tuesday achieved a breakthrough in the Zojila tunnel, linking Ladakh with Kashmir through an all-weather route. The project has long been seen as critical to ending the region's seasonal isolation.

Ladakh MP Hanifa Jan described the breakthrough as the fulfilment of a dream that generations of Ladakhis had nurtured for decades. "People are extremely happy with this achievement," Jan said. "For at least the last 50 years, Ladakh's leadership has consistently demanded this tunnel to improve connectivity to the region."

Thanking Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari, who was present at the breakthrough ceremony, Jan said the tunnel holds immense strategic as well as civilian importance. "Though there were initial hurdles, the tunnel has finally become a reality. I think the government realised the need for this tunnel during the [Kargil] war in 1999."

Until now, the pass has re-

mained Ladakh's primary road link with the Kashmir Valley. Every winter, heavy snowfall and temperatures plunging to around -30°C cut off road connectivity for months. With Leh's airport serving as the region's only civilian air link, airfares often rise sharply during the winter, placing travel beyond the reach of many residents.

In Kargil, the first major town beyond the tunnel, religious and social organisation Jamiat Ul Ulama Isna Asharia Kargil hailed the breakthrough as a historic milestone. Its general secretary, Sheikh Ibrahim Khalili, and political affairs in-charge Sajjad Kargili said the Zojila tunnel had been among the most longstanding demands of the people of Kargil and Drass. They said local communities, activists, political leaders and civil society groups had campaigned for decades to secure year-round connectivity for the region.

Kargili noted that the residents have long pursued three major infrastructure aspirations: air services to the city and the construction of the tunnel, among others. He said that with the breakthrough of the tunnel, "one of these historic demands is now on the path to realisation".



Firefighters, police at the site in Jaipur on Tuesday. ROHIT JAIN PARAS

In Jaipur, 8 killed in fire at 'illegal' factory

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, June 9

A MASSIVE fire broke out at a firecracker factory in Jaipur's Kho Nagoriyan area around 11 am Tuesday, killing eight persons, including a teenager, and leaving many others critically injured with severe burn injuries.

The deceased have been identified as Mohammad Ashraf (40), Mohammad Rabbil (16), Abdul Wahid (46), Sameer Khan (20), Bilal (28), Azim (18), Nasir Khan (25), and an unidentified person. Nasir succumbed to his injuries during treatment at SMS Hospital. The injured were discharged after undergoing treatment at Sawai Man Singh (SMS) Hospital, officials said.

"Six persons were brought to the hospital, of whom one person was declared dead on arrival and another died shortly after being admitted to the hospital..." said Pradeep Sharma, Assistant Superintendent of SMS Hospital. Dr R K Jain, a plastic surgeon at SMS Hospital, said two of the patients sustained nearly 95% burns, while another suffered 75% burns — and "it is

difficult to save such patients".

Jaipur Collector Sandesh Nayak said that the firecracker unit operated near ITI College in Ayesha Nagar Talai area, Kho Nagorian. Preliminary findings suggest that highly combustible material stored inside the unit may have triggered the blaze. "It appears the factory was functioning illegally without the required permissions. The matter is being investigated," Nayak told *The Indian Express*.

Local MLA Amin Kagzi questioned how the unit was operating without the knowledge of the authorities. Also raising concerns about the factory's ownership, he said, "Even if the deceased were not from Rajasthan, their lives were equally valuable. The failure lies with the authorities."

Police officers and forensic teams also inspected the site to ascertain the cause of the fire. Jaipur Police Commissioner Sachin Mittal and DCP (East) Ranjeet Sharma said that "action will be taken against defaulters, including police officers, who let the factory operate, as well as the owner of the factory".

Time stands still on the ground, survivors remember their miraculous escape

Brendan Dabhi
Ahmedabad, June 9

NARESH KARSAN Patel believes Vishwas Kumar Ramesh cheating death when the Air India flight AI 171 crashed wasn't the only "miracle" that happened on June 12, 2025.

Patel, who is approaching his 60s, and his wife Daksha were on the ground floor of the mess building of B J Medical College that was struck by the Boeing Dreamliner as it came down. Both escaped, Daksha doing so with spinal injuries.

For nearly 16 years, it is from this mess that Patel has been delivering tiffins to doctors and students at Ahmedabad Civil Hospital attached to the college. "I had just returned from making a delivery to the mess, where Daksha and other women were making and serving lunch. Suddenly there was a huge explosion and dust everywhere. I saw something big stuck in the wall and liquid (fuel) spreading." Then, everyone started screaming and trying to escape from the building.

In Gujarat's worst air disaster since 1988, 260 people lost their lives, including 241 passengers and crew aboard the airliner, and 19 people on the ground, when the plane bound for London Gatwick airport crashed within minutes of take-off from Ahmedabad. Kumar was the sole survivor on board.

After the aircraft hit the mess building, its tail end got embedded in the structure, even as the rest of the plane struck four hostel blocks beyond it.

A year later, little has changed on the spot, including the gaping hole in the mess wall



BJ Medical College's hostel buildings that were impacted by the plane crash in Ahmedabad on June 12 last year. BHUPENDRA RANA

where the plane came in, and an overhead tank bent at an unnatural angle due to the impact. Inside, with the concrete falling off, construction rods stand exposed and bent out of shape, electrical wires hang bare, and swarms of pigeons — the scourge of empty places — have settled in. The mess has come up in a row of hostel blocks that are located 500 metres from the destroyed one. "The women cooks rush out every time a large aircraft passes overhead," Patel says.

Daksha suffered both physically and psychologically, he adds. "The women had jumped over a marble counter and out of the windows to escape. She hurt her L4 and L5 vertebrae. She was so scared that she went to live with her parents in Maharashtira for a month. It was only after her anxiety subsided that she returned and got treated for her injuries." Air India paid for the treatment.

The Patni family that makes

a living selling fruits and vegetables also count themselves as lucky. They live along a dirt path adjoining the medical college's hostel compound, and two of its members who used to work in the mess had left the jobs days earlier when the accident happened.

Sitting outside her kuchcha house with a tarpaulin roof, which overlooks the burnt hostel buildings, Jyotsna Ajay Patni says: "When the crash happened, I was sitting right here. We ran as fast as we could, and took shelter in a one-room building behind our house. The trees were all scorched and so was our home."

Her mother Asha and sister Neha used to work at the mess. "Their lives were spared by the grace of God," says Jyotsna.

The first responders used the Patni family's hand carts to haul bodies, but by the time they made their way back home, Jyotsna's father Sattu

Patni says, they were in for a shock. "Someone had robbed the money we had saved for my younger daughter's wedding."

The other shock was the death of 13-year-old boy Aakash Patni, the son of a teaseller sleeping on the pavement nearby, who was among the casualties on the ground. His mother Sita who was with him suffered extensive burns.

Jyotsna says she keeps thinking of Aakash. "He used to come and sit with us every day. He was taken away at such a young age."

Opposite the Patni home, 15-feet-high mounds of sand have lately been deposited along the boundary wall of the hostel block. This is the spot picked by the Gujarat government to rebuild the hostels destroyed in the crash.

However, many have objected to this, demanding a memorial to those killed instead. Eighteen others besides Aakash died on the ground that day. Families of some have left Ahmedabad.

Like Ravi Thakore, whose entire family worked in the hostels. Thakore and wife Lalita were delivering tiffins when the plane crashed, killing their daughter Aadhyaa and Thakore's mother Sarla. They had left Aadhyaa with Sarla as they did their rounds.

The bodies of Sarla and Aadhyaa were among the four people who died on the ground who could be identified only by DNA profiling. Their last rites were done seven days later, on June 19. The Thakores stopped working at the hostels after that.

Earlier this month, the neighbour said, they left Ahmedabad for good to migrate back to their home town of Patan.

• BRIEFLY



The debris of the balcony that came crashing down on a street near the Banke Bihari temple in Vrindavan, Mathura, on Tuesday. EXPRESS

UTTAR PRADESH

6 injured as balcony collapses on lane near Banke Bihari temple

AT LEAST six devotees were injured on Tuesday afternoon after a dilapidated balcony of a house collapsed onto a crowded lane leading to Banke Bihari Temple in Vrindavan, triggering panic in the area. Mathura SSP Shlok Kumar said the incident occurred on the road leading to the temple and the injured devotees were immediately rushed to a nearby hospital for treatment. "It appears that some monkeys were sitting on the dilapidated balcony when it gave way and fell over the pilgrims passing below," Kumar said. According to preliminary information, the balcony was part of an old private building located near the temple. The collapse sent debris crashing onto the busy thoroughfare. ENS

ED summons Pinarayi's daughter Veena

THE ED has summoned former Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan's daughter Veena T and officials of sand mining company Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) for questioning in a money laundering case. Officials said Veena has been asked to depose at the agency's zonal office here on June 12. CMRL managing director Sasidharan Kartha and other company officials are among the nine others who have been summoned for questioning on different dates, the officials said. PTI

2 soldiers killed in Uri accidental grenade blast

TWO SOLDIERS died in an accidental grenade blast in Uri sector of Baramulla district of J&K on Tuesday, according to officials. A hand grenade exploded accidentally during routine handing over of equipment at a camp in Kamalkote in Uri, resulting in injuries to two jawans, the officials said. They said the injured jawans were shifted to the Army's 92 Base Hospital where doctors declared them dead on arrival. Inquest proceedings have been initiated, they said. PTI

In Arunachal village, over 100 homes vandalised in protest against dam project

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 9

PROHIBITORY ORDERS have been issued in Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Siang district after groups opposing the Upper Siang dam project allegedly vandalised the homes of several villagers who had recently signed an MoU backing the project.

Local reports claimed that among the houses allegedly vandalised on Monday was that of local MLA Oni Panyang. The incident took place two days after Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu and MLA Panyang announced that 110 households from Geku, one of the villages along the Siang river that are expected to be affected by the hydropower project, signed an MoU "in support of the Pre-Feasibility Report (PFR) for the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project".

Ever since the 11,000 MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project was proposed in 2017, it has been opposed by many families whose villages and farmlands would be affected by such a dam. Over the last couple of years, the state authorities and the National Hydroelectric Power Corporation (NHPC) have been trying to begin work on a

Pre-Feasibility Report (PFR), which has been stalled by local opposition. As news of the MoU signing made the rounds, unrest spread to Geku on Monday.

In an executive order imposing restrictions on the assembly of people and "incitement on social media" in Geku on Tuesday, the District Magistrate of Upper Siang alleged that "anti-dam groups vandalised and caused damage to some dwelling houses and properties of pro-PFR residents within Geku township and nearby villages".

"It is currently apprehended that there is every likelihood of the situation being further escalated by the anti-dam groups by resorting to violence, intimidation and vandalism of public properties or the properties and assets of other pro-PFR residents..." the order said.

Both central and state governments are pushing for the Siang dam as a means to counter the possible effects of the 60,000 MW dam — the world's largest hydro-electric project — that China is planning on the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet. The Yarlung Tsangpo flows into Arunachal Pradesh as the Siang, which joins other tributaries, like the Dibang and Lohit, to become the Brahmaputra in Assam.

• RESULTS SUGGEST ONCE-DAILY PILL CAN HELP LOWER BLOOD SUGAR & AID WEIGHT LOSS; SIGNIFICANT FOR OVER 100 MILLION INDIANS WITH DIABETES

Easy pill to swallow: New oral GLP-1 drug shows encouraging results during trials

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Pune, June 9

FOR MILLIONS living with Type 2 diabetes and obesity, the future of treatment may not involve needles. Researchers have reported encouraging results from a clinical trial of elecoglipron, an experimental oral GLP-1 drug that not only lowers blood sugar levels significantly but also helps participants lose weight.

The findings are drawing attention because most GLP-1 therapies (which mimic the blood sugar-regulating and hunger-killing gut hormones) currently available are injectable, while the few oral versions come with strict dosing

requirements that can make adherence difficult. Presented at the American Diabetes Association's Scientific Sessions and simultaneously published in *The Lancet*, the results suggest that a convenient once-daily pill could eventually help bridge gaps in diabetes care.

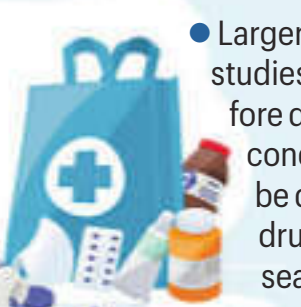
Elecoglipron is a small-molecule GLP-1 drug that can be taken once daily without food or fluid restrictions, potentially making treatment more convenient for patients. Even oral semaglutide, one of the few approved pill formulations, must be taken on an empty stomach with restrictions on food and water intake. The potential significance of oral GLP-1 ther-

apies may be especially important in India, which is home to more than 100 million people with diabetes. Indian patients often develop Type 2 diabetes at lower BMI levels than Western populations because of the so-called "thin-fat" phenotype, characterised by higher visceral fat, lower muscle mass and greater metabolic risk despite a relatively lean appearance.

According to Dr Shashank Joshi, consultant endocrinologist at Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, around one in five Indians with diabetes has a BMI below 23, yet many still have excessive liver fat and significant insulin resistance. This makes treatments that simulta-

• Elecoglipron Advantage

- No food or fluid restrictions, potentially making treatment more convenient for patients
- Potential tool for obesity treatment of adults who are overweight but not diabetic
- Effective for Indian diabetes patients who have lower BMI levels than Western population because of "thin-fat" phenotype
- Side-effects include gastrointestinal issues such as nausea, vomiting, changes in bowel habits
- Larger Phase-3 studies needed before definitive conclusions can be drawn on the drug, say researchers



What the trial found

neously improve blood sugar control, reduce body fat and support metabolic health particularly valuable.

The Phase 2b SOLSTICE trial, sponsored by AstraZeneca, evaluated the efficacy, safety and

tolerability of elecoglipron in adults with Type 2 diabetes. The study enrolled 406 participants across nine countries, including the US. Participants were assigned to different dose groups and followed for 26 weeks.

Researchers found that all tested doses of elecoglipron lowered blood glucose levels significantly more than placebo. Up to 89.6% of participants receiving the drug achieved HbA1c level below 7%, the standard blood sugar target recommended for adults with diabetes. In comparison, only 24.9% of participants receiving placebo reached that goal. Up to 72.3% of participants on treatment achieved at least 5%

weight loss compared with 20.2% in the placebo group.

"Our study's findings underscore the expanding potential of oral GLP-1 receptor agonists for people with Type 2 diabetes," said Dr Vanita Aroda, Director, Diabetes Clinical Research in the Division of Endocrinology, Diabetes and Hypertension at Mass General Brigham.

The promise of elecoglipron is not limited to blood sugar control. In a separate study known as VISTA, researchers evaluated the impact of the drug on adults who were obese but did not have diabetes. The trial found dose-dependent and clinically meaningful weight loss over 26 weeks, with benefits continuing

through 36 weeks. The findings reinforce growing interest in oral GLP-1 therapies as potential tools for both diabetes management and obesity treatment.

At this stage, the drug's safety profile appears broadly consistent with other GLP-1 medications. Researchers reported that overall tolerability was similar to what has been observed with existing drugs in this class.

Experts caution that larger Phase 3 studies will be needed before definitive conclusions can be drawn. "Phase 3 data are still needed to confirm safety, tolerability and preservation of lean muscle mass before it can be considered a breakthrough therapy," said Dr Joshi.

UP, Bengal top Centre’s Rs 95,692-cr interim allocation for states under VB-G RAM G

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, June 9

THE CENTRE on Tuesday announced interim allocation for states out of the Central outlay of Rs 95,692.31 crore for the financial year 2026-27 under the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act 2025 — VB-G RAM G — with Uttar Pradesh getting the highest share of Rs 9,721.48 crore, followed by West Bengal at Rs 8,508 crore.

Announcing the decision, Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said the allocation has been made based on the states’ last year expenditure under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MG-NREGS).

The move comes days after the Ministry of Rural Develop-

● States with highest interim share

States	Proposed Interim Allocation (in Rs crore)
UTTAR PRADESH	9721.48
WEST BENGAL	8508
ANDHRA PRADESH	7707.21
TAMIL NADU	7585.49
RAJASTHAN	7581.87
BIHAR	6715.83
MADHYA PRADESH	6252.03
KARNATAKA	5709.9
MAHARASHTRA	4420.32
TELANGANA	3825.31

ment released a set of draft rules to implement the new rural job guarantee scheme under the VB-G RAM G law from July 1, 2026. As per the draft rules, the Centre shall adopt the objective

parameters used for horizontal devolution among states as recommended by the 16th Finance Commission and accepted by the Government of India to make normative allocation of funds under the VB-G RAM G scheme. The VB-G RAM G rules are yet to become effective but

the ministry has announced interim allocation of funds to the states under the scheme.

Chouhan earlier held a video conference with the rural development ministers of the states. “Not a single worker should remain without work even for a day,” Chouhan said, adding that disruption in employment generation, wage payments or statutory rights would not be acceptable.

The Centre has made an outlay of Rs 95,692.31 crore for the VB—G RAM G scheme during the financial year 2026-27. Unlike the MG-NREGS, where the Centre paid 100 per cent of the wage bill, the VB-G RAM G is a Centrally sponsored scheme with the fund sharing ratio of 60:40 between the Centre and states, and 90:10 for states in northeastern region, Himalayan states and UTs with legislature and 100% central share for Union Territories without legislature.

Concern over escalation in West Asia: PM speaks to Kuwait Amir

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 9

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Tuesday spoke to the Amir of Kuwait, Sheikh Meshal Al-Ahmad Al-Jaber Al Sabah, and expressed deep concern over the escalation of tensions in West Asia while reaffirming India’s strong condemnation of attacks on Kuwait’s sovereignty and territorial integrity.

This came days after an Indian national was killed in an Iranian attack on Kuwait International Airport that reportedly left more than 60 injured.

According to a statement by the PM’s office on Tuesday, “The two leaders exchanged views on the evolving security situation in West Asia.” This discussion between PM Modi and the Amir of Kuwait took place days after Israel and Iran attacked each other over the weekend, in the first significant escalation since the fragile ceasefire was agreed in April this year.

“Prime Minister expressed deep concern over the escalation of tensions and reaffirmed India’s strong condemnation of attacks on Kuwait’s sovereignty

“Prime Minister reiterated the call for de-escalation, dialogue and diplomacy for earliest restoration of peace and stability.”

STATEMENT FROM PMO

and territorial integrity... Prime Minister reiterated the call for de-escalation, dialogue and diplomacy for earliest restoration of peace and stability,” it added.

“Prime Minister thanked His Highness the Amir for his personal attention to the continued well-being and the safety of the large Indian community in Kuwait,” according to the PMO statement.

This is the first phone conversation between the two leaders since the war in West Asia broke out on February 28. Earlier this year, on March 3 and March 18, PM Modi had telephonic conversations regarding regional stability with Kuwait’s Crown Prince, Sheikh Sabah Al-Khaled Al-Hamad Al-Mubarak Al-Sabah.

Last week, India had condemned the attack on Kuwait airport while renewing calls for an end to violence while urging strongly not to target civilian population and civilian infrastructure. “Since the onset of the conflict in West Asia, we have strongly urged that civilian population and civilian infrastructure must not be targeted. We again call upon parties to cease such attacks,” the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) had said in a statement.

In a post on X, the Embassy of India in Kuwait said it is “closely coordinating” with the Kuwaiti authorities to extend all possible support and assistance to the bereaved family as well as those injured in the incident last Wednesday. The deceased was identified as Manzoor Ahmed, a 55-year-tailor from Madhya Pradesh. This latest death put the total number of Indian fatalities to at least 10 since hostilities broke out between Iran and US-Israel on February 28.

“We extend our sincere condolences and sympathies to the family of the deceased and his relatives, and we wish a speedy recovery to all the injured,” said Colonel Saud Abdulaziz Al-Otaibi, the official spokesman of Kuwait’s Ministry of Defence.

Kuwait Interior Ministry spokesperson Brigadier General Nasser Bousleib said that the passenger terminal (T1) at the airport was subjected to an attack by several hostile drones. The Kuwaiti foreign ministry later summoned the Charge d’Affaires at the Iranian Embassy and handed him an official protest note regarding the attacks.

Consider using app for Aadhaar verification: States, UTs told

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, June 9

THE CENTRE has asked states and Union Territories to consider using app-based Aadhaar verification for citizen-facing services such as hotel and guest house registration, visitor management, hospital patient verification and examination candidate checks, in a move aimed at reducing document misuse and strengthening privacy safeguards, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

In a letter, sent a few days ago to the Chief Secretaries of all states and UTs, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) said the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) has recently launched an app that allows Aadhaar number holders to securely store, display and share Aadhaar-verifiable information with requesting entities for identity verification.

According to the communication, the app-based verification system is designed to enable secure identity checks while addressing concerns related to data privacy, misuse of Aadhaar photographs, authenticity of offline Aadhaar data, and proof of physical presence during verification.

In Delhi, the government has recommended that departments and agencies, including the police, Home Guards, Tihar Jail, forensic laboratories, courts and the fire services use the app.

Under the proposed process, the verifying institution will use the app to generate or open a QR code for authentication. The individual undergoing verification will scan the code, after which basic details such as name, age and mobile number would appear on the screen along with the individual’s photograph, enabling the verification to be completed without submission of a physical document or photocopy.

Officials say the switch could reduce the risks associated with sharing photocopies of Aadhaar cards -- a common practice at hotels, guest houses and other establishments. “Such copies can be misused if they fall into the wrong hands. The move also comes against the backdrop of reported fraud cases in which Aadhaar-related information was allegedly collected on false pretences and later used to obtain goods or loans,” an official said.

The Centre has also outlined that institutions wishing to undertake Aadhaar app-based offline verification will have to register with UIDAI in accordance with the Aadhaar (Authentication and Offline Verification) Amendment Regulations, 2025, notified through a Gazette notification on December 9, 2025.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER



GORKHA RIFLES
Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave hearts, No 9423128Y Late Rfn Palendu Rai of 6/11 GR who made supreme sacrifice during OP Parakram on 10 Jun 2002 Indian.



Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks BORDER SECURITY FORCE
CONSTABLE RAJ KUMAR 39 BN BSF 02.03.1968 – 10.06.1994
CONSTABLE KANAK CHAND 39 BN BSF 31.03.1974 – 10.06.1994

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constables Raj Kumar and Kanak Chand on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous bullet injuries, while fighting with militants in area of Kurnuhara, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



ASI SABU THOMAS MANAPPALLIL 170 BN BSF 24.11.1967 – 10.06.2025



CONSTABLE MAHAVIR PRASAD MEENA 76 Bn 05-06-1962 To 10-06-1991

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Subordinate officer Assistant Sub Inspector Sabu Thomas Manappallil on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice, while on operational duty in area of BOP Peernagar, Silchar (Assam). #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



Veer Balidani Head Constable Satpal Singh 113 Bn 01-01-1960 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Constable N. Nagraj 113 Bn 13-06-1976 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Constable Dinesh Singh 113 Bn 14-05-1965 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Constable P. Shambashiv Rao 113 Bn 05-06-1972 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Lance Naik S. Chatopadhyay 113 Bn 01-05-1966 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Constable Shrivard Sahoo 113 Bn 10-05-1965 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Constable P. Velu 113 Bn 20-04-1972 To 10-06-1998



Veer Balidani Constable A. G. Khan 113 Bn 30-11-1972 To 10-06-1998

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to eight bravehearts of 113 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an operation in Pasara, Telangana on 10 June 1998. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.



Veer Balidani Shri Rampal Singh Asst. Comdt. 85 Bn 02-02-1966 To 10-06-2009



Veer Balidani Inspector Prawal Parimal 7 Bn 07-08-1975 To 10-06-2009

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Asstt. Comdt. Shri Rampal Singh of 85 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an operation at village Kurchuli, district Bijapur, Chhattisgarh on 10 June 2009. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

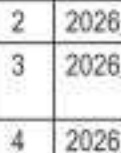


Veer Balidani Constable Shashindra Kumar Sharma 159 Bn 15-01-1985 To 10-06-2012



Veer Balidani Constable Shashindra Kumar Sharma 159 Bn 15-01-1985 To 10-06-2012

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Shashindra Kumar Sharma of 159 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a fierce encounter with Maoists in Gaya district, Bihar on 10 June 2012. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Sankaramangalam, Kollam-691 583
Phone: 0476-2651215 to 2651217, e-mail: md@kmmil.com, URL: www.kmmil.com

TENDER NOTICE
For more details please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://tenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmmil.com

Sl No	Tender ID	Items
1	2026_KMMIL_854783_1	Supply of Electric Hoists
2	2026_KMMIL_855032_1	Fabrication and Supply of Tickle Condenser
3	2026_KMMIL_855008_1	Supply of Oilwet Filter Assembly with 200 & 80 NB Nozzle
4	2026_KMMIL_855044_1	Supply of Safety shoes Leather-Black

Chavara 09.06.2026 Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd



EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
No. ECR/HQOMech(ENHM)/18/2020 dated-05.06.2026
Mechanical Department
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

Mechanical Department of East Central Railway invites "Expression of Interest" for Engagement of Professional Housekeeping Agencies for Enhanced and High-Quality On Board Services in Coaching Trains over ECR.

The responses must be submitted in sealed envelope with necessary document to the Office of PCME/ECR, Room No.29, Third Floor, Mechanical Department, E.C Railway, Headquarters office, Hajipur, Vaishali, PIN-844101 and a copy via email to ecrcenhm@gmail.com Application should reach up to 15:00 hrs on or before 23.06.2026.

The detail EOJ along with Terms & conditions may be downloaded from <http://ecr.indianrailways.gov.in>

PR/0369/HQ/ENHM/Notice/26-27/48 CENHM/ECR/HJP



TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001-2022 Certified Company)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec.No.PMM11-e-41/2026: Lot-1: 2.5sq.mm PVC FRLS, Armoured Copper Control Cables, Lot-2: PVC FRLS, Armoured Aluminium Power Cables. Date & Time of availability of above tender: 10.06.2026 at 5:00 PM. Website: www.tender.apecprocurement.gov.in. Contact No.CE/Transmission: 0866-2429230. Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER/TRANSMISSION R.O.No.GMCC/APTRANSCO/79/26-27



SEZ BIOTECH SERVICES PVT. LTD.
(Manjari SEZ - Poonawalla Biotechnology Park at Manjari Badak, Taluka Haveli, District Pune-412307)
(Hadapsar SEZ - at Village Hadapsar/Manjari, District Pune, Maharashtra, India)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER Date:10/06/2026
SEZ Bio-Tech Services Private Limited Manjari SEZ and Hadapsar SEZ are deemed distribution licensees for their SEZ area located in Manjari and Hadapsar Pune respectively.
The Short-Term Thermal Power Procurement Tender for both entities is uploaded on the DEEP Portal as per Ministry of Power Guidelines.
For any queries, please contact us at: ddlm@sezbiotech.com, ddlh@sezbiotech.com



GMDC
Gujarat Mineral Development Corporation Ltd.

TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender is invited for Appointment of Agency for Design, Development and Comprehensive Annual Maintenance of Various Websites of GMDC.
For e tenders notice, tender documents and for further details visit our website www.gmdcltd.com.
Tender shall be downloaded from <https://gmdc.procure.com> and submitted online as per e-tender notice. Please visit <https://gmdc.nprocure.com> for time to time for any corrigendum/addendum.
GMDC E-Tender No.: GMDC/IT/Websites/01/26-27
n-Procure Tender No : 311614



Gujarat Mineral Development Corporation Ltd.
(A Government of Gujarat Enterprise)
Khanji Bhawan, 132 Feet Ring Road, Near University Ground, Vastapur, Ahmedabad-380052



EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE
Dhanbad, dt. 05.06.2026

E-Tenders are invited for execution of the following works by Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.), E.C. Railway, Dhanbad:-

Sl. No. 1, E-Tender No.: 89-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Chainpur-Provision of Multi Section Digital Axle Counter (MSDAC) in Chainpur (CNPR) Yard under Dhanbad Division. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 33,57,243.77

Sl. No. 2, E-Tender No.: 90-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Barkakana-Connection of CIC line with Shunting Neck at Barkakana. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 55,20,633.32

Sl. No. 3, E-Tender No.: 91-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: GMR-BRKA: Replacement of bed block of bridge no. 174, strengthening of pier, boulder pitching colour washing or white washing, pointing & epoxy grouting works under ADEN/2/GMO. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 1,40,05,853.43

Sl. No. 4, E-Tender No.: 92-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Reconditioning of Point and Xing, tounge rail and SEJ under jurisdiction of Sr. DEN (3)/DHN. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 50,98,423.14

Sl. No. 5, E-Tender No.: 93-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Supply of welding portion and other consumables under the jurisdiction of ADEN/2/GMO & ADEN/BRKA. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 1,09,50,599.00

Sl. No. 6, E-Tender No.: 94-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Dhanbad Division TSR (P)-294 Tkm & CTR (P)-1,045 Tkm by PORS under jurisdiction of Sr DEN/3/DHN. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 1,64,40,801.22

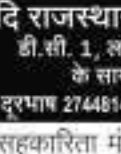
Sl. No. 7, E-Tender No.: 95-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Repair and replace corroded pipe and sanitary work at KTH under ADEN/2/DHN. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 50,48,364.82

Sl. No. 8, E-Tender No.: 96-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Provision of Dog Kennel at DHN under ADEN/1/DHN. 06 (Six) Months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 43,22,855.69

Sl. No. 9, E-Tender No.: 97-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Provision of ramp (with All Divyang facilities) in the FOB of TET MRQ, NMG & CCK station under ADEN/1/GMO. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 4,75,02,718.41

Sl. No. 10, E-Tender No.: 98-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Provision of 3.0M wide FOB at RIBP & LRB station in the jurisdiction of Sr. DEN/2/DHN. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 10,22,73,471.23

Sl. No. 11, E-Tender No.: 99-DHN-2026-27, Name of the work with its location & completion period: Drain & Pathway works at GAP, PRP, TKN, BNF, GJD & HZD Stations in connection with the work of yard improvement/up-gradation work under ADEN/GJD. 12 (Twelve) months. Approx. Cost of work (In Rs.): 14,84,87,343.08



दि राजस्थान स्टेट को-ऑपरेटिव बैंक लि.
डि.सी. 1, आकाशवाणी सीटिंग सिटी, मेरु, गानावाला के सामने, टाक रोड, जयपुर 302015
दूरभाष 2744814, 2744429 वेबसाइट www.rscb.bank.in

सहकारिता मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार द्वारा शुरू की गई पहली को लाभ समीचीन स्तर पर यूरोपियन एवं सहकारी समितियों के लिए आवश्यक क्षमता निर्माण एवं विभिन्न योजनाओं के सुचारु क्रियान्वयन हेतु राजस्थान राज्य सहकारी बैंक लि. में Co-operative Terms के एक दफ (संवित्ता आधार पर) के लिए प्राप्त अभ्यर्थियों से आवेदन आमंत्रित किया जाते हैं। विस्तृत विवरण बैंक की वेबसाइट www.rscb.bank.in पर उपलब्ध है।
प्रबन्ध निदेशक



EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM
Notice No.: W.584/E-Tendering/83, 84, 85, 86-DHN-26-27, Dhanbad, dt. 05/06/2026
(1) It is further to notify that, in the E-Tender No. 83-DHN-2026-27 and 86-DHN-2026-27 dt. 21.05.2026, Date of closing & opening of e-tender should be read as at 12:00 hours on 16.06.2026 & from 12:30 hours on 16.06.2026 respectively instead of at 12:00 hours on 15.06.2026 & from 12:30 pm on 15.06.2026.
(2) It is further to notify that, in the E-Tender No. 84-DHN-2026-27 and 85-DHN-2026-27 dt. 21.05.2026, Date of closing & opening of e-tender should be read as at 12:00 hours on 17.06.2026 & from 12:30 hours on 17.06.2026 respectively instead of at 12:00 hours on 15.06.2026 & from 12:30 pm on 15.06.2026.
All other details, term and condition exists in the e-tender notice No. 83-DHN-2026-27, 84-DHN-2026-27, 85-DHN-2026-27, 86-DHN-2026-27 dt. 21.05.2026 will remain unchanged and unaltered.
Divl. Railway Manager (Engg.)
East Central Railway, Dhanbad
PR/0372/DHN/ENGG/Corrigendum/26-27/32



EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
(Construction Department)
E-TENDER NOTICE
e-tender is invited on Behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned work:-
SN. 1, e-Tender No. : ECR-CAO-C-S-EPC-02-26-27, Name of work: Engineering procurement and Construction (EPC) of important Bridge No. 136 (9x45.70m OWG), 151 (26x30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type), 153 (11x30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type)+1X12.20m PSC Slab), 154 (14x30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type), 161 (1X9.15m PSC Slab+10X30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type+1X9.15m PSC Slab), 162 (1X9.15m PSC Slab+10X30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type+1X9.15m PSC Slab), 163 (17X30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type+1X12.20m PSC Slab) & Major Bridge No. 144 (2X12.20m PSC Slab), 145 (2X12.20m PSC Slab), 152 (4X45.70m OWG), 155 (2X9.15m PSC Slab), 156 (1X9.15m PSC Slab+1X30.5m Ballasted Deck O W G Welded Through Type+1X9.15m PSC Slab), 157 (2X45.70m OWG), 158 (1X9.15m PSC Slab+3X30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type+1X9.15m PSC Slab), 159 (1X9.15m PSC Slab+3X30.5m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type+1X9.15m PSC Slab), 160 (7X30.50m Ballasted Deck OWG Welded Through Type) for 3rd & 4th line including their formation at approaches and protection works in connection with Punaraksh-Kul 3rd & 4th rail line Project, Approx cost of the work in (Rs.): 1280,01,81,360.15, Cost of tender form in (Rs.): 0.00, Earnest money in (Rs.): 25,60,03,700.00, Period of work completion: 36 Months, Date and time for closing of tender: 15.07.2026 at 12.15 hrs.
Any e-tenders which is sent by Post/Courier/Fax or by hand will not be accepted. All such manual submission of tender even if it is on firm's letter pad or received in time will not be accepted.
The above e-tender document along with full information is available on website <http://www.irops.gov.in>.
Note: In case of any discrepancies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.irops.gov.in> at least 15 days before last date of closing, for latest corrigendum/corrections etc in connection with this tender.
Any change/addendum/corrigendum will be published on IREPS website only.
CAO/Con/South
EC Rly. MHX, Patna
PR/0370/CONS/MHX/Patna/CONST/IT/26-27/72



MADHYA PRADESH RURAL ROAD DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
(AN AGENCY OF PANCHAYAT & RURAL DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT, GOVT. OF M.P.)
3rd Floor, Vikas Bhawan, Arera Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)
(GST No. 23AAATM9054A3ZX)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER EL-96
No./5699/22/D-12/MPRRDA/2026 Bhopal, Dated : 09.06.2026
Online Percentage rate Tenders are invited for "Shifting/Raising of High Voltage (HV)/Medium Voltage (MV)/Low Voltage (LV) lines and poles from alignment of PMGSY/CMGSY Road from contractors having 'A' class valid license issued by Madhya Pradesh Licensing Board (Electrical) and registered with MPPWD in appropriate class of contractors on e-procurement portal <https://www.mptenders.gov.in>. Contractors are to quote rate in percentage below/above or at par of the estimated rates given in BOQ including all Taxes except GST.

S. No.	Name of District	No. of Packages	Total PAC (In Rs.)
1	Dhar	2	12218477.00

1. Tender document can be purchased and submitted only online from the above website from 10.06.2026 from 17:30 hrs. and last date for online bid submission is 01.07.2026 (17:00 hrs.)

2. Other Critical dates and details can be viewed in the detailed NIT and tender document on the above mentioned portal and concerned PIU.

CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (TENDER)
M.P. Madhyam/126273/2026

‘मेरी सड़क’ ऐप डाउनलोड कर कीडबैक देकर राष्ट्र के विकास में सहयोग दें।



OFFICE OF THE RESIDENT ENGINEER
BUILDING DIVISION, BIHAR BHAWAN, NEW DELHI
National Competitive Bidding by e-tendering
Website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

E-tender Notice CORRIGENDUM
This is to inform to all that in E-tender notice No-01/2026-27 whose PR No. is IPRD_PR_004125/26-27 Published in daily new-paper and issued from this office by letter No. 346 enc, dated 22.05.2026 following modifications are being made.
Name of Work :- Comprehensive Housekeeping, Maintenance and operation Contract (for 5 years) of Bihar Sadan, Dwarika, New Delhi 2026-31.

Sl. No	Prticulars	Last Modified Date and time	New Modified Date and Time
1	Last date and time of sale (download) of BOQ	From Date 06.06.2026 to 30.06.2026 upto 15.00 hrs	From Date 22.06.2026 to 15.07.2026 upto 15.00 hrs
2	Last Date and time of submission (upload) of tender	Date 01.07.2026 upto 15.00 hrs	Date 16.07.2026 upto 15.00 hrs
3	Date and time of opening of tender (Technical Bid)	Date 02.07.2026 upto 15.30 hrs	Date 17.07.2026 upto 15.30 hrs
4	Date and time of opening of tender (Financial Bid)	After disposal of Technical Bid from Departmental Tender Committee	After disposal of Technical Bid from Departmental Tender Committee
5	Pre Bid Meeting Date/Time/Place	Date 12.06.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. in office of Chief Engineer (Patna), BCD, Patna. Date 16.06.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. in office of Bihar Bhawan, New Delhi.	Date 30.06.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. in office of Chief Engineer (Patna), BCD, Patna. Date 03.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. in office of Bihar Bhawan, New Delhi.

All other conditions will remain unchanged

PR. No. 005289 (BCD) 2026-27
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

रक्त की आवश्यकता पड़ने पर लाइसेंस प्राप्त ब्लड बैंको से ही रक्त प्राप्त करें।



Office of the District Planning Officer, Dhanbad
Notice Inviting Bid (NIB)
RFP FOR
SELECTION OF AGENCY FOR FREE COACHING OF ASPIRANTS PREPARING FOR PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION, STAFF SELECTION COMMISSION (SSC), BANKING, RAILWAY, AND OTHER SIMILAR GOVERNMENT COMPETITIVE EXAMINATIONS IN DHANBAD DISTRICT.

NIB No 01
Issue Date 08.06.2026
The Deputy Commissioner, Dhanbad, Govt. of Jharkhand, invites Request for Proposal (RFP) for the selection of agency for free coaching of aspirants preparing for Public Service Commission, Staff Selection Commission (SSC), Banking, Railway, and other similar government competitive examinations in Dhanbad.

Opening Date 08.06.2026
Closing Date: 19.06.2026
The Bidders are advised to go through the RFP document carefully. Submission of bids shall be deemed to have been done after careful study and examination of the tender document with the full understanding of its implications. The RFP document can be downloaded from the website <https://gem.gov.in/> & <https://dhanbad.nic.in>. Submission of bid shall be through Jharkhand

Kuki farmer killed in armed attack in Manipur village

Express News Service
Imphal, June 9

A KUKI farmer was killed in an attack by armed miscreants in Lansan village in Manipur's Tamenglong district on Tuesday. The police said the attack happened around 11.30 am in the Kuki-dominated village.

According to the police, a group of armed miscreants opened fire towards some farmers working in a paddy field along the Imphal-Tamenglong road. Haogin Louvum, 55, was killed in the attack. A case has been registered and investigation is underway, said the police.

The incident was reported on the day 14 Kuki men, who had been held captive by Naga groups since May 13, were released. The 14 men had been abducted following a twin ambush at Kangpokpi and Noney districts, killing four persons including three church leaders and one Naga man.

On Monday, a Rongmei Naga man, Chunjanglung Panmei, 58, was killed in an attack in Pongringlong Part-I village of Kangpokpi district.

The incident occurred while Panmei, along with eight villagers, had gone to collect firewood from Kangpokpi forest.

Kuki Inpi Sadar Hills, a Kuki body, alleged Louvum was killed by NSCN-IM Kamson group.

14 abducted Kuki men freed, no word on six missing Naga men

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 9

NEARLY A month after they were abducted and one aborted release attempt later, 14 Kuki men were released by Naga groups in Manipur's Senapati district Tuesday afternoon. However, a question mark still lingers over the location and fate of six missing Naga men, who are believed to have been abducted by the Kuki side.

The Naga groups have been hoping to use the 14 Kukis with them to force the other side to hand over the six missing Nagas.

A senior police official said the 14 Kuki men were released at Taphou Kuki, a village in Kangpokpi district, to which most of them belong, and that search is still on for six missing Naga men.

Taphou village headman Lenkhomang Chongloi said the 14 men were handed over to them by a team of police, security forces and the administration, and they were told that this was happening only an hour earlier. The Kuki headman said: "We thought the 14 had already gone, that we had lost them. So emotions are running very high right now."

On May 13, amidst the rising Kuki-Naga tension in Manipur, dozens of villagers were abducted by both sides in Kuki-Zo-majority Kangpokpi district and



14 Kuki hostages were released nearly a month after they were abducted by armed groups, in Imphal on Tuesday. PTI

Naga-majority Senapati district, respectively. Fourteen captives had been released by both sides after a day-long stand-off.

However, Naga groups in Senapati had continued to hold on to 14 captives, demanding that six of their missing people, who they alleged had been abducted by Kuki groups, be released first.

The Kuki groups have denied holding any Nagas, saying they released all their hostages on May 15.

According to locals, the Kuki villagers who had been abducted had stepped out of home on May 13 morning to gather firewood in the jungle, when the situation in the hills began to spiral due to the killing of three church leaders from the Thadou Baptist Association in an am-

bush at Kangpokpi.

In retaliation, the Kuki groups abducted over a dozen Naga villagers in Kangpokpi. This was followed by the abduction of over two dozen Kuki residents of Taphou. Chongloi said the 14 released men were undergoing medical check-ups. "An Army doctor has come. We will take them to civil doctors as well. We are thankful that they do not have any physical injuries, but we don't know what their mental and psychological condition might be like," he said.

United Naga Council (UNC) president Ng. Lorho told The Indian Express that the release had been facilitated by building consensus among the different Naga groups in Senapati. "The government has assured us that

the status of our six men will be established and produced within a time frame. So, we are waiting now. We have made the first move on humanitarian grounds," he said.

In an oral statement made close to Taphou, he said, "We are honouring the commitment made by Honourable Home Minister Amit Shah ji through Honourable CM of Nagaland Dr Neiphiu Rio that the government will put all effort to trace and establish the status of the six Naga missing hostages."

Different quarters had been urging for the release of the 14 Kuki men, including Nagaland Chief Minister Rio, Meghalaya CM Conrad Sangma and different church groups. The Home Department of the Manipur government had also appealed to the UNC to facilitate the release of the hostages, stating that the case related to the missing men had been transferred to the NIA, along with continuing search operations.

With these appeals, there had been discussions to release them on June 1. However, this had led to tensions in Senapati with other Naga groups expressing discontentment over this potential release without the six men being located and rescued, and the UNC had called off the release citing "prevailing sentiments of Naga public".

Shiv Shakti Point soil chemically close to lunar meteorite that hit Antarctica

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, June 9

DATA COLLECTED by India's moon mission Chandrayaan-3 has established a close chemical relationship between the soil found at Shiv Shakti Point, the landing site near the Moon's South Pole, and a lunar meteorite that had hit Antarctica's Allan Hills region of Victoria land about a million years ago.

A new study led by a team of researchers from the Physical Research Laboratory (PRL) noted that the iron and magnesium-rich and aluminum-deficient soil found at the Shiv Shakti point came closest chemically to the lunar meteorite ALHA 81005 discovered in Antarctica in 1982.

Dwijesh Ray, lead author and PRL scientist, told *The Indian Express*: "The Chandrayaan-3 landing site occupies a compositional space between traditional ferroan anorthosite and Mg-suite lithologies (names of different types of rocks), and closely resembles the lunar meteorite ALHA 81005."

Both ferroan anorthosite and Mg-suite lithologies are typical lunar rock types composed of specific elements, like calcium and magnesium.

The lunar surface has suffered numerous micro-meteorite and meteorite hits in the past, as a result of which the regolith layers (the top layers) on its surface have a certain chemical composition. But the possibility of deeper lava and mineral layers mixing with the

E. EXPLAINED

Importance of the findings

The results highlight the compositional diversity that exists within the lunar highlands and demonstrate that different impact histories can expose and redistribute distinct crustal materials across the Moon. For upcoming rover missions, such geochemical information could help prioritise locations that are likely to contain materials excavated from deeper layers, that could prove valuable in providing insights into early evolutionary histories of the Moon.

surface soil as a fallout of these events were not scientifically established yet.

The latest results have emerged from the data gathered by the Alpha Particle X-ray Spectrometer (APXS), a scientific probe onboard the Pragyaan rover on Chandrayaan-3, had landed on the Moon's South Pole in August 2023.

The APXS is designed to unravel the chemical composition of the soil at the Chandrayaan-3 landing site.

The PRL team, in a new publication in the journal *Nature*, described the soil at the landing site to be a mix composition of a number of chemicals.

Rajnath clears solar project on unused defence land in Sitapur

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 9

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh has approved the establishment of a 250 MW Solar Power Project with a Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) in Sitapur, Uttar Pradesh, marking a pioneering effort among several planned projects aimed at utilising thousands of acres of unused defence land across India for various green energy initiatives.

The Sitapur project will be developed on a vacant parcel of defence land measuring 850 acres, the Defence Ministry said on Monday. "This is the first-of-its-kind project undertaken by the Ministry of Defence (MoD), involving the development of a large-scale solar power generation facility with integrated BESS support on defence land," the statement from the Ministry noted.

The Ministry stated that the solar power project at Sitapur reflects the government's commitment towards clean energy, sustainability and reduction of dependence on conventional energy sources. It said that besides strengthening long-term energy security for the defence forces, the project is expected to substantially reduce expenditure incurred on procurement of conventional grid power for defence establishments, resulting in significant savings to the government exchequer over the life cycle of the project.

It noted that NTPC Limited is implementing the project through a competitive bid process to realise the most optimal energy pricing and savings for defence establishments.

COURT QUASHES DGCA'S SUSPENSION ORDER, SAYS IT'S ILLEGAL, UNSUSTAINABLE

‘Got my life and dignity back’: After 15 years, pilot hopes to fly again as HC restores licence

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, June 9

AT 46, Jeetendra Krishna Varma was flying all three aircraft types in Air India's fleet. Then, in 2011, his licence was suspended without notice or inquiry, and everything unravelled. He lost his job, his marriage, custody of his children, and spent years at his father's home in Gujarat because he could no longer afford to live in Pune or Mumbai.

On Monday, the Bombay High Court quashed the DGCA's suspension order, restored his licence, and noted that Delhi Police has not framed charges against him in 15 years and the authority never produced the "forged" marksheet he was accused of using to procure a flying licence.

Varma is 61 now. The age bar for pilots is 65. "Aviation and flying are in my blood," he told *The Indian Express*. "I want to resume flying and restart life."

"I'd never been to a court or police station and suddenly these things came up and I was a victim of a media trial. The

hasty decision of suspension of my licence led to termination of my 22 years of unblemished service record. I was at the peak of my career at the age of 46 and was flying all three kinds of aircraft Air India had at that time and suddenly I lost everything. With this ruling, I have got my life and dignity back," he told *The Indian Express*.

The suspension not only ended his flying career but upended his personal life. Varma, who was earlier based in Pune, claims he lost his house, underwent divorce proceedings, and has not seen his children in 15 years. "My family members, including my siblings, and close friends supported me and without them it would have been difficult and I might have had to beg on the streets. I ended up spending over Rs 50 lakh (in the legal battle) in the last 15 years. It was very painful. You cannot change destiny; you have to face it. You need patience and must remain calm during the judicial process," he said.

On March 12, 2011, Varma was on a flight from Shanghai to



Jeetendra Varma, 61, says he will start from scratch, train again

New Delhi. At his hotel room in Delhi, he was summoned by police officers probing allegations of favouritism in issuance of licences by DGCA officials. He had been accused of paying certain amounts for a forged marksheet to obtain his licence. He was arrested along with another pilot and granted bail within a week on March 19.

Four days later, he wrote to DGCA seeking the suspension's withdrawal and release of his Commercial Pilot License (CPL). No reply came, and he ap-

proached the Bombay High Court in April 2011 through advocates Mohan Bir Singh and Rahul Jalan.

Although a criminal complaint was lodged against him in 2011 by Delhi Police for allegedly procuring a flying licence using forged marksheets, no charges were framed against him even after 15 years. His termination from Air India had earlier been set aside by the HC observing violation of fundamental rights and principles of natural justice and upheld by the Supreme Court last year, after which he rejoined the airline. But he still couldn't fly, as the licence remained suspended.

The bench of Justices Manish M Pitale and Shreeram V Shirsat found that the DGCA had suspended his Airline Transport Pilot Licence (ATPL) without issuing a show-cause notice and without specifying the suspension duration. Justice Shirsat, writing for the bench, observed that the authority had "conspicuously failed" to explain the basis of its decision. The court also rejected the

DGCA's reliance on Rule 19, which applies only to persons convicted of contraventions under the Aircraft Rules. The DGCA argued the suspension was "neither arbitrary nor illegal and that it was passed on merits, based on the documents available on record". The court disagreed, setting it aside as "clearly illegal and unsustainable". The matter has been remitted to DGCA, which must give Varma an opportunity to explain his version and pass a reasoned order within two months.

Varma trained at the Airline Asian Academy in Orlando, Florida, and was issued a CPL in 1988. Over nearly two decades he accumulated close to 7,000 flying hours and eventually qualified for an ATPL.

"The age bar for flying is 65. I have only a few flying years left, so I have to start from scratch, but my passion is still alive. Technology and the way of training have changed in the last 15 years, so I'll have to work on that. I have to get my licence first followed by a medical checkup. Let's see what happens," he said.

West Bengal agrees to drop ‘dham’ from Digha Jagannath Temple name on Odisha’s request

Atri Mitra & Sujit Bisoyi
Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, June 9

THE BJP government in West Bengal on Tuesday announced that it would remove the word "dham" from the name of the Digha Jagannath Temple on request of the Odisha government.

This seeks to end the controversy that erupted over Digha temple's name, which had irked many religious and political figures in Odisha — the home of the 12th-century Puri Jagannath Temple, which has long been known as Jagannath Dham.

Announcing the decision following a Cabinet meeting, West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari said using the word "dham" for the Digha Jagannath Temple was not correct in accordance with "Sanatan culture".

"The previous West Bengal government has approved it as Sri Sri Jagannath Dham Cultural Centre. They technically made it a cultural centre, but inserted the word 'dham' in it. It has been built using funds from the public exchequer. I accept the request of the Odisha Chief Minister, and we will remove the word 'dham' immediately," said Adhikari.

The West Bengal CM said the complex would remain and that worship would continue there.

BJP Puri MP Sambit Patra, who had gone to West Bengal

with Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi's letter requesting that the word "dham" be dropped from the Digha temple's name, was present during the announcement.

The naming of the newly built temple at Digha, inaugurated in April last year by the Mamata Banerjee government, had been criticised by servitors of the Puri temple, and the Odisha government had strongly objected to the new temple being called a "dham".

The Odisha Chief Minister, in a letter to his then West Bengal counterpart on May 6, 2025, had said that using "dham" for the Digha temple "dilutes the distinct heritage of Puri", and added that it hurt the sentiments and emotions of millions of pilgrims and devotees.

Majhi had noted the Puri shrine holds unparalleled religious, spiritual, and cultural significance, not just for the people of Odisha, but for millions of devotees across India and the world, and the name "Jagannath Dham" holds a unique and sacrosanct identity linked to Puri.

Chairperson of the Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee, Dibyasingha Deb, also appealed to ISKCON, which manages affairs at the Digha temple, to persuade authorities to desist from using the word "dham" for the new shrine.



Reliance Industries Limited
Growth is Life

Regd. Office: 3rd Floor, Maker Chambers IV, 222, Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021.
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CIN: L17110MH1973PLC019786

NOTICE

SPECIAL WINDOW FOR TRANSFER AND DEMATERIALISATION (DEMAT) OF PHYSICAL SHARES

Please note that a **Special Window for transfer and dematerialisation (demat) of physical shares** will remain open **up to February 04, 2027** as per SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-PoD/I/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 ("SEBI Circular").

This facility is available to those investors who had **purchased physical shares of Reliance Industries Limited ("the Company") prior to April 01, 2019**, and:

(a) had not lodged the shares for transfer; or
(b) had lodged the shares for transfer, but the same were rejected, returned, or not attended to due to deficiencies in documentation.

Applicability of the Special Window

For clarity regarding the applicability of this window to transfer the deeds executed before April 1, 2019, investors may refer to the matrix below

Lodged for transfer before April 01, 2019?	Is the Original Share Certificate available with the investor?	Whether eligible to lodge in the Special Window?
No - it is fresh lodgement	Yes	Yes (subject to conditions stated in the SEBI Circular)
Yes, but was rejected/ returned earlier	Yes	
Yes, was lodged	No	No
No, was not lodged	No	No

Kindly note that request(s) which are accompanied by original share certificate(s) along with transfer deed(s) and other supporting documents will only be considered under the Special Window.

Investors wishing to avail of this Special Window may contact the Company's **Registrar and Transfer Agent, KFin Technologies Limited** (Unit: Reliance Industries Limited), having their address at **Selenium Tower-B, Plot Nos. 31 & 32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Hyderabad – 500 032.**

For further details, investors may refer to the SEBI Circular available at: <https://tinyurl.com/29ab3727>.
Queries may be addressed to rilinvestor@kfintech.com

For Reliance Industries Limited
Sd/-
Savithri Parekh
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Place : Mumbai
Dated : June 10, 2026

www.ril.com

Office of the Commissioner of Industries Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi Udyog Sadan

Plot No.419, F.I.E., Patparganj Industrial Area, Delhi-110092
Email: handicrafthandloom00@gmail.com

Admission Notice

Regarding applications invited in the prescribed format from bonafide residents of National Capital Territory of Delhi for admission in 1st Year (9 Seats) / 2nd Year (2 Seats) under Lateral Entry system for the session 2026-27 for Three Year Diploma Course in Handloom & Textile Technology commencing from 16th July 2026 at IIHT, Jodhpur vide advertisement dated 22.05.2026/29.05.2026, the last date for submission of application forms has been extended up to **17 June, 2026**.

All other contents of the earlier advertisements will remain same.

Sd/-

Rakesh Kumar

Section Officer (H/H)

Industries Department, GNCTD

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0100/26-27

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA MINISTRY OF EDUCATION DEPARTMENT OF HIGHER EDUCATION

Appointment of Vice-Chancellor of Central University of Himachal Pradesh

Applications are invited for the post of Vice-Chancellor of Central University of Himachal Pradesh

The Vice-Chancellor, being the academic as well as administrative head, is expected to be:

- A person possessing the highest level of competence, integrity, morals and institutional commitment.
- A distinguished academician, with a minimum of 10 years' experience as Professor in a University or 10 years' experience in reputed research and/or academic administrative organization with proof of having demonstrated academic leadership.
- Preferably not more than 65 years of age as on the closing date of receipt of applications of this advertisement.

Salary and Service Conditions

- The post carries a pay of Rs. 2,10,000/- (Fixed) per month with Special Allowance of Rs. 11,250/- and other usual allowances.
- The terms and conditions of the services will be those as set forth in the Act, Statutes and Ordinances of the University.

Procedure for appointment

- Appointment will be made from a panel of names recommended by a committee constituted under the provisions of Act of the University.
- The advertisement is available on the websites <https://dohe-education.gov.in> and <https://www.cuhimachal.ac.in>
- Candidates are required to "APPLY ONLINE ONLY" on the Ministry of Education SAMARTH portal as per the link given below:
<https://vcrec.samarth.ac.in/index.php/>
- The above link will be active from 10.06.2026, 10:00 Hours to 09.07.2026, 17:00 Hours.

CBC 21201/11/0004/2627

Milestone in history, long road to future

IT'S own words “sabka saath, sabka vikas, sabka vishwas” is the animating spirit for the Narendra Modi government that crosses a historic milestone today — Modi is now the longest continuously serving elected Prime Minister India has known. “*Sabka vishwas*” is especially resonant. It frames both the achievement and the challenge. After all, a three-term prime ministership would not be possible without public trust that is sustained and renewed over 12 years and counting. That, too, in an environment brimming with rising aspirations and shifting engagements, impatient choices accelerated by disruptive technologies. But “sabka vishwas” is also a reminder of an unfinished journey, a challenge yet to be fully met. Be it finding a language to address the restlessness of the young, which has come to the fore in recent weeks because of a compromised examination system, or showing them the light of opportunity as headwinds batter the economy, or breaking a longer silence to assuage minority insecurities — a government that has made room for itself to reach out and do things that may even defy its own political script, needs to make the circle of trust more encompassing.

In many ways, the Modi government broke with a past that had congealed into the status quo and reaped the benefits. It put in place an architecture of welfare benefits that harnesses new technologies to streamline delivery, designed social safety nets — from health insurance to foodgrains — that have ensured stability even in times of great disruption like Covid-19. On the world stage, it has navigated a new, confident course for India in a time of war and flux and Trump tariffs. Politically, at home, it has shifted the centre of gravity to the right, while implementing its “core” commitments, from building the Ram temple to scrapping Article 370, to finding new flashpoints like “ghuspaithiya (illegal immigrant)” to keep the momentum going. Tired old favourites have been relegated, across sectors, from freeing the Padma awardees of darbaris — and there are many crowding that line — to the fading of old personnel and priorities. Twelve years on, however, it may be time for a reset. A politics of polarisation is rising, and the new elites nurse a permanent sense of grievance and, more disquietingly, a winner-takes-all policy. The government needs to send a message that it is open to talent, and that it will resist the reflex to label and domesticate it.

The crumbling of Opposition parties, one after another, in the BJP-dominant system, also speaks of shrinking spaces. Many of these parties — including the TMC — are beset by internal weaknesses. They are unable to withstand confrontation with an organised and fleet-footed adversary. And yet, a government that has won three terms must know that it will be judged not just by what it says and does, but also by whether or not it is listening. The government must talk to the people, of course, but it must also talk with their representatives across the aisle. Not to lure them across, but to engage them in conversation that helps redeem its pledge of sabka vishwas, as Nehru had put it, not wholly or in full measure, but very substantially.

Mind investor sensitivities please

OVER THE last few years there has been a flight of capital from India. Foreign portfolio investors took out \$14.6 billion from the equity markets in 2024-25, \$19.6 billion in 2025-26, and have so far this year withdrawn close to \$15.8 billion. Alongside, there has been a sharp decline in net foreign direct investments (FDI). While gross FDI flows have risen from \$80.6 billion in 2024-25 to \$94.5 billion in 2025-26, net FDI flows stood at just \$7.7 billion last year, up from an even lower \$1 billion the year before. The collapse in net FDI can be traced to higher repatriation and outward investments by Indian firms. Several explanations have been put forth to explain the trends in FDI flows and investor preferences for other jurisdictions. One explanation revolves around Bilateral Investment Treaties (BITs). India's BIT 2016 model has been criticised on grounds such as “narrow definitions” and “procedural barriers” like the five-year exhaustion of local remedies before initiating international arbitration (Rethinking India's Bilateral Investment Treaties, RIS Discussion Paper). Prior to the 2016 model, India had signed 83 BITs, of which 74 were ratified. Subsequently, termination notices were sent to 68 countries/regions till March 2023 with requests to renegotiate based on the new framework. However, since then, treaties have been signed with a few countries. The central government is now remodelling its BITs framework — in the Union budget 2025-26, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman proposed that the current model BIT be “revamped and made more investor-friendly”. As per a report in this paper, the key principles on which this centres are a minimum two-year period for local remedies prior to accessing international arbitration, no most-favoured nation clause, and an exclusion of tax-related provisions. At this critical juncture, the need to attract foreign capital cannot be emphasised enough. Legal certainty must be provided and existing frameworks should be simplified as procedural barriers will only dampen investor enthusiasm. An approach more mindful of investor sensitivities is called for.

Truth on aliens is out there — handle with care

THE MARTIANS invaded Earth in 1938, but most people weren't worried. The scale of the panic created by one of history's most famous hoaxes — Orson Welles's radio dramatisation of H G Wells's novel *The War of the Worlds*, partly presented as if it were a real news report of an alien invasion — has been exaggerated. Such a trick might be even tougher to pull off in today's connected world and atomised media environment. But it's also a world of fake news, deepfakes and old-fashioned mischief. If one were to call up an orange man and introduce oneself as a little green man, one may be able to negotiate a tariff exemption for Mars. It stands to reason, then, that the International Academy of Astronautics's updated guidance for researchers on how to deal with potential signals from extraterrestrial civilisations has been extra careful compared to the 2010 iteration. Information should be handled with “extreme care”, and “best practices and tools in science communication should be employed” to convey it to non-specialist audiences. It's cautious about social-media engagement, recognising the danger of researchers being troled. What policies might alien societies have for such an eventual-ity? It's impossible to tell — anthropomorphising what could be radically different forms of life would be a misguided effort. But perhaps, after taking a look at humanity in all its chaos, they'll echo one part of IAA guidelines: “Handle with extreme care.”

In age of AI, Pope returns to older concern: Technology, wealth, inequality



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

ARTIFICIAL intelligence (AI) begins to transform economies, an old argument from the industrial age is returning in a new form. A Pope, a socialist senator, a populist president, and a Silicon Valley mogul are all grappling with the same question: Who should own the wealth that AI is generating?

The issue has come into sharp policy focus as President Donald Trump plans to meet America's leading AI firms at the White House to discuss an idea that would once have seemed unthinkable — giving the American public a financial stake in the companies that are profiting most from the AI revolution.

Last week, Bernie Sanders, the lone socialist in the US Senate, proposed an American AI sovereign wealth fund financed by a one-time transfer of 50 per cent of shares from the largest AI companies. Late last month, Pope Leo XIV devoted the first encyclical of his pontificate to the ethical and social challenges posed by the unfolding AI revolution.

These are different men with contradictory ideologies shaping their worldviews. But they are revisiting one of the oldest ques-

tions of modern politics: Who benefits from technological change — capital or labour? How do we balance the creation of massive wealth by new technologies with the imperatives of economic and social equity?

It is fitting that a Pope named Leo should raise this old question about the new technological revolution. In 1891, Pope Leo XIII issued the encyclical *Rerum Novarum*, an important religious response to the rise of modern capitalism. Europe was then facing the full consequences of the Industrial Revolution. Factories had created immense wealth, but they had also produced social dislocation, inequality, and labour unrest. Socialist ideas that had gained ground since the mid-19th century were now acquiring a radical character.

Rejecting both unrestrained capitalism and revolutionary socialism, Leo XIII defended the dignity of labour, workers' right to organise, and capital's moral obligations. His encyclical became one of the foundations of modern Catholic social teaching.

One hundred and thirty-five years later, Leo XIV has deliberately invoked that legacy. His encyclical, *Magnifica Humanitas*, treats the AI revolution with the same ethical concern that Leo XIII accorded the industrial age. If the 19th century witnessed deepening tensions between capital and labour, the 21st, Leo XIV argues, confronts a new challenge: The relationship between human beings and the intelligent machines that threaten to take over their work.

AI without restraint, Leo XIV argues, could concentrate wealth and power in the hands of a few corpor-

Leo XIV returns to the concerns of Leo XIII. Technology creates wealth, but it also creates inequality. Politics has always been about managing the tension between the two

ations, widen inequality, and leave behind those who lack access to the new economy. The danger, in his view, is not merely technological but social — the exclusion of millions from the prosperity generated by the new machines.

These concerns are resonating in an America already anxious about the impact of AI on jobs. Major technology firms are cutting thousands of positions even as they pour billions of dollars into AI. Surveys suggest that many Americans fear that AI will shrink employment opportunities and deepen inequality. The American mood is grim: Workers are worried, and that anxiety is beginning to shape public debate.

It is interesting that some of the industry's leaders have moved in a similar direction to Sanders. OpenAI chief Sam Altman, who met Sanders last week, has been making the case for sharing the benefits of AI-generated prosperity. He has spoken of voluntary sharing of a percentage of stock, through which citizens might share in the wealth created by AI. The disagreement with Sanders is less about principle than about how far and how fast public ownership should go.

Trump says he is not opposed to Sanders's proposal. His populist political coalition has long overlapped with that of Sanders. Trump has said his administration is examining ways in which Americans might become “partners” in the AI boom. The mechanism under discussion is similar to Altman's ideas.

Not everyone in the US is impressed. Many tech giants are unenthusiastic. The Wall Street Journal has pilloried Trump for

pursuing the idea of the US government taking a stake in US tech companies. “Not long ago, it would have been hard to imagine a Republican president demanding government ownership in a private company, but here we are.” Many liberal American economists, too, recoil at the thought of the US government extorting money or shares from US corporations.

But a potential convergence and accommodation might be the AI story of the moment — the acknowledgement that the current revolution is too consequential to be left to the markets alone. The first and second industrial revolutions did not produce a social compact between capital and labour overnight. Decades of conflict gave rise to the Western welfare state.

The AI revolution may demand another such adjustment. The debate is no longer only about regulating AI for safety and international security. It is also about the distribution of wealth and power in the age of intelligent machines.

In that sense, Leo XIV returns to the concerns of Leo XIII. Technology creates wealth, but it also creates inequality. Politics has always been about managing the tension between the two. The story of AI may only be the latest chapter in modern society's enduring struggle: Finding a sustainable balance between the interests of capital and society.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is also a distinguished professor at the Motwani Jadaja Institute of American Studies, Jindal Global University, and holds the Korea Foundation Chair at the Council for Strategic and Defence Research, Delhi

4,399 days, the long arc of leadership



M VENKAIAH NAIDU

INDEPENDENT INDIA has seen 15 prime ministers from Jawaharlal Nehru to Narendra Damodardas Modi. They served the country in different socio-political and economic scenarios, addressing a variety of challenges to the best of their abilities. The saga of the present incumbent tells a unique story.

Today, on June 10, Narendra Modi became the elected PM with the longest continuous tenure — 4,399 days in office, surpassing Nehru's record. He has three more years to go in his term. The achievement is significant because it comes in an era of unprecedented political competition, coalition dynamics, 24-hour media scrutiny, and the rise of social media-driven public discourse.

Born to parents of modest means, Modi worked as a tea vendor in Vadnagar, Gujarat, assisting his father. To travel from there to the PM's office in South Block in the national capital is an extraordinary achievement.

His was a journey of self-realisation, of understanding Bharat, the people and their problems, envisioning the destiny of our country as “Swarnim Bharat” and striving for the realisation of this vision. His mind was primarily shaped by his early association with the RSS. For most of his life, he quietly went about discharging the duties assigned by the RSS, Jana Sangh and BJP at various levels. In the process, he acquired immense organisational abilities, clarity of thought, courage to dream of India's destiny and the ability to rise to the occasion when the call of duty knocked at his door.

At 51, Modi became the youngest Chief Minister of Gujarat. He demonstrated his abilities from day one, unleashing and channelising the entrepreneurial abilities and energies of the people of Gujarat. His 13-year, unbroken tenure as CM was eventful in several ways. The Gujarat model that emerged during his tenure captured the imagination of the people of the country. The people of Bharat yearned for a leader who could deliver. They found such a leader in Modi.

Modi led the NDA to victory in the 2014 Lok Sabha elections. For the first time, the BJP secured a majority on its own. I am glad to have been one of the senior leaders of the BJP who strongly pitched for Modi as PM. Modi repeated this stellar performance in

the next two elections in a row.

PM Modi believes that Bharat's transformation can't be realised without the people's participation. Swachh Bharat was made into a people's movement with the construction of over 12 crore individual household toilets; over 4 crore houses were built for the poor; over 57 crore bank accounts opened under JAN; Rs 45 lakh crore transferred to beneficiaries under DBT; LPG connections for over 10 crore women toiling in kitchens inhaling smoke. Over 24,000 crore digital transactions through UPI made our country the global leader in real-time digital payments; 80 crore people got food support during the Covid-19 pandemic and continue to get it. Modi's philosophy is “Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas”.

PM Modi pioneered human resource development with a massive expansion in educational and health institutions. IITs, IIITs, and AIIMS have increased manifold across the country. Ayushman Bharat is the world's largest publicly funded health programme.

PM Modi does not believe in stereotypes. Appeasement is not the right option. The abrogation of Article 370, abolition of triple talaq, introduction of GST reforms against much opposition, 33 per cent reservation for women in Parliament and state assemblies are clear pointers.

Modi has left an indelible impression on internal and national security. Left-wing extremism is almost wiped out. Surgical strikes and Operation Sindoor taught effective lessons to those casting an evil eye on us. Our foreign policy is no different. PM Modi made it clear that it will only be aligned with national interests and not individual countries. The voice of Bharat now matters at all global dialogue tables.

I observed PM Narendra Modi's thought processes and work for a few months after he assumed office in 2014, in order to assess his mission. I then publicly stated that MODI stands for “Making of Developed India”. After these 12 years, I have no hesitation in rechristening MODI as the “Man of Destiny for India”. That destiny is Swarnim Bharat. Bharat is safe and secure in his hands. I wish Narendra Damodardas Bharat Modi all the best in his endeavours.

The writer is the former Vice President of India



VANSHIKA VERMA

OUR PARENTS taught us not to trust strangers. Not to answer every question they asked. Not to give away our school's name, our address or family details casually. Not to let someone into the house if they could not account for themselves. That wisdom passed through generations, shaped by a simple instinct: Certain information, once given away, cannot be taken back.

I thought about that wisdom recently in a room full of people who would have agreed completely with it and then gone right back to scrolling. A friend of mine had just bought a smart ring. The recommendation came from his gym trainer. It tracked sleep, heart rate, recovery scores, activity levels, and stress indicators through skin temperature. Every morning, he checked his data, adjusted his training accordingly, and discussed the numbers with his trainer. Everyone in the room wanted one. So did I. A device that could optimise your life felt efficient, aspirational, and extremely cool. But when I asked where the data went, the room was silent for some seconds, then went indifferent. One friend wanted to know, “Who is going to look at my sleep data?” Another checked whether the ring came in different colours. My friend assumed the information stayed on the app.

My generation cannot simply be described as ignorant. We are educated, digitally fluent, and fully aware that privacy exists as both a concept and a right. But knowing privacy exists and knowing how to practice it as a dynamic right are two different things. The strangers our parents warned us about are no longer behind the gate. They sit behind a permission screen, a cloud server or an app that promises to make life easier. They do not knock. They simply wait for us to click “agree”.

The data we give away is not trivial. Every OTP, KYC submission, Aadhaar-linked verification and food-delivery profile becomes part of an intimate portrait of who we are. India is not without a legal response: The Supreme Court has recognised privacy as a fundamental right, and the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, and the Rules framed under it, now establish a framework around consent, notice, and user rights. But what is the use of privacy being a fundamental right if we treat it as an irritation?

We need to explore models where children are taught from a young age that data privacy principles must be practised before they learn how to be online. Legislatures, policymakers, institutions, parents, and users share this responsibility.

Privacy has a serious image problem. It is often described as something technical, legal, or distant, when in reality it is deeply personal. Making it feel as important as it truly is will require curriculum, conversation, media literacy, and a greater willingness from companies to be accountable for the systems they build, presenting them in a transparent and understandable manner to the very generations their marketing seeks to attract.

The challenge is not learning how to use technology. It is learning how to live with it, to grow alongside it rather than simply surrender to it, to enjoy its benefits while understanding its costs, and to ask better questions before we click “agree”.

The writer is a final-year B.A. LL.B. student at Symbiosis Law School, Noida

40 YEARS AGO June 10, 1986



Punjab-Haryana row

IN SPITE of best efforts by the Centre, both at political as well as official level, there could be no settlement between the chief ministers of Punjab and Haryana on various issues connected with the territorial transfer on June 21. The Central leadership was keen that both the States should come to some settlement before the Venkataramah Commission gives its report on June 10. The Congress (I) vice-president, Arjun Singh, had been holding talks with the Chief Ministers of the two States, Bansi Lal of Haryana and Surjit Singh Barnala of Punjab. The Congress (I) vice-president, Mr Arjun Singh, had been holding talks with the Chief Ministers of the two States.

Chavan, Hegde meet tomorrow

THE CHIEF Ministers of Maharashtra and Karnataka will meet in Bangalore in an attempt to defuse the situation in the disputed border areas rocked by violence for the past nine days resulting in the loss of six lives besides injuries to scores of others. The meeting between the Chief Ministers comes after hectic political consultations in the past few days between the senior leaders of different political parties in Bombay, Bangalore and Delhi.

Revolt brewing

A REVOLT is brewing in the Haryana Congress (I) ranks over what is considered a rather raw deal handed out to the state on

the territorial issue ignoring its claims to the Hindi-speaking areas of Ambala and Fazilka. There is a strong possibility of some legislators resigning at the time of the announcement of recommendations of the Venkataramah Commission and transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab.

12 held for spying

THE TAMIL Nadu police arrested about a dozen people on charges of spying. The arrested persons included some foreigners also who were masquerading as Sri Lankan militants. The police are investigating the involvement of a number of local people in the spying activities, on the confession of the arrested persons.

● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
Mainstream politicians should remember, in the battle to defeat Jordan Bardella or Marine Le Pen, unity is strength — *The Guardian*



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Modi milestone is affirmation of strength and openness of Indian democracy



NITISH KUMAR

IN A democracy as large and competitive as India's, public trust is hard to earn and even harder to sustain. Yet, despite constant political contestation and intense public scrutiny, Narendra Modi has continued to enjoy the confidence of the people. By becoming India's longest continuously serving elected prime minister, he has set a new benchmark in democratic politics. Although we come from different parts of India, PM Modi and I belong to a generation whose political consciousness was shaped by the Emergency. We witnessed first-hand the assault on democratic freedoms and participated in the movement that sought to restore them. That struggle was not merely a political event but a formative experience that shaped our understanding of public life and democratic values.

For decades, there was a perception that the highest offices were reserved for a privileged few or those born into influential political families. PM Modi's journey has challenged that notion. Rising from humble beginnings to occupy the highest elected office, he has become a source of inspiration for millions of young Indians, especially those from modest backgrounds. His story reinforces the belief that in a vibrant democracy, determination, hard work, and ability can overcome barriers of birth and circumstance. This milestone is also a powerful affirmation of the strength and openness of Indian democracy.

As a follower of Dr Ram Manohar Lohia, Loknayak Jayaprakash Narayan and many other great socialist leaders, I have always viewed politics as a means to ensure the welfare of the people. Helping people rise above poverty and live a life of dignity should be the highest priority of any political leader. In this respect, PM Modi has an impressive record. With his sharp focus on poverty eradication, the NDA government has helped bring 25 crore people out of poverty. Toilets, bank accounts, houses, gas connections, tap water, health insurance coverage and many other basic necessities have reached crores of

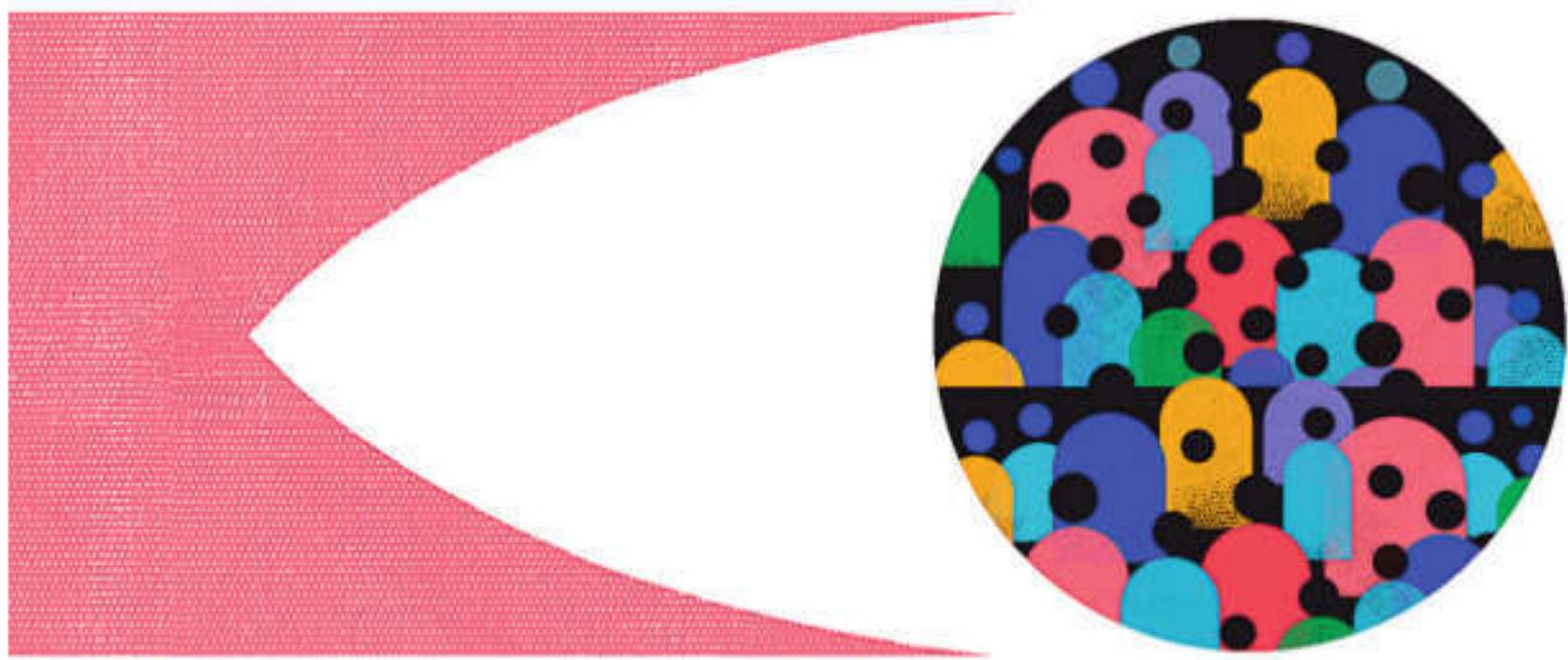


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

people. Large sections of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, backward classes, extremely backward classes, women, poor families and first-generation beneficiaries of development programmes have now begun to see themselves as active participants in India's growth story. Youth have found new entrepreneurship opportunities through special schemes. Bringing these groups into the mainstream of national development has been the most important catalyst in ensuring social justice.

I have also seen the emphasis PM Modi has placed on women's welfare and dignity. Many of his schemes have directly benefited women and reduced hardships in their daily lives. It has been my experience in Bihar that when women are at the centre of development efforts, society progresses faster. Little wonder that the successes of our Jeevika experiment in Bihar are now spoken about globally.

Having served as chief minister for many years, I know the challenges associated with ensuring that benefits reach the intended beneficiary. Good intentions alone are not enough. Effective implementation is important. I have also seen how the ability to convert policy decisions into results requires constant monitoring, reforms, administrative focus and attention to detail. A defining feature of PM Modi's leadership has been his emphasis on ensuring that governance translates into tangible outcomes for citizens. He has consistently focused on efficiency, transparency and accountability. Through the extensive use of technology, direct benefit transfers and robust moni-

toring mechanisms, the gap between policy formulation and implementation has been significantly reduced. As government benefits reach people more effectively and with fewer leakages, public trust in institutions is strengthened. This trust is further reinforced by the PM's continuous engagement with citizens, helping foster a stronger connection between the government and the people.

PM Modi's political trajectory includes a long and successful stint as CM of Gujarat. In fact, he will soon complete 25 years of continuous service at the helm of an elected government. This experience at the state and national levels has given him a deep understanding of the needs of states. His tenure as PM has been marked by a strong commitment to cooperative federalism. During my tenure as CM, I personally experienced his support for the development of Bihar, irrespective of political circumstances. I am especially inclined to mention the stupendous support that Bihar got during the 2024-25 and 2025-26 budgets, including the establishment of the Makhana Board and the power plant in Bhagalpur, and funds for management of floods and a host of infrastructure projects.

PM Modi has great respect for the unique culture and traditions of Bihar. He has showcased Bihar's heritage on the global stage by gifting makhana, Madhubani paintings and other products from the state to international dignitaries. He ensured that Jannayak Karpoori Thakur was conferred the Bharat Ratna, a long-pending demand that was unfulfilled for decades. Compared to the decade before 2014, support and investment

His story reinforces the belief that in a vibrant democracy, determination, hard work, and ability can overcome barriers of birth and circumstance

from the Centre have increased significantly. The construction of important bridges across the Ganga, the expansion of national highways, the development of airports, and rapid upgrades in railway infrastructure are helping drive Bihar's growth. Particularly commendable is the transformation taking place in railway infrastructure, something that has always been close to my heart. The introduction of new trains, such as Vande Bharat, has improved the ease of travel. Railway electrification and other modernisation projects have gathered remarkable momentum under PM Modi.

I have always practised and supported zero tolerance for corruption. One of the qualities that endears PM Modi to the people is his firm stance against corruption. It is rare to see leaders who have spent decades in positions of power without a single stain on their integrity. Along with curbing avenues for corruption through institutional reforms, he has also demonstrated the political will to pursue cases against corrupt politicians and officials through the legal process.

A notable aspect of PM Modi's tenure has been the way India has gained greater weight on the global stage. As an Indian, it makes me proud to see our voice being welcomed with respect in matters relating to the economy, climate change, technology, health or cooperation. While maintaining strong relations with different countries and groups, PM Modi has consistently stood for peace and progress. As a result, the world increasingly looks towards our nation with hope as a major driver of global growth in the 21st century.

Having spent many decades in public life, I know that leadership demands continuous effort, relentless hard work and discipline. It requires constant travel, regular engagement with people, detailed review of government work, and, at the same time, the ability to remain connected to a larger vision. PM Modi's tireless energy and dedication have helped him retain the confidence of the people for such a long time. As he becomes the longest continuously serving elected PM of India, it is an occasion to celebrate PM Modi's contribution to public life and wish him many more milestones ahead. I congratulate him on this historic achievement and wish him good health and continued success in serving the nation.

The writer is a Rajya Sabha MP and former chief minister of Bihar

There is a barrier to peace — and it is not Iran



MANAV SACHDEVA

MORE THAN 100 days into the conflict in West Asia, the dominant assumption is that Iran remains the main obstacle to regional peace. Yet the events of the recent past suggest a more uncomfortable possibility. The greatest obstacle to an off-ramp may not be Tehran at all, but Benjamin Netanyahu. The conventional narrative portrays him as a leader seeking ever-greater security guarantees before accepting peace. But, his "eternal war" approach may not be the pathway to peace; it may be the mechanism by which peace is indefinitely deferred. A genuine settlement would reopen questions that war postpones. It would bring renewed attention to accountability, coalition instability, and the legal challenges that have shadowed Netanyahu's premiership for years.

This is not unique to Israel. History is filled with leaders who discovered that the end of conflict posed greater risks to their political future than its continuation. But the consequences today extend far beyond Israel's borders. The Palestinian, Lebanese, Iranian, and Gulf Arab populations alike find themselves trapped within a conflict whose continuation threatens lives and livelihoods. The world economy is reeling, and India, too, is not insulated from the economic fallout.

The irony is that the US may ac-

A limited US-Iran accommodation may serve both their interests. But for Netanyahu, it would reduce the centrality of the Iranian threat in his politics

tually have a plausible off-ramp. Donald Trump, despite his reputation as a disruptor, is temperamentally well-suited to declaring victory and moving on. The substance matters less than the narrative. A diplomatic arrangement that caps enrichment, reduces tensions in the Gulf, and lowers the risk of direct confrontation could easily be presented as a triumph. Maritime guarantees could be framed as evidence of American strength. Whether such claims would fully reflect reality is beside the point. Political narratives are rarely judged by their precision.

A limited US-Iran accommodation may serve both their interests. But for Netanyahu, it would reduce the centrality of the Iranian threat in his politics, constraining Israel's freedom of military action. It would weaken the claim that permanent emergency is the only viable framework for the region. This is why the concept of the spoiler matters. Spoilers fear the consequences of peace more than those of continued conflict.

They do not necessarily oppose negotiations. Instead, they introduce new conditions, expand objectives, question timing, or create new realities that make compromise harder. The spoiler does not need to defeat peace. It merely needs to ensure that peace never quite arrives.

There was a reason successive US

administrations approached direct confrontation with Iran cautiously. Iran is not Iraq or Libya. It sits at the centre of a web of maritime routes, energy corridors and proxy networks that extend far beyond its borders. The Strait of Hormuz remains one of the most consequential chokepoints in the world economy. Escalation rarely remains local. Once the hornet's nest is disturbed, nobody controls the direction of the swarm. Each round of escalation creates pressure for another.

Yet the incentives facing key actors increasingly point in the opposite direction. Political careers and coalitions depend on conflict. In such an environment, peace becomes a threat. The path forward requires more than just diplomacy. It needs the incentives that make perpetual conflict politically useful to be changed. Escalation must become costlier than restraint, and political survival must be separated from permanent crisis. That is a difficult task. It offers no breakthrough and no guarantee of success. And it begins by acknowledging an uncomfortable possibility: The principal obstacle to peace may no longer be the side everyone assumes. Sometimes, the greatest barrier to an off-ramp is not the adversary across the table, but the ally standing beside you. And with friends like these, who needs enemies?

The writer is a diplomat and former UN aid worker



NEERAJ BUNKAR AND DHEERAJ RAYALU TADI

PEDDI OPENS with Boman Irani, who, over the next three hours, will try to unravel a story buried in the depths of India's sporting saga. What follows is the grand introduction of the film's eponymous protagonist, accompanied by heaps of praise that border on religious fervour. This formulaic opening marks *Peddi*, a fresh addition to the growing line of caste-conscious Telugu cinema. The story revolves around Peddi and the hardships that shape him into a crossover athlete for the larger benefit of his community.

The film falls into a familiar trap of message-driven Telugu cinema: It shines a light

on social issues but ultimately weakens the very cause it seeks to champion. Its foundational idea is the treatment of Peddi's community, whose characteristics are loosely based on generic representations of Dalit and tribal communities. Telugu "social change" films often capitalise on sympathy generated through depictions of poverty and ostracism while avoiding any specific social identity. This prevents the film from engaging with caste oppression in concrete terms.

As the narrative unfolds, a familiar figure emerges: The Herculean hero destined to save his community through seemingly supernatural abilities despite generations of deprivation affecting nutrition, education, and social opportunity. The feudal ghost of Telugu cinema remains intact. The saviour narrative survives; only the identity of the saviour has changed. Social justice once

again becomes dependent on an exceptional individual rather than a collective struggle. Sports cinema has repeatedly shown how athletic achievement can challenge social barriers. Figures such as Muhammad Ali, Jackie Robinson, and Palwankar Baloo transformed sport into a site of resistance. Yet, *Peddi* uses the protagonist's athletic range primarily to elevate him into a larger-than-life figure. As a result, it becomes difficult to invest emotionally in his journey.

The film's understanding of marginal-

'Peddi' uses the protagonist's athletic range primarily to elevate him into a larger-than-life figure. As a result, it becomes difficult to invest emotionally in his journey

ised identities also remains limited. Criticism rightly emerged over Janhvi Kapoor's character being framed largely through asexualised lens and the justification of Peddi's non-consensual behaviour as a rustic form of romance. Instead of challenging stereotypes, it reinforces the notion that marginalised people require (re)finement by supposedly more "civilised" social groups.

Equally troubling is the "labour as training" arc borrowed from classic sports dramas. Peddi's labour-intensive tasks — already associated with his social identity — are later (re)framed as athletic training, while "upper-caste" wrestlers undergo no comparable process. In another context, such scenes might symbolise discipline or humility. Here, however, they risk normalising unequal treatment and reducing structural exploitation to character-building.

As individuals from marginalised communities, we strongly support marginalised heroes. The film's greatest weakness is its inability to translate genuine emotions to the audience. Even as filmmakers recognise the importance and commercial value of marginalised storytelling, many narratives remain trapped within feudal structures. What resonates is not the invincible hero but the vulnerable one whose life is constantly at risk for even the smallest act of rebellion. *Peddi* is a well-intentioned step forward in storytelling of the marginalised, but it ultimately undermines its own message through misogyny, an overpowered protagonist, and a hollow understanding of social justice.

Bunkar is a researcher specialising in caste and cinema, and Tadi is a researcher with interests in psychology, caste, cinema, and philosophy

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Dignified marriage

A COUPLE living separately for 15 years clearly indicates that the marital relationship has ceased to exist in substance, even if it continues legally on paper ('In law, need to write a new marriage story', *IE*, June 9). Prolonged litigation and the forced continuation of such marriages often lead to emotional distress, financial burdens, and social complications for both parties. While the Supreme Court can grant relief by invoking its constitutional powers, ordinary courts do not possess the same authority. There is a strong need to amend the Hindu Marriage Act to include irretrievable breakdown of marriage as an independent ground for divorce.

Bal Govind, Noida

THE SC has rightly observed that it is unfair to force a couple to remain married when the marriage has effectively been dead for years ('In law, need to write a new marriage story', *IE*, June 9). The Court has advocated a provision under which couples may separate if a marriage has irretrievably broken down and there is no reasonable prospect of reconciliation. Any such legislation must also safeguard women's rights relating to maintenance, property, residence, and child custody.

Veda Chidanand, Bengaluru

French Open win

ZVEREV'S CASE illustrates a pattern that Indian tennis would do well to observe ('When the Grand Slam crown isn't enough', *IE*, June 9). Domestic talent that consistently reaches the highest levels of international competition often continues to face perception gaps that results alone cannot bridge. For India, the lesson is that developing elite players takes sustained investment. Reaching the quarterfinals or semifinals of a Grand Slam should be seen as a significant national achievement, not a footnote to someone else's victory.

Prajesh Paramasivan, Neelambur

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express, and has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of How Prime Ministers Decide

The Big Picture

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 10, 2026

AN UNLIKELY FRIENDSHIP

Two men and a phone call

Kaise ho aap?

The calls started a year ago, soon after Savdhanbhai lost his son Kamlesh and daughter-in-law Dhapuben in the June 12, 2025, Air India crash that killed 241 passengers. Every day since then, Savdhanbhai has got a call or a text message – from Kamlesh's Pakistani co-worker in London.

RITU SHARMA on the grief and the conversations that hold them together

AIR INDIA CRASH
a year later

"Kaise ho aap, theek ho?"

For the last one year, that's how almost every voice text, every call from Omar Ali to Savdhanbhai Chaudhary has begun.

It's a daily reassurance Savdhanbhai and his wife Ratniben have hung on to since June 12, 2025, when the Ahmedabad-Gatwick Boeing 787 Dreamliner carrying their elder son Kamlesh and his bride Dhapuben crashed minutes after takeoff, killing 241 of the 242 passengers on board.

Over the grief-stricken days that followed, 40-year-old Omar Ali, Kamlesh's Pakistani co-worker at a fancy goods store in London, and Savdhanbhai, a 48-year-old farmer in Thavar, a village in Gujarat's Banaskantha district, struck an unlikely bond.

Every day on his way to work, Omar Ali would call Savdhanbhai to talk — regular, everyday conversations about the weather, Savdhanbhai's infected toe nail, the cluster beans he had eaten for lunch ("guar... what is it, what does it look like?"), Omar's clean-shaven look. The calls and text messages have come without fail, every single day.

"Hamein zara sa nakhoon me bhi dard hota hai toh Omar poochta hai (Omar calls and asks even if I have a small pain in my toe nail). And if someone is unwell at his home, even if it is a fever, we get to know," says Savdhanbhai.

Speaking from London, Omar says, "Tal-ways tell Savdhanbhai, God made our relationship possible; Kamlesh was the medium for that to happen. I never thought I would be so close to this family. Mere dil ko sukoon sa milta hai inse bat karke aur tassalli de kar (I find peace of mind and comfort talking to them and reassuring them)."

When it all came crashing down

Six months ago, when *The Indian Express* visited Savdhanbhai at his home in Thavar, he had pulled out a 30-second video on his phone. Shot from outside Ahmedabad's Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport on June 12, it showed Kamlesh and Dhapuben at the entry gate. Dhapuben, 26, dressed in a traditional skirt, with a bright pink *odhani* covering her head and face, and Kamlesh, 26, wearing a T-shirt and jeans.

"We had gone to drop them off. I rarely take videos but don't know why I took one that day. Maybe because I thought I should record my *bahu's* first flight," Savdhanbhai had said.

That was Savdhanbhai and Ratniben's first visit to Ahmedabad. They had travelled over a 100 km and had reached Unjha in Mehsana district on their way back, when they learnt about the crash. They turned the car around and sped to Ahmedabad, praying and hoping that their children would somehow make it alive.

Kamlesh and Dhapuben were among the 241 who died as the plane crashed into the B.J Medical College mess building, minutes after takeoff.

Kamlesh, who had been in London since September 2022, came home to Banaskantha for his wedding on November 22, 2024. He had left for London soon after and returned a few months later to take Dhapuben with him.

The family says Kamlesh got a work visa two years ago and had hoped to start a small business in five years. He wanted to take his younger brother Hitesh, 23, a Master's student in agriculture business management from Banaskantha, along with him. "Now even the thought of that sends shivers down our spines," Kamlesh's maternal uncle Devkaran Chaudhary said.

On January 6 this year, Savdhanbhai and his nephew Ishwar Chaudhary made another trip to Ahmedabad, travelling five hours from their village to a hotel in the city. Here, Air India had set up a Family Returns Centre, where relatives of the 241 passengers could collect the personal belongings of their loved ones retrieved from the crash site.

Inside the cavernous hotel room, Savdhanbhai had "wept like a child" as he held a few transparent ziplock bags in his cupped palms. Inside one of them was his son Kamlesh's charred wedding album. The other held a desktop calendar with a photograph of the newly-weds. "Two souls with a single thought, two hearts that beat as one", it read, with the couple's photographs on each of its 12 pages. The other bags had their PAN cards, Aadhaar, voter cards, marriage certificates — all charred or singed yellowed.

"I was holding on to the last things Kamlesh touched. I want to keep these with me forever," Savdhanbhai had told *The Indian Express*.

With the bodies, Ratniben says, they were handed over Dhapuben's *payal* and an earring and some pieces of Kamlesh's T-shirt, packed in a box. On the portal that Air India had set up for the 'unassociated items' (personal belongings recovered from the crash site that hadn't been traced to any of the passengers), the family could identify a gold locket which Ratniben had bought Dhapuben a day before they were flying, two *kalash* (urns) and a silver coin with an engraving of Lord Shiva. "The Air India staff came to hand over the kalash sometime in March. We were asked to produce proof that the other items were ours. How could we? So we let it be," Ratniben says.

Savdhanbhai says their lives "ended" the day their elder son and his bride died. But a sequel was to follow.

For a year now, he and Ratniben now eagerly await a daily routine — a 3 pm call from Omar. Kamlesh's boss Angat Singh, an Afghan Sikh who goes by the name "Tannibhai", had deputed Omar to call the Chaudharys and ask after them.

Since then, Omar, who would call his parents in Lahore every day as he left home for



SOURCE: OMAR ALI



BHUPENDRA RANA

Their initial calls were short. Savdhanbhai would struggle with his Hindi, slipping into Gujarati ever so often, while Omar held on patiently — the father's loss didn't need a language

work, has called Kamlesh's parents instead.

Their initial calls were short. Savdhanbhai would struggle with his Hindi, slipping into Gujarati ever so often, while Omar held on patiently — the father's loss didn't need a language.

The daily calls, messages

Omar says Kamlesh and he weren't exactly close. They were colleagues at the store — Omar, the most senior of Tannibhai's employees, worked as the sales manager while Kamlesh handled another section in the store.

But the moment he heard about the Air India crash and that Kamlesh and Dhapuben were among the dead, something stirred. "I felt a strong grief *aur main dahade mar kar roya* (I cried out loud). The entire staff came running towards me and tried to console me," he says.

On Tannibhai's directions, Omar took Savdhanbhai's number from Kamlesh's roommate Dixit Patel and tried calling him. He got through a couple of days later. "I still remember his words. '*Mera beta chala gaya*.' I knew he was crying on the other end. I didn't know what to say and mumbled something about '*apka beta aur hamara bhai chala gaya* (your son and my brother... he is no more). I told him to stay strong and assured him I would call again."

Thus began a tradition touching in its simplicity — a call between two men, asking if the other was doing alright.

"Savdhanbhai and his family are very innocent. I told him that my parents are no more; this is a relationship from God's side. I once told him that when I used to call my parents, they would never be the first to disconnect the call. They would say '*Allah hafiz, bye bye*', but wait for me to hang up. Savdhanbhai does the same now. We talk every day, sometimes briefly due to work or other constraints, but we connect every day in some form," says Omar.



BHUPENDRA RANA

The youngest of ten siblings, Omar lost his brother and father within a month of each other in 2022, followed by his mother's death the following year. "I was not very close to my parents because of our age gap. Savdhanbhai is not much older; in fact I am closer in age to Savdhanbhai than to Kamlesh. Kamlesh used to say his father felt more like a friend. Maybe that's how I feel towards Savdhanbhai now," he says, talking of a relationship that he struggles to define.

Does he feel a son's responsibility towards Savdhanbhai? A friend's? Hard to say, he says. Perhaps, it's a bond best left untaged. Like most good relationships, theirs grew slowly, sustained by the daily calls and WhatsApp messages. For the first few months, Omar showed up every single day,

before Savdhanbhai began reciprocating. "Gradually, the relationship grew. Now I pour my heart out to him. He also shares everything about Kamlesh's mother, brother Hitesh, Kamlesh's in-laws. When I see him in pain, I feel terrible — he has already gone through so much trauma. How much can a man suffer?" says Omar.

The two share the occasional video call, and photographs — of Omar's life in London, with his wife and two children, of Savdhanbhai's fields with freshly sowed musk melon, chillies and lady's fingers, of Kamlesh and Dhapuben from their wedding album. Even Savdhanbhai's *thali* with *bajri roti* and *guar sabzi*. "He asked me what we had for lunch today and I told him *guar*. He didn't know what that was, so I sent him

(Clockwise from top) Kamlesh, in the centre, with storeowner Tannibhai (on the left) and Omar Ali (right) before Kamlesh's last trip home; Savdhanbhai and Ratniben at their home in Thavar village; Kamlesh's charred wedding album recovered from the crash site

a photo," says Savdhanbhai, whose eyes alternate between welling up when he talks of Kamlesh and Dhapuben, and crinkling into a smile at the mention of Omar.

The day in March, when Omar shaved his beard for the first time, he came on a video call with Savdhanbhai. "I told Omarbhai, '*Aap bahut achhe lag rahe ho, aap ko kisi ki nazarna lage* (You look good, God bless you),' he says.

Since Kamlesh's death, Samadhanbhai and Ratniben have decided to lead their lives just the way their son would have wanted. "Before Kamlesh left, he had promised to buy us a car on Diwali. From the money we got as compensation, we bought a car last Diwali, just as he wished," says Savdhanbhai. The white SUV now stands parked outside their house, under a tin roof.

Savdhanbhai also used a part of the compensation he got — Rs 25 lakh as interim relief, Rs 1 crore ex-gratia through the Tata Trust, and Rs 4 lakh from the Gujarat CM Relief Fund — to repay the Rs 55 lakh that he had borrowed from his family and friends to send Kamlesh to London in 2022.

"Kamlesh would keep telling me to think differently. That is how, two months ago, I started growing muskmelon on a part of our 10-*bigha* land where we grow mustard and castor. Recently, we tried red chillies. I researched and found out that the seeds of pumpkin and muskmelon fetch a higher value than the fruits themselves. All this keeps me busy, it's just a way of staying distracted. We also sold three of our five buffaloes and nine of our 10 cows; Kamlesh always said it was too much of a burden for us," says Savdhanbhai, his eyes brimming up again.

Each of these decisions have come after a call to Omar. "I discuss everything with him. Say, if I have to sow a new crop, I talk

The moment he heard about the crash, something stirred. "I felt a strong grief *aur main dahade mar kar roya* (I cried out loud)," says Omar

to him about my plans before I go ahead. He doesn't really know much about farming, but tells me, 'Go ahead, if you do it, it will be good. *Khuda apko barkat dega* (God will bless prosperity on you). I showed him pictures and videos of the chilli, muskmelon, and watermelon I sowed," says Savdhanbhai.

Last month, Savdhanbhai couriered a 10-kg packet to Omar's London address — homemade ghee, digestive *churan* and two packets of dry *kachori* for Omar's wife Sa-meena. Just the way he would for Kamlesh.

"Omarbhai asked me how much I had spent on the courier and I said, '*Apne rishte ke kitne paise hain* (Can you put a price on our relationship)?' Poor Omar, he could not reply. After that he has never mentioned money," he smiles.

A few months ago, Omar sent a blazer and a shirt for Kamlesh's younger brother Hitesh, and a sweater for his mother Ratniben.

These days, Savdhanbhai, who dropped out of school after Class 11, sends messages in English too. "I have learnt to translate text. I translate from Gujarati to English first, then translate it back to Gujarati to ensure there are no errors before I send them to Omar and his family," he says.

One of the messages he wrote to Omar in English reads, "I was in a noisy place when you called, so I regret not picking up the phone. I went to do some necessary work. You will be fine, Thank you," with a folded-hands emoji.

With Kamlesh gone, Savdhanbhai's phone is his keeper of memories. Of the many text messages he holds close to his heart are those he exchanged with Tannibhai, Kamlesh's employer in London.

One of these, written by Tannibhai in Gujarati using Google Translate, reads, "*Tume kem cho? Kamlesh na bhai kem che? Badhu theek chali rahiye chhe ne* (How are you? How is Kamlesh's brother? Is everything going well)?"

For the last 12 months, Tannibhai has been transferring Rs 50,000 to Savdhanbhai's account — a quiet gesture for a "hardworking and honest boy and his family".

Speaking to *The Indian Express* from London, Tannibhai says, "I have also created a fundraising page where we have raised £2,800 from my family and friends. I have not shared this with Savdhanbhai yet, but I plan to send this amount to him either for Hitesh's wedding or when I am not able to support them monthly."

A year since the loss

On June 12, the anniversary of the tragedy, Savdhanbhai, Ratniben and the rest of the family plan to visit the crash site in Ahmedabad.

Savdhanbhai says, "Sometimes, I wake up in the middle of the night, think of Kamlesh and Dhapuben and feel so helpless. We are farmers; we never thought our son would go abroad. Before leaving, he had told us he would take us to London once. Big dreams... all shattered now," he says, unlocking his phone to show a few videos of Kamlesh that Omar has edited and sent, with instructions on how to upload them as his WhatsApp status on June 12.

One of these videos has a photo of Kamlesh and Dhapuben, accompanied by a voiceover that says, "Beautiful memories are all we have left, they will stay with us for a lifetime, rest in peace". Another is a montage of stills — Kamlesh striking poses, and one with Dhapuben. In the background is a song from the Bollywood film *Border*, a plea to the wind to find a loved one, "*Aye guzarne wali hawa bata/ Mera itna kam karegi kya/ Mujhe chhod ke jo chala gaya/ Use dhondh la...*"

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• DEMOGRAPHY

Across world, why fewer people are having children



RISHIKA SINGH

A FINANCIAL INCENTIVE of Rs 30,000 for a couple upon the birth of their third child. More state-funded IVF attempts for first-time parents. A plan to orient around 300,000 units of public housing towards households raising children.

These are just some of the many policies introduced by governments across the world in recent years to encourage child-bearing. Last month, Andhra Pradesh became one of the first Indian states to announce payments for having more than two children. Sweden and Japan have also proposed various solutions to the common concern of demographic decline.

In some ways, the transition has been expected. Many societies see smaller population increases over time, owing to improvements in health, education and economic indicators. But the pace and scope of this transition are unexpected.

Rapid TFR decline

Among the most important figures in population growth is the total fertility rate, or TFR. It is the average number of children that a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime. A “replacement rate” of 2.1, that is, an average of two children per woman to replace the mother and father, is considered ideal to ensure population stability.

As of 2023, in over two-thirds of the total global population, TFRs were below 2.1.

From a global average of 5.3 in the early 1960s, TFR stood at 2.2 in 2024 — just above the replacement rate. In this period, the TFR in India declined from 5.9 to 2 — just below the replacement rate. Announcements like Andhra’s mark a reversal from a few generations ago, when the population boom was among the biggest crises for the nation and family planning policies were introduced.

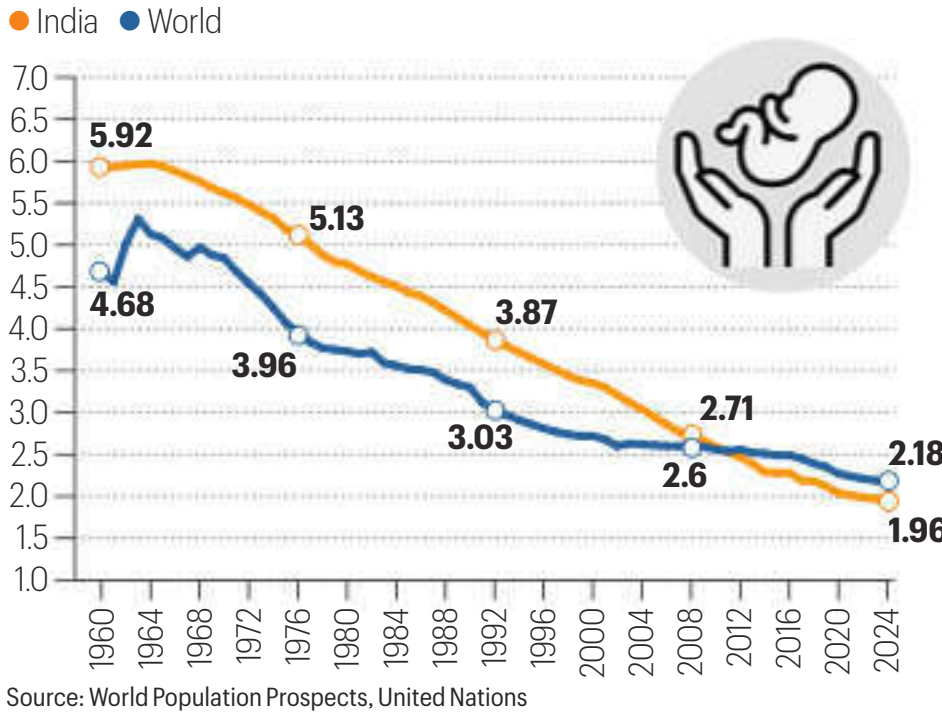
Moradhvaj Dhakad, a scientist and Marie Curie Research Fellow at the Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research in Rostock, Germany, told *The Indian Express*: “The decline has happened much faster than UN projections from around a decade ago, which expected TFR to fall to under 2.1 between 2030 and 2035, but India achieved this level around 2020.”

Many drivers

According to the demographic transition theory, as societies move from low economic growth and education levels to prosperity,

• Fertility rates in freefall

The total fertility rate (TFR), the average number of children that a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime, has declined across the world and in India.



Source: World Population Prospects, United Nations

both birth and death rates fall, with little overall change in population as a result. But the widespread shift in just a few decades has prompted the search for other factors.

Income is often a starting point. Martin Kolk, an Associate Professor at the Stockholm University Demography Unit and Department of Sociology, told *The Indian Express* that in the past, people with smaller incomes had more children in many countries. “It now appears that in more and more contexts, people with higher incomes are actually having more children, including rich East Asian societies such as Japan (TFR 1.1) and South Korea (TFR 0.7, among the lowest globally). It’s the richest individuals who have more children, but in middle-income countries, you often see the reverse pattern still,” he said.

Dhakad also chalked this up to urbanisation, which has raised living costs. Women’s increased educational attainments, participation in the workforce and ability to make reproductive decisions also matter. In sub-Saharan Africa, with TFRs as high as 4 and 5, high levels of teen pregnancies have been attributed to limited use of contraception, low education levels and early marriages.

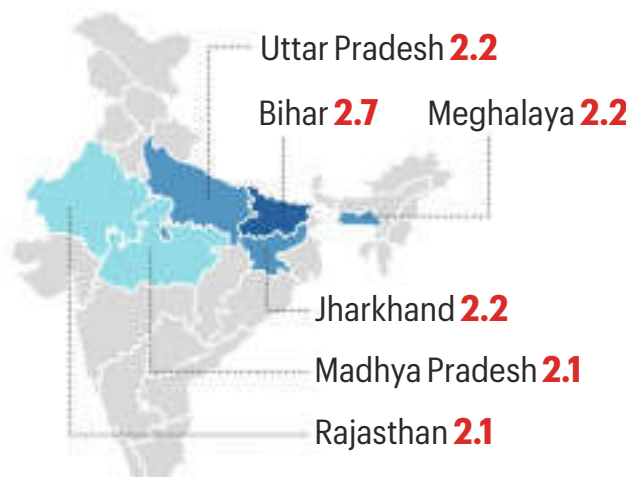
The endurance of traditional gender roles means that women end up shouldering domestic responsibilities in addition to working towards their career aspirations, and many then choose not to have children, or have fewer children. While India has a low share of women in the workforce, strides in health and education could have played a role, Dhakad said.

“Government population control cam-



• In most states, fertility below replacement level

The map shows the only states with TFR at or above ‘replacement level’ (2.1 children per woman). This is the level needed to maintain a stable population



Source: National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6), 2023-24

paigns such as *hum do, hamaare do* further spread family planning messaging even among the less educated groups, and in rural areas. Moreover, it has been found that development is the best contraception... Parents realise that they do not need to have more children to ensure their survival into adulthood,” he said.

Still, these factors do not tell the whole story of countries such as Sweden (with a TFR of 1.4), which are rich and have substantial state support for women after childbirth, alongside men making larger contributions to domestic responsibilities.

Kolk said these policies have helped prevent an even steeper decline in TFR: “In the Nordics, fertility has decreased from high to moderate levels and in southern Europe, it has fallen from low to very low levels. In these different contexts, the explanation is likely related to pro-family policy.” “But if we want to understand why fertility is falling in basically all countries from 2010 and 2015 to 2025 — both in systems with more and less generous family policy — cultural reasons are probably more important... people prioritise childbearing less,” he said.

Australian demographer Peter McDonald has argued that two major trends can be traced back to the second half of the 20th century. The first was a rise in social liberalism, marked by individuals re-examining social norms, choosing what suited them and focusing on individual aspirations. The other was the withdrawal of the welfare state in many Western economies. One byproduct of these trends was that having children was no longer a mandate for living a good life.

Preparing for the transition

By 2050, the proportion of elderly persons in India is expected to increase to 20.8% of population, that is around 34.7 crore.

This would necessitate the need to invest in healthcare, social support and care infrastructure.

• POLITICS

Can a political party use cockroach as symbol? What EC rules say

Damini Nath

New Delhi, June 9

EVER SINCE Chief Justice of India Surya Kant’s “cockroach” remark, the image of the insect has come to be used by those protesting against the statement as well as the satirical Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

CJP is not a political party but a “youth pressure group”, according to its founder Abhijeet Dipke. Dipke has not ruled out applying for registration as a political party with the Election Commission (EC) in the future, but for now, the group has an online presence and held its first protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on June 6.

Even if the CJP, or any other group for that matter, were to register as a party and apply for the cockroach as its election symbol, the EC is unlikely to allot it. Here’s why.

What do the rules say?

The EC allots election symbols to parties

and independent candidates as per the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968. According to the Order, the recognised national and state parties’ candidates are allotted the reserved symbol of their respective parties — for instance, the lotus for the BJP, or the raised hand for the Congress. For unrecognised parties, which are registered parties that have not met the electoral performance criteria for the national or state party tag, or independent candidates, the EC allots symbols from a list of “free symbols”. These candidates and unrecognised parties can request for their choice of symbol from the list, but they are not assured of getting the same.

What kinds of symbols are allowed?

In the list of free symbols, which the EC revises from time to time, images include fruits, vegetables, household appliances, farm equipment, sports equipment, etc. The latest list, published by the EC in May 2025,

Picking a poll symbol

• The EC allots symbols from a list of “free symbols” for either registered parties that haven’t met electoral performance criteria for the national or state party tag or independent candidates.

• The latest list, published in May 2025, has 184 symbols, including air-conditioner, balloon, door bell, dustbin, frying pan, jackfruit and grapes.

has 184 symbols, including AC, balloon, doorbell, dustbin, frying pan, jackfruit and grapes. Some household items such as immersion rod, latch, mixer, toothbrush, and TV remote are also on the list. Also present are a variety of fruits and vegetables as well as other food, including cake and toffees.

The EC list also says that certain symbols can be allotted freely except in certain states and Union Territories. For instance, the apple can be allotted to a party “in all States and Union Territories except in the States of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim, Tripura, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu, Kerala & Karnataka”.

This is because in the states mentioned above, the symbol has already been allotted to a recognised state party. This means two different recognised parties in two different states can have the same election symbol: there is no rule against it, and these parties are unlikely to contest against each other.

Can a creature be an election symbol?

Following representations from animal welfare activists in the 1990s, the Election Commission stopped allotting animals as election symbols.

Former Union Minister and founder of People for Animals (PFA) Maneka Gandhi wrote in a post on the PFA website that for the 1989 Tamil Nadu Assembly election, the AIADMK faction led by J Jayalalithaa was allotted the rooster as its symbol. She claimed that thousands of roosters were tied to the top of fast-moving vehicles during the election campaigning, leading to many of these birds dying.

The Bahujan Samaj Party, which was formed prior to the ban, still retains its election symbol, the elephant, making it one of the few exceptions. With the EC’s prevailing stand against allotting animals as election symbols, the cockroach symbol is unlikely to be granted if anyone seeks the same, EC officials said.

• TELECOM

In HC relief for Airtel and Vi, the lengthy row over spectrum charge

Soumyarendra Barik

New Delhi, June 9

IN A major financial and regulatory reprieve for telecom operators Bharti Airtel and Vodafone Idea (Vi), the Bombay High Court Monday struck down the Centre’s one-time spectrum charge demand estimated at more than Rs 24,000 crore. The court also set aside all consequential actions taken by the government based on the disputed demands. “The respondent (Centre) has not been able to justify the said decisions and its action of levying one-time spectrum charge retrospectively upon the petitioners,” the court said in its order. However, the broader legal battle over the charge remains pending before the Supreme Court. Here is what to know.

How airwaves are governed in India

Devices such as phones require signals to connect. These signals are carried on airwaves, which must be sent at designated frequencies to avoid interference.

The Union government owns all publicly available assets within the country, which includes airwaves. These airwaves are called spectrum, which is subdivided into bands of varying frequencies. The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) under the Ministry of Communications regularly auctions these airwaves to private companies.

The current dispute traces its origins to the telecom

OVER RS 24,000 CR IN DUES REMOVED

• In 2023, Airtel told stock exchanges that its dues stood at Rs 15,178 crore, of which it had paid Rs 8,500 crore. The remaining Rs 6,600 crore was classified as contingent liability.

• Vodafone Idea, which is facing financial strain, had reported dues of Rs 7,000 crore, including Rs 3,322 crore linked to erstwhile Idea Cellular.

• Analysts estimate the verdict could translate into cumulative relief of more than Rs 24,000 crore for the telcos by removing the liability and associated uncertainty from their books.

• The status quo holds for payments already made. Other issues will be decided in the SC case, brought by Airtel, Vi, etc.

Change in policy

Over the following years, the government and the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) introduced a series of changes governing the allocation of additional spectrum. Operators that received bandwidth beyond the initial allocation had to pay higher revenue-share-based spectrum charges. Industry bodies accepted this framework and withdrew several legal challenges, while successive policy documents and committee reports largely favoured recurring spectrum usage charges rather than upfront one-time levies.

The debate shifted in 2008, when the DoT began exploring the idea of imposing a one-time charge on spectrum holdings beyond 6.2 megahertz (MHz). A panel recommended an upfront payment mechanism for excess spectrum, and in 2010, the TRAI formally recommended a one-time spectrum charge for holdings above the threshold. The move gained momentum after the Supreme Court’s 2012 judgment in the 2G spectrum case intensified scrutiny on spectrum allocation and pricing.

In November 2012, the Union Cabinet approved the levy of one-time spectrum charges on existing operators, including retrospective charges on spectrum held beyond 6.2 MHz from July 2008 onwards. The DoT subsequently issued demand notices to operators such as Airtel and Vodafone Idea, prompting them to approach the Bombay High Court in January 2013.

The court granted interim protection against coercive action, and the matter was pending for more than a decade before this week’s ruling, which effectively nullifies the Centre’s 2012 decision.

• HEALTH

Monthly, not weekly shots: New obesity drug promises easier weight management



EXPERT EXPLAINS

DR ANOOP MISRA

CHAIRMAN AT FORTIS CDOC HOSPITAL FOR DIABETES AND ALLIED SCIENCES

PHARMACEUTICAL GIANT Pfizer has just declared mid-stage trial results for berobenate, an experimental anti-obesity and diabetes drug designed to be taken just once a month. If approved, it could become the first GLP-1 weight-loss therapy (which mimics the gut hormone GLP-1 to regulate blood sugar, slow stomach emptying and reduce appetite) to be administered as a once-a-month injection instead of weekly jabs.

The drug is drawing attention not just for

Pfizer’s berobenate is being

positioned as a once-monthly GLP-1 therapy. How is this significant from a patient adherence and treatment-compliance perspective?

Berobenate is currently transitioning into a robust global phase 3 development programme, which consists of 10 planned or ongoing late-stage clinical trials. It is expected to be available for patients around late 2028 to mid-2029. The drug has been engineered to remain in blood circulation much longer than conventional GLP-1 therapies, allowing sustained activation of GLP-1 receptors throughout the month. From an Indian perspective, a once-monthly GLP-1 injection is important because long-term adherence remains a major challenge. Less frequent dosing may reduce treatment fatigue, improve convenience and help patients remain on therapy for longer periods.

The drug showed up to 12.3% weight loss. How should clinicians interpret these results in comparison with established therapies such as

Wegovy, Zepbound and Mounjaro?

Clinicians should avoid direct comparisons across trials. The reported weight loss is clinically meaningful and encouraging for monthly therapy. However, semaglutide (Wegovy) and especially tirzepatide (Zepbound, Mounjaro) have demonstrated substantial weight reductions in larger and longer studies. At present, berobenate appears promising, but its major differentiating feature may be monthly administration rather than weight-loss efficacy.

The side-effect profile appears broadly comparable to existing GLP-1 drugs. What will experts be looking for in late-stage trials before judging its clinical value?

Experts will focus on the durability of weight loss, long-term safety, gastrointestinal side effects, discontinuation rates, and cardiovascular and kidney benefits. They will also examine whether the extended drug exposure over an entire month leads to any unique safety concerns. In that way,

it may undergo similar scrutiny as once-a-month insulin.

Could less frequent dosing improve long-term outcomes for people living with obesity, or are efficacy and side effects likely to be deciding factors?

Less frequent dosing has the potential to improve treatment persistence, which is a major determinant of long-term success in obesity management. However, efficacy and tolerability will continue to be the most important factors. A monthly injection is attractive, but patients and clinicians will ultimately prioritise how much weight is lost, how well it is maintained, and whether side effects remain manageable. Other long term data (especially cardiac) are clearly needed to address these concerns.

GLP-1 drugs are seen as long-term treatments for a chronic disease. How might a monthly injection change the way obesity is managed in routine clinical practice?

A monthly injection could further strengthen the concept of obesity as a chronic disease requiring long-term treatment, similar to diabetes or hypertension. In India, it may improve patient acceptance, reduce the burden of frequent injections, and facilitate longer-term treatment engagement. This could be particularly useful in busy clinical settings and for patients who find weekly injections inconvenient.

Do you see the future of obesity treatment moving toward longer-acting therapies, combination drugs, or more personalised approaches?

The future is likely to involve all three. Finally, the ease of administration (once monthly) and cost are key determinants. Further, personalised approaches based on liver disease (liver fibrosis), presence of obstructive sleep apnea, knee osteoarthritis, are likely to guide treatment selection. For India, where obesity and diabetes have varied patterns, personalised obesity medicine may become important.

NAVY SURFACE DRONE RESCUES TWO CREW MEMBERS AFTER U.S. APACHE GOES DOWN NEAR OMAN COAST

Big challenge in the US-Iran talks: Both sides demand victory

Erika Solomon, Farnaz Fassihi & Tyler Pager
June 9

FOR WEEKS, the parameters of a preliminary agreement to end the war between the United States and Iran have been clear to its negotiators.

The hang-up? How to devise a deal so each side can claim a win.

Washington and Tehran — both neither fully victorious nor completely defeated in the war — badly want a deal. But they also need something they can present as favorable to the hawks and hard-liners back home.

Added to this fundamental dispute are the peculiarities of the two countries' leaders. One of them is in hiding and slow to sign off on any proposal; the other is so unpredictable, his own envoys struggle to negotiate on his behalf.

Unsuccessful efforts at devising this alchemy of wording have mired the two sides in a state of neither war nor peace. They have left the global economy in limbo, too, as both sides continue their blockades of the vital Strait of Hormuz.

The longer this uncertainty persists, mediators warn, the higher the risk the whole peace process will be derailed. The tenuous nature of it all was reinforced on Monday when Israel and Iran exchanged strikes

for the first time since the April cease-fire, bringing the Middle East back to the precipice of full-blown war before both sides backed down.

Any framework for a peace agreement is likely to require Iran to allow normal maritime traffic through the strait and the United States to halt its blockade of Iranian vessels. It is also likely to include a pledge to hold a second phase of negotiations culminating in Iran's giving up its highly enriched uranium stockpile and Washington's easing economic sanctions in return. And any deal is widely expected — perhaps most problematically for President Trump — to unlock some of Iran's frozen assets.

The dilemma is how to sequence the terms, said Sanam Vakil, director of the Middle East and North Africa program at Chatham House.

"The US wants to get everything and not give too much at the beginning," she said. "And the Iranians want to get things at the beginning and give things along the way."

On one side of the equation is Iran's supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, who is still in hiding out of concern about being targeted like his father, the former supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, killed by US-Israeli strikes in their opening salvos of the war. NYT

Trump: Iran downed our helicopter, US must react

Israel strikes historic port city Tyre, killing 8

Reuters
Washington, Beirut, Dubai, June 9

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Tuesday Iran had shot down a US Apache helicopter that was patrolling Strait of Hormuz overnight and vowed to respond, but gave no other details.

"I have just been informed by our Great Military that last night the Iranians shot down one of our highly sophisticated Apache Helicopters while patrolling over the Strait of Hormuz," Trump wrote in a social media post. He said the two US pilots involved in the incident were both safe and uninjured. "Nevertheless, the United States must, of necessity, respond to this attack," he added.

His remarks threw into deeper uncertainty the prospects for a truce announced on April 8 in the war in the Gulf.

On Monday, Israel and Iran said they would halt attacks on each other after an appeal by Trump to end their first direct exchanges of fire since April, but Tehran warned it would resume hostilities if Israel continued to attack its ally Hezbollah in Lebanon.

Monday's flare-up added



Lebanese security officers gather at the site where an Israeli airstrike damaged a building, in Dahiyeh, Beirut's southern suburb. FILE

further strain to efforts to broker a peace deal to end the wider West Asia war and reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

In remarks earlier on Tuesday about the downing of the Apache helicopter, Trump had said the two helicopter crew members were "fine" following their rescue by a US navy drone, but he had made no comment about what brought the Apache down. A navy surface drone found and rescued the two crew, the US military told Reuters.

US Central Command said the AH-64 Apache went down at around 3 am on Tuesday.

In Tehran, two Iranian air defence personnel were due to be buried on Tuesday

afternoon after being killed in Israeli strikes the day before, Iran's military said. No deaths were reported in Israel after the Iranian strikes. Earlier on Tuesday, Israel struck the historic port city of Tyre in southern Lebanon, killing at least eight people. Tuesday's raids were the deadliest on Tyre since fighting erupted in Lebanon in early March.

Israel had issued an evacuation order for the city earlier on Tuesday. Residents fled and civil defence teams transported elderly residents into temporary shelters, state media reported. The eight victims were killed in a single strike on the city's eastern edge, Lebanon's health ministry said. A video verified by

Reuters showed debris strewn across a road at the site of attack.

Israel's refusal to end its campaign in Lebanon, as Iran demands, has hindered Trump's efforts to extend a tenuous truce in the wider US-Israeli war with Iran into a durable settlement.

Trump also told reporters he might have "an idea" for an Iran deal within a few days, without elaborating.

US and Israeli officials said Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had spoken on Monday. In an interview with Axios, Trump said he had warned the Israeli leader not to return to war with Iran. "I said, Bibi, you better be careful, or you will be on your own very soon."



Red Cross workers disinfect Rwampara General Hospital amid efforts to contain an Ebola outbreak in eastern Congo. FILE

With few masks, no boots, Congo's Ebola medics left exposed

Reuters
Nairobi, London, June 9

NEARLY A month into one of the world's largest ever Ebola outbreaks, medics in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo are struggling to secure basic equipment to stay safe and prevent further spread of the disease, according to more than a dozen doctors, humanitarian workers and public health officials.

While major donors are surging funding, the size of the outbreak, reductions in pre-positioned stocks due to aid cuts, and logistical problems have caused shortages and driven up costs for personal protective equipment.

The International Rescue Committee aid group warned on Tuesday that stocks of essential protective equipment are expected to run out within days.

In North Kivu, one of three affected provinces that have confirmed over 550 cases and

100 deaths, medical teams are close to exhausting items like chlorine and often lack equipment including boots, said Pablo Lwanzo Paluku, chief doctor for the Butembo zone.

A suspected Ebola victim's body was wrapped in a blue tarpaulin and transported on a taxi roof due to the lack of a body bag or ambulance, he said. "What little we have is improvised," said Paluku.

As of June 4, only a quarter of critical supplies needed for the next three months had arrived in Congo and Uganda, which has reported 19 cases, with face shields and alcoholic gel particularly short, according to the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention.

Already, 34 healthcare workers have been infected with the rare Bundibugyo strain of the virus and seven have died, just over three weeks after the WHO declared an international emergency.

Indian-origin couple, child die in fall from London apartment block

Press Trust of India
London, June 9

AN INDIAN-origin couple and their 9-year-old terminally ill son died after they fell from a luxury London apartment block in a suspected murder-suicide, according to media reports.

Rakesh Pai, 47, Aditi Paralkar, 46, and their son Sid died after falling from a balcony on the 36th floor of their apartment in Highpoint tower block in Elephant and Castle, south London, on May 27, the Telegraph newspaper reported.

The family lived in the 45-storey building on the 36th floor, approximately 400 feet from the ground, according to the Sunday Guardian.

Neil Coyle, Labour MP for Bermondsey and Old Southwark, said Sid was born with "severe illnesses" and police believe his condition contributed to their "horrendous decision". The family was found by the emergency services after witnesses reported at 7.29 am that a group of people had fallen from a height. Paramedics attempted resuscitation, but all three were pronounced dead at the scene.

"It's a terrible tragedy, a family of three. Just awful. Some constituents saw it happen. The suggestion was that the child was born in the UK with severe illnesses, which the police inferred contributed to their horrendous decision," Coyle said.



People gather in large numbers during an anti-Pakistan protest, in Muzaffarabad, Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, on Tuesday. ANI

Markets, streets deserted in PoK; protests at Pak consulate in UK

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, London, June 9

SHOPS AND markets remained closed on Tuesday in different parts of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir after a protest call by the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), as over 20 people have reportedly been killed in recent police action in the region.

About 2,000 protestors associated with the JAAC launched a protest march from Bhimber and they would reach Mirpur on onward travel to Muzaffarabad, BBC Urdu reported.

It added that some protesters would reach Rawalakot and then proceed to Muzaffarabad. Police and security forces personnel are patrolling the roads and other areas.

JAAC has been staging protests demanding subsidised flour and electricity. The group was outlawed on Friday by

authorities, citing concerns over public order and security.

The streets in Muzaffarabad were deserted, with hardly any vehicles on the roads, Dawn reported. It added that riot police and paramilitary personnel remained deployed in the city.

It reported that hundreds of people had gathered in the Quaid-i-Azam stadium of Mirpur, another major town of PoK. "Shops are closed here, and traffic is off the roads," local journalist Sajjad JarraI told Dawn by telephone.

The legal fraternity of PoK boycotted judicial proceedings on the Bar Council's call to protest the alleged arrest of senior lawyer Amjad Ali Khan, a core member of the JAAC.

Pakistan's human rights body on Monday said that it was "deeply alarmed" by the ongoing violence in PoK during violent clashes.

Authorities on Tuesday an-

nounced a reward for those who helped in the arrest of the key leaders of the JAAC.

According to an official notification, a "Rs 10 million reward money" will be given to any person who provides information leading to the successful arrest of the central leaders of the JAAC, including Shaukat Nawaz Mir, Omar Nazir Kashmiri, Sardar Aman and Khawaja Mehran.

Meanwhile, PoK's so-called Prime Minister Faisal Mumtaz Rathore urged a return to the negotiating table to end the tensions that have gripped the region over the past few days.

Protesters on Tuesday staged a demonstration in front of the Pakistani Consulate in Bradford, the UK, over the firing on mourners at a funeral in PoK. This came days after 30 British MPs sought diplomatic intervention over the massive human rights abuses in PoK.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

NASA names astronauts for Artemis III docking mission



The NASA logo is seen at Kennedy Space Center in Cape Canaveral. FILE

NASA ON Tuesday named three US astronauts and an Italian astronaut to serve as the crew for its next Artemis mission, a spacecraft docking demonstration in Earth's orbit next year that will test landers from Elon Musk's SpaceX and Jeff Bezos' Blue Origin for the first time in space. NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman at a ceremony in Houston named US astronauts Andre Douglas, Frank Rubio and Randy Bresnik and Italian astronaut Luca Parmitano as the Artemis III crew, which is due to launch late next year. "Artemis III is an incredibly exciting, and highly coordinated multi-launch campaign," Jeremy Parsons program manager said. REUTERS

THE PHILIPPINES

32,000 displaced after quake that killed at least 37

RESCUERS SEARCHED ruined buildings in the southern Philippines on Tuesday to ensure no one was still trapped a day after one of the strongest earthquakes to hit the country in a half-century killed at least 37 people and displaced more than 32,000. Only four people were considered missing in the southern provinces near where the quake struck Monday. AP

ITALY

Ben-Gvir faces probe over Gaza flotilla incident

ITALIAN PROSECUTORS put Israel's far-right National Security Minister Itamar Ben-Gvir under investigation over the treatment of activists who were part of a Gaza flotilla last month, a judicial source said on Monday. The source, said Ben-Gvir was being investigated on suspicion of torture and kidnapping of Italian citizens who were among the activists. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

6 troops killed in clashes with Taliban KPK

SIX FRONTIER Constabulary personnel were killed and four others injured in clashes with the Taliban militants who attempted to seize a check post in Hassan Khel area, some 30 km southwest of Peshawar in Pakistan, officials said on Tuesday. PTI

NEPAL

Man held with more than Rs 7.9L in cash

AUTHORITIES IN Nepal arrested an Indian national for carrying INR 7.9 lakhs without any supporting documents, police said on Sunday. The 59-year-old man, identified as Bhima Srinivas, was arrested on Saturday at the domestic terminal at the airport. PTI

Gurung back as home minister, to reopen file on Nepal royal murders

Yubaraj Ghinire
Kathmandu, June 9

NEPAL HOME Minister Sudhan Gurung on Tuesday announced that the government would reopen the file related to the Royal Palace shootout case in which King Birendra, his entire family and eight others lost their lives 25 years ago.

Soon after taking charge as Home Minister on Tuesday, Gurung said the file would be reopened, but did not elaborate on whether there would be a fresh investigation into the incident that took place on the night of June 1, 2001.

The official investigation team headed by House Speaker Taranath Rana Bhat had concluded that Crown Prince Dipendra, who was estranged from his parents over their refusal to allow him to marry the girl of his choice, targeted them and other close relatives present during a family gathering before shooting himself. Crown Prince Dipendra died in a coma in a hospital three days later.

Prince Gyanendra, who was away in Pokhara for a presche-



Nepal Home Minister Sudhan Gurung. FILE

duled meeting, had been called by the Crown Prince to join the family dinner, but sources involved in the investigation told The Indian Express that King Birendra asked him not to rush back and instead fulfil his prior commitment.

Gyanendra, the third in line of succession, became king after Dipendra died on June 3. His brother Nirajan was among the ten who died in the shooting at the Royal Palace.

Incidentally, it was not a cabinet meeting that decided to reopen the case. Gurung made the announcement after returning to office on the 47th day after his resignation, following his exoneration by an investigation team over the legitimacy of his property and his alleged connection with a controversial businessman under probe.

• WHITE HOUSE SOUTH LAWN SET FOR FIRST U.F.C. EVENT AS TRUMP CELEBRATES HIS 80th BIRTHDAY WITH EIGHT-SIDED WIRE-MESH CAGE COMPLETE WITH AN OPEN OVERHEAD DOME

From tennis to T-ball, White House no stranger to sports, but nothing like UFC bout

Will Weissert
Washington, June 9

TEDDY ROOSEVELT boxed. Richard Nixon bowled. Dwight D Eisenhower put in a putting green. George H W Bush added a horseshoe pit. Herbert Hoover played a game named for himself to get more exercise, while George W Bush threw open the space for youth T-ball.

The White House and its storied South Lawn are no strangers to sporting events. But they've never seen anything like the UFC bout President Donald Trump is hosting to celebrate his 80th birthday on Sunday or the eight-sided, wire-mesh cage complete with an open over-

head dome featuring large screens that are surrounded by thousands of arena seats.

Sometimes called America's backyard, the South Lawn was until now known for low-contact sports and joyful events geared toward children or bipartisanism, like the annual Easter Egg Roll or the congressional picnic.

The same space being used for blood sport, feting a president who relishes it and playing out in a hulking structure featuring a complicated overhead lighting scheme known as The Claw, illustrates yet another of the White House norms that Trump is gleefully laying to rest — or, in UFC parlance, forcing to tap out.

That the president has begun suggesting that he could make the cage-fighting venue a permanent South Lawn fixture under scores just how far from T-ball the White House has come.

"Sports has been central to presidents. I don't know that it's been quite the spectacle that it is with the Trump administration," said Michael Patrick Cullinane, senior historian at the Theodore Roosevelt Presidential Library.

Teddy Roosevelt pioneered sports at the White House.

Many early presidents were talented athletes before taking office. Abraham Lincoln and William Howard Taft were celebrated young wrestlers. John



Stage for the UFC fight on the South Lawn of White House. FILE

Quincy Adams was fit enough to take daily naked swims in the Potomac River while in office.

But Teddy Roosevelt was the

first to make sports a large part of White House life, installing a tennis court on the lawn. His wife, Edith, was concerned

about his workload, and the grass court outside his office was meant to force more relaxation.

Cullinane, who is the author of "Theodore Roosevelt and the Tennis Cabinet" and is a history professor at Dickinson State University, said Roosevelt loved tennis and, though he didn't play well, he did so "long and vigorously."

Roosevelt would take the court daily at 3 pm, rain or shine, for seemingly endless six-game sets against top aides. He also boxed, holding bouts in the White House that were far more intimate affairs than Sunday's UFC fight. While sparring with his military aide Col Daniel T Moore in 1905, Roosevelt de-

tached the retina of his left eye.

During a recent New York Post interview, Trump was asked about Roosevelt and replied that he "had a lot of energy, loved the outdoors." He indicated that he knew about Roosevelt's having boxed at the White House but didn't comment on how the UFC event might compare.

Trump has attended a series of major sporting events, including Monday's trip to the NBA finals in New York. The UFC coming to him, however, is unlike anything the presidency has seen.

"There's definitely precedence for athletic events, but this is a combination of athletic

event and a celebrity event," said Tevi Troy, a presidential historian and senior fellow at the Reagan Institute.

Troy noted, as the bevy of musical acts pulling out of the Trump-led celebration to mark America's 250th birthday illustrates, "The entertainment world is just hostile to Republicans and Trump. So he goes to find his celebrities where he can."

Trump has been a UFC fan for decades. His 2024 presidential campaign showcased his friendship with the league's chief, Dana White, and Trump also attended bouts around the country, hoping to energize voters not usually interested in politics. AP

CURBS MOSTLY ON INSTITUTIONAL PLAYERS, RETAIL AUDIENCE INSULATED

MFs place curbs on large gold ETF inflows amid forex pressure

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 9

SEVERAL LARGE mutual fund houses have suspended fresh subscriptions into their gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) and fund of funds (FoFs) as the ongoing conflict in West Asia continues to swell the country's imports bill and put pressure on foreign exchange reserves.

HDFC Mutual Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Tata Mutual Fund and Nippon India Mutual Fund have all placed such curbs on gold ETF schemes, which came into effect between June 5-8.

"Investors are requested to note that the Board of ICICI Prudential Trust Ltd has approved temporary restriction on subscriptions of ICICI Prudential Gold ETF (Gold ETF) with effect from the close of market hours of June 5, 2026. Subscriptions in Gold ETF directly with ICICI Prudential Asset Management Company Ltd (AMC) by eligible investors for an amount exceeding Rs 25 crores shall not be accepted till further notice," said ICICI MF.

Other fund houses also placed similar curbs on fresh

subscriptions into their gold ETF schemes.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had last month called upon the public to help the country battle against the threats posed by the West Asia war, announcing measures to curb fuel usage, gold imports and foreign exchange drain.

Under the SEBI regulations, gold ETFs are mandated to invest 95% of their net assets in physical gold and other SEBI-mandated gold instruments, which drives up the need for gold imports.

Notably, these restrictions are applicable only for large transactions in the segment, with other services such as SIPs and redemptions still open for investors. Thus, these are aimed at restricting inflows from institutional investors rather than retail participants.

Gold import bill for the March 2026 quarter was \$22.57 billion and full year of FY26 at \$71.97 billion as against \$9.5 billion and \$58 billion respectively in the previous year, RBI data says.

Many industry players welcomed measures announced by the fund houses.

• GOLD IMPORT PROBLEM

HDFC MUTUAL Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Tata Mutual Fund and Nippon India Mutual Fund have all placed such curbs on gold ETF schemes, which came into effect between June 5-8

THE MOVE comes after Prime Minister Modi last month called upon the public to help the country battle against the threats posed by West Asia conflict

THESE RESTRICTIONS are likely to dampen the momentum seen



in gold ETF inflows over the past few months

"We hope other AMCs also follow suit, because as an industry, we have to recognise that excessive financialisation of gold at elevated prices can add to import demand, put pressure on the current account deficit, and eventually contribute to rupee depreciation. Our stance on gold has been very clear. Indians should not only stop buying gold at these levels, but also look at selling a small portion of their idle gold holdings," according to Fe-

roze Azeez, joint CEO of Anand Rathii Wealth.

Calling these restrictions on gold ETF inflows a "responsible step," Azeez said, "India holds nearly \$4 trillion worth of household gold, while the current account deficit is around \$65 billion. That means even 1% to 1.5% of household gold coming back into circulation can make a meaningful difference to India's external finances."

These restrictions are likely

to dampen the momentum seen in gold ETF inflows over the past few months.

"It looks likely that such curbs are expected to remain until there is some meaningful resolution in West Asia. Gold and silver ETFs have become a popular avenue to hedge for institutional players, especially during the risks that exist today. That explains some of the reason why flows into gold ETFs have boomed, alongside retail interest. However, if hedging is taken out of the equation, flows might dry up a bit in the coming months," a fund manager at a domestic fund house said.

Notably, investments in gold ETFs crossed that into the traditionally popular equity funds for the first time when it had more than doubled month-on-month to a record high of Rs 24,040 crore in January 2026.

This was on the back of gold's rise to prominence at a time when US tariff threats had drawn safe-haven demand for the precious metal.

However, inflows have since moderated to the pre-boom levels of Rs 2,000-Rs 4,000 crore as the safe-haven demand has since shifted to the dollar.

FCNR(B) DEPOSITS SWAP SCHEME

Why higher interest rates may be needed to bring in NRI dollars

George Mathew & Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 9

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) last week announced, until September 2026, the special dispensation that allows banks to mobilise fresh three- to five-year Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) — FCNR (B) — deposits and permitted them to swap these deposits with the RBI at a concessional rate, effectively covering the entire hedging cost.

By absorbing the hedging burden, the RBI has made FCNR (B) deposits a more attractive source of overseas funding for lenders. Experts believe the steps announced by the RBI may attract an additional \$50 billion-\$70 billion in foreign capital into Indian markets, provided the banks offer the right interest rates after considering the hedging costs.

But bankers say the regulatory incentive alone may not suffice to trigger large inflows. With US dollar deposit rates in major markets like the US still offering returns of over 4%, Indian banks may need to raise FCNR (B) deposit rates by at least 100 basis points to remain competitive and persuade NRIs to shift funds to India. In FY26, FCNR (B) deposit inflows plunged by 86 per cent to \$946 million from \$7.1 billion in FY25, with the amount outstanding rising to \$33.8 billion at the end of March. Unless banks offer a meaningful rate premium over overseas alternatives, the response from de-

positors may remain muted despite RBI's support.

What are FCNR (B) deposits?

FCNR (B) deposits are fixed-term bank deposits that can be opened in India by non-resident Indians (NRIs) and Overseas Citizens of India. They allow overseas Indians to maintain their savings in designated foreign currencies such as the US dollar, pound sterling, euro, Japanese yen, Australian dollar and Canadian dollar, rather than converting their funds into Indian rupees. Interest earned on FCNR (B) deposits is exempt from income tax in India as long as the depositor qualifies as a non-resident under Indian tax laws. Under the current framework, banks can offer rates linked to globally accepted benchmark rates.

FCNR rates now

Compared with conventional rupee fixed deposits, interest rates on FCNR (B) deposits remain significantly lower, typically by 250-300 basis points or more. For instance, SBI currently offers 3.35% on FCNR (B) deposits with a tenure of 3-4 years, 2.95% for 4-5 years, and 3.05% for maturities above five years. HDFC Bank offers 3.65% for 3-4 year FCNR (B) deposits and 3.40% for tenures above four years, while ICICI Bank offers 3% for 3-4 year deposits and 2.90% for deposits exceeding four years.

Compared to this, SBI offers 6.30% for a normal 3-year fixed deposit (FD). HDFC and ICICI

offer 6.50% for 3-5 years tenure.

The lower rates reflect the fact that FCNR (B) deposits are maintained in foreign currencies such as the US dollar, pound sterling, euro and Canadian dollar, regions in which benchmark interest rates are generally lower than domestic rupee rates. However, the RBI's latest relaxation on FCNR (B) deposits is expected to improve the economics of mobilising such funds. By allowing banks to raise fresh three- to five-year FCNR (B) deposits without bearing the full cost of hedging foreign exchange exposure, banks can offer more attractive rates to overseas depositors without significantly impacting their margins.

Why Indian banks should hike rates

Indian banks are yet to work out and announce the new rates on FCNR (B) deposits. "Banks need to more than match the interest rates offered by foreign banks in various jurisdictions like the US. Otherwise, funds won't come. FCNR (B) deposit inflows declined sharply in FY26," said an official of a nationalised bank.

SBI currently offers around 3.85% on three- to five-year US dollar Certificate of Deposit (CD) products in the US. Comparable offerings from US banks are slightly higher, with Merrick Bank providing a 4.20% annual percentage yield on a three-year CD and Morgan Stanley offering about 4.30% APY on a five-year CD. These rates are higher than what are being offered by Indian banks for FCNR (B) scheme.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

AI agents to match physical workforce at TCS soon: Chair



“As the cost of intelligence falls, many more processes, decisions and interactions in many more industries will become candidates for AI-driven transformation”

N CHANDRASEKARAN,
TATA CONSULTANCY SERVICES CHAIRMAN

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 9

TATA CONSULTANCY Services (TCS) Chairman N Chandrasekaran on Tuesday said the company is investing in building artificial intelligence (AI) agents and expects a future where the number of AI agents working alongside the firm could match its physical workforce.

He said TCS is investing in building AI agents for their internal operations, solution framework and client specific work. "I predict TCS will have many AI agents," Chandrasekaran said while addressing the AGM of the company. "What we build in this next chapter for our clients for India and for you will be the most consequential work this company has done yet."

TCS had workforce of 5.85 lakh globally as of March 2026.

He said AI tools definitely reduce the need for human input in the building and maintenance of software. "However, AI does more than reduce the effort. It is not merely a technol-

ogy. It is an infrastructure. It is an infrastructure of intelligence. If you look back at the history when such an infrastructural shift happens, opportunities expand," TCS Chairman said.

On the rapid rise in use of AI, he said, "today AI primarily exists in the world of software and computers but soon it will take shape into physical world in stores, factories, warehouses, energy networks, vehicles and supply chains."

This will require experts who understand how to link an AI and physical equipment infrastructure, he said.

He said cloud made technology central to every industry. "AI will do lot more than any of these examples at a greater scale and across wider canvas. As the cost of intelligence falls, many more processes, decisions and interactions in many more industries will become candidates for AI-driven transformation," Chandrasekaran said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Mistry questions governance, conflict of interest in Tata Trusts

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 9

FORMER TATA Trusts trustee Mehli Mistry has raised a series of questions before the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner, ranging from compensation and commissions received by certain trustees from Tata group companies to potential conflicts of interest arising from trustees simultaneously holding positions on the boards of group entities.

Apart from questioning his own removal from the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), Mistry raised issues of governance and decision-making within the philanthropic institution.

The challenge marks a significant escalation in the ongoing dispute, bringing broader questions of governance, accountability and conflict management within the Tata Trusts structure under regulatory scrutiny. In filings submitted to the regulator last week, Mistry has questioned trustee appointments, board-level decisions, remuneration arrangements, and governance practices across the Tata Trusts ecosystem.

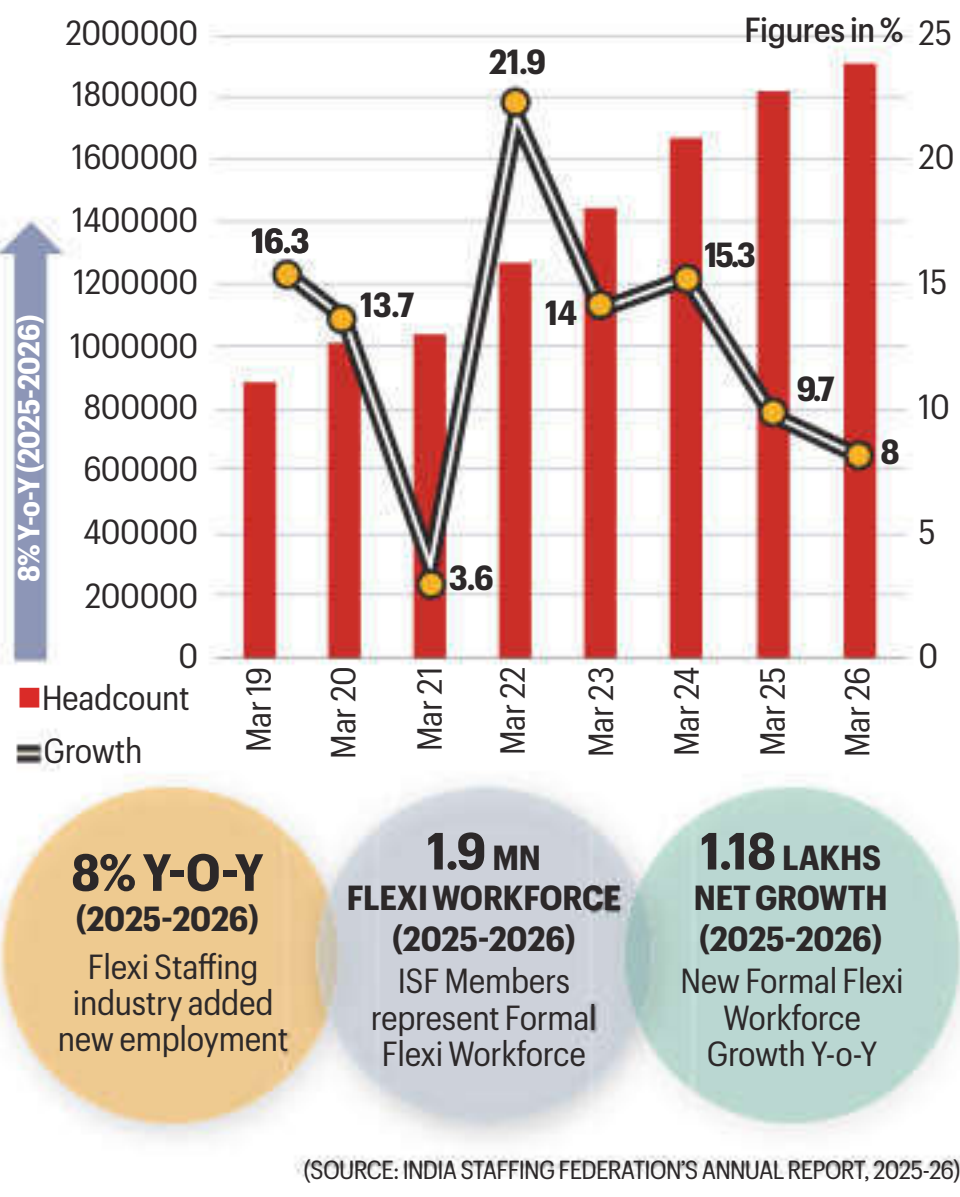
Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata has not responded to a mail sent by *The Indian Express* seeking his response to the claims made by Mistry till the press time.

A key theme of Mistry's argument relates to the fiduciary responsibilities of trustees overseeing charitable institutions.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• Flexi staffing employment growth in India

India is fast emerging as one of the biggest markets for flexible employment, under which employees are hired for a limited project or period. IT, retail and FMCG sectors are the biggest consumers of flexible staffing solutions.



OpenAI files for US IPO after Anthropic

Bengaluru: ChatGPT-maker OpenAI confidentially filed for a US initial public offering on Monday, joining rival Anthropic in a push toward the stock market as investors seek exposure to the artificial intelligence (AI) boom.

OpenAI did not disclose the size or terms of the offering, but *Reuters* has reported that the AI giant is targeting a valuation of

up to \$1 trillion in a stock market debut that could come as early as September.

At that valuation, OpenAI would set the stage for a trio of trillion-dollar-valuation companies debuting rapidly, which together are seen as the most consequential test of investor appetite for high-growth technology stocks in the last 10 years. REUTERS

Indian shares gain, led by banks on RBI forex swap facility

Bengaluru: Indian share benchmarks rose on Tuesday, led by lenders after the central bank detailed a concessional forex swap facility for banks' overseas foreign-currency borrowings, while a pause in Israel-Iran hostilities helped cool oil prices.

The benchmark Nifty 50 rose 0.52% to 23,242.10, and the BSE Sensex gained 0.54% to 73,918.76.

The Reserve Bank of India on Monday allowed banks to raise overseas foreign-currency borrowings of at least three years at concessional swap rates, aiming to boost dollar inflows with the rupee under pressure from higher oil prices, foreign outflows and geopolitical risks.

Banks and financials rose about 2.1% and 1.4%, respectively, while state-owned lenders climbed 3.6% and private banks gained 1.6%.

Fifteen of the 16 major sectors advanced. The small-caps and mid-caps rose 1.7% and 1.4%, respectively. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

AI world vastly different from IT Act era: Vaishnaw

New Delhi: The current information technology (IT) law was framed much before the rapid emergence of Artificial Intelligence (AI), Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said Tuesday, adding that he believes a new legal framework may be required to deal with the changing landscape. In an interview with PTI, Vaishnaw, who is Minister for IT and electronics, said discussions are on with the industry and

that the Centre will seek to strike a balance between innovation and regulation. PTI

BYD unveils plug-in hybrid Seal U SUV

New Delhi: BYD India, a subsidiary of China's EV major BYD, on Tuesday announced the launch of its first plug-in hybrid 'Seal U SUV' later this year. Unlike traditional hybrid systems, which rely primarily on the petrol engine with the battery providing support, DM-i follows an electric-first approach. PTI

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▲	US Dollar ▼
73,918.76	23,242.10	₹1,52,519	₹95.35
394.50	119.10		
0.54%	0.52%	Silver ▲	Oil ▲
		₹2,45,938	\$97.19

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA
GOLD PER 100G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JUNE 8, 2026

• WHILE APPLE HAS OVERHAULED THE DIGITAL ASSISTANT, MAKING IT SMARTER AND MORE AWARE JUST AS GEMINI AND CHATGPT, THE FIRM IS NOT CALLING IT A CHATBOT

Apple introduces AI-powered Siri overhaul ‘built on modern architecture’

Anuj Bhatia
Cupertino, CA, June 9

FOR OVER a decade, Siri was largely confined to basic tasks such as setting alarms. But Apple knew that its digital assistant had fallen short of the original vision. In a long-delayed overhaul, the company on Monday unveiled a new version of Siri at the annual Worldwide Developers Conference in Cupertino, California.

The company is betting on artificial intelligence (AI) to unlock Siri's potential.

The latest "Siri AI" is a more conversational AI assistant that can draw on a user's personal context and carry act on their behalf. These capabilities align more closely with Apple's original vision for the digital assistant. The version can be termed Siri 2.0 as it has come after many years.

A next-generation Siri was

first announced in 2024, alongside the launch of Apple Intelligence. However, the AI-powered version faced repeated delays.

On-screen awareness, personal context

The problem with previous versions of Siri was that it couldn't use the information on an iPhone to assist the user.

With the upgrade, Siri can understand personal context and function across apps, while still being aware of what's on the screen through Apple's Visual Intelligence.

It will also be able to search for answers across the web like ChatGPT and Claude.

The upgrades include on-screen awareness, identifying locations in pictures being viewed, and giving directions to the locations. It can also proof-read text on apps to catch typos and errors.

During a Q&A session with



Apple's Software Chief Craig Federighi addressing the media following the WWDC 2026 keynote in Cupertino, California. ANUJ BHATIA

select media at Apple Park. Mike Rockwell, engineering lead for Siri, demonstrated the new version to journalists and analysts. He asked Siri what everyone was bringing to an upcoming potluck lunch, and Siri AI gathered the information from separate texts and displayed it on the screen.

Rockwell then asked which drinks will pair well with the food. It accessed Apple's World Knowledge Service for suggestions. The interaction was preserved as an ongoing conversation, allowing users to return to it at any time through the app.

"Now, we did go back and forth on what's the best way if

you want to get back to such a chat that you had," Apple SVP of Software Engineering Craig Federighi said. "Because you want to continue it, you want to reference it, and quite honestly, the most natural affordance for any user to go find something like that is to have an app that they can manage on their home screen, launch, and get back to. And so, we have a Siri app."

While Apple has overhauled Siri AI, making it smarter and more aware just as Gemini and ChatGPT, the firm is not calling it a chatbot.

"We see Siri not as a separate chatbot, an unintegrated place where you go and chitchat, but rather as an integral yet conversational tool that you use in the moment," said Federighi.

Powered by Apple or Google?

Apple has partnered with Google to use Gemini models to

power the next-generation Siri. Apple executives said Siri AI is personal and no information is being shared.

While Apple relies on Google's AI models, the executives indicated that they are not the same as the publicly available Google Gemini, that many people in the tech industry had assumed when the two firms had announced a partnership in January.

"We use none of the models that Google deploys to its customers," Federighi said during a media briefing, adding that the requests are completely private, are not stored and never accessible to anyone.

"When it comes to the knowledge base, we of course don't use Google Search or anything like that as the foundation of our system," he said. "The Siri app is a great way to get back to a conversation. You can look at what you've previously

been doing and either continue that conversation or start a new one. But this app isn't just reaching out to a model in the cloud — it's built on powerful system software in Apple Intelligence," Federighi made it clear, adding that when customers make queries about current events, the information will pass through Apple's in-house system.

Attempt to make AI more 'personal'

Apple has previously failed to make Siri AI work, and despite its claims, the company is back at the drawing board to make its digital assistant perform effectively on the iPhone and other Apple devices.

Through the keynote and media briefing, Apple executives said Siri is built on a modern architecture, it's natively multimodal, with privacy-first interactions across all products. This allows it to create a seamless

experience. It can access and act on personal content locally, like messages, notes, and photos, without compromising privacy.

Even though Apple has introduced a separate Siri app that lets users continue and reference conversations, it insists that the assistant is an extension of system workflows rather than a standalone chatbot.

The demos of Siri AI given by Apple seemed promising.

Compared to other tech companies and their chatbots, Apple's AI strategy is rooted in making Siri practical and focus on turning everyday tasks on the devices easier to accomplish. This sets it apart from OpenAI's ChatGPT and Google's Gemini, which may appear more robotic and less human at times.

The reporter was in Cupertino at the invitation of Apple.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Classifieds

PERSONAL

It is forp general information that I,Abhay Tigga,S/o- Marianus Tigga,R/O-13/7, Zamrudpur,Greater Kailash,Po:Greater Kailash,DIST:-South Delhi,Delhi-110048,declare that name of my father has been wrongly-written as Marinaus Tigga in my 10th Class Educational Documents. The actual name of my father is Marianus Tigga.

0040859602-13

I,hitherto known as Shabeer Manna Khan,S/O-Manna Kuddush Khan,R/O-R-259,G floor,Greater-Kailash, South,Delhi-110048,have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as ARYAN SINGH.

0040859630-11

I,hitherto known as Gulshan Kumar Arora,S/O-Kishan Lal Dua,R/O-804,Sector-16A, Vasundhara-Ghaziabad,UP-201012, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Gulshan Dua

0040859602-12

I,Vishnu Garg S/o Shiv Charan Lal R/O NE-7, Gali No-1,Vishnu Garden,Tilak Nagar,Delhi-110018,have changed my name to Vishnu Kumar for all,future purposes.

0040859630-2

I,Vikash Chauhan,S/o-Rajinder Chauhan,R/O-504 madam Pur Khadar Sarita Vihar, New Delhi-110076, have changed my name to Vikas Chauhan for all purposes.

0040859646-4

I,Vaaruni Kaushik D/O Ashwani Kaushik R/O-C-8/225-B,Keshav Puram,Delhi-110035,have changed my name to Garima Kaushik for all future purposes.

0040859628-3

I,Tanveer Singh S/o Sarabjeet Singh R/O-T-208, Baljeet Nagar New Delhi-8 have changed my name to Tanveer Singh Bhatia

0040859634-2

I,Sunil Kumar,R/O B-167, Second Floor,Vivek Vihar Phase-1,Delhi have changed my daughter's name from Tanvi,to Tanvi Sehgal, for all purposes.

0040859602-7

I,Shahzad S/o Maksood Alam R/o C-3/219, Block-C3, Nangli Vihar Extn., Gali-No.18, Bapraula, Delhi-110043, have changed my name to Sameer.

0040859634-8

I,Santu PD Singh S/o Ram Pratap Singh R/o Goraul Bhagwanpur, Goraul, Vaishali, Bihar-844118,have changed my-name to Sant Kumar Singh.

0040859634-6

I,SAIMA SAIFI,W/O MOHD ZAHID,R/O 53/14,ZAKIR NAGAR,OKHLA,NEW DELHI-110025,inform that SAIMA SAIFI and SAIMA,both names are same person.

0040859646-9

I,Rajrani W/O Rajinder Kumar Jain,R/O-123 Preet Vihar, Delhi-110092,have changed my name to Raj Rani Jain for all purposes.

0040859646-8

I,Avneet Kaur D/o Sarabjeet Singh R/o T-208, Baljeet Nagar New Delhi-8 have changed my name to Avneet Bhatia

0040859634-1

I,RAMAKRISHNAN V/O- Ramesh R/O-SM/Q.No.86-A, Air Force Station, Arjangarh, New Delhi-110047, have changed my name from RAMAKRISHNAN V to RAMAKRISHNAN vide affidavit dated-09-Jun-26,before notary public.

0040859646-10

I,RAJESH BANSAL S/O SATPAL BANSAL R/O D-49,SECOND FLOOR PRASHANT VIHAR, DELHI-110085.HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAJESH KUMAR BANSAL.

0040859646-1

I,RAHUL S/o Prabhu Nandan, R/O-RZ-E-156,Upper Ground-Floor Right-Side Nihal Vihar Nangloi,Delhi-110041, have changed my name to RAHUL KUMAR

0040859630-6

I,Pooja w/o-Vinod kumar r/o-244 sector-14 sonipat,have changed my name to Pooja Arora, for all purposes.

0040859630-9

I,Nuzhatnaz,W/o Javed Alam, R/O-C-55/2,Gali No.7,Chauhan Banger,Delhi-110053,have changed the name of my minor daughter from Junaibra(DOB-20-11-2008) to Zunaira,for all purposes.

0040859602-10

I,NIDHI RAJ SINGH Alias NIDHI RAJ,W/O-MRITUNJAY KUMAR SINGH,R/O-H-703, AMRAPALI ZODIAC, SECTOR 120,NOIDA, GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR, UTTAR PRADESH-201301,have changed my name to NIDHIE RAJ SINGH, for all purposes.

0040859634-11

I,Munendra Yadav S/o Yogendra Singh R/O B-51, 2nd-floor Flat.No-21, Kalyankunj Barola, Sector-49, Noida(U.P) have changed my name to Munendra Kumar for all future purposes.

0040859540-1

I,Mohd Nasir,S/o Mohd Hussain,R/o H-No.2963,kucha neel kanth,Darya ganj,Central delhi-110002,have changed my name Mohmed Nasir to Mohd Nasir, for all purpose

0040859511-1

I,Rubina Khan W/o, Anshu Rustagi R/O-A-138, First Floor, Ramprastha Colony, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201011 have changed my name to Kriti Rustagi for all purposes

0040859560-1

I,Ranju Devi W/o Manikant Sharma R/o Mehus, Shekhpura, Mehuns, Sheikhpura, Bihar-811102 have changed my name to Shobha Sinha.

0071041039-1

I,Mohd Nasir,S/o Mohd Hussain,R/o H-No.2963, kucha neel kanth,Darya ganj,Central-delhi-110002,I,inform that my father name is wrongly written in my passport Mohmed Hussain,but correct name is mohd Hussain.

0040859511-2

I,Mohd Bilal,S/O-Abdul Salam,R/O-House No.495,Gali.No.5,Block-D,Sangam-Vihar, Pushpa-Bhawan, Po:Pushpa Bhawan,south Delhi-110062,Have Changed my Name to Bilal for All Future Purposes.

0040859602-3

I,Misha d/o-Tarun Dembla r/o-1326 sector-14 sonipat,have changed my name to Misha Dembla,for all purposes.

0040859630-8

I,Mangal Singh,S/o-Vinod Kumar,resident of,32-Samman Bazar,Bhogal Jangpura,New Delhi-110014,have changed my minor son name Yohan to Yohan Singh,for all purposes.

0040859646-6

I,Mangal Singh,S/o-Vinod Kumar,resident of,32 Samman Bazar,Bhogal Jangpura, NewDelhi-110014,have change my minor son name Pranik to Pranik Singh,for all purposes.

0040859646-5

I,MOHD ASFAQ KHAN,S/O-SHOKAT ULLAH KHAN,R/O-A-195,SHAEEN BAGH, ABUL-FAZAL-2,JAMIA-NAGAR,OKHLA, NEW-FRIEDS COLONY, SOUTH,DELHI-110025, INFORM THAT GIVEN NAME MOHD ASHFAQ KHAN,FOR ALL PURPOSE

0040859602-2

I,MOHAMMAD SHAKIR MALIK,S/O-SAFFIQ AHMED,R/O-39 GALI.NO-4,ARAM PARK SHA5HTRI NAGAR DELHI-110031,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHD SHAKIR MALIK FOR FUTURE.

0040859602-9

I,MADHU RANI GAUR,W/O-SUMIT KUMAR,R/O-HOUSE.NO-1262 KH.NO-531 UPPER,GROUND FLOOR,LAL-DORA SHAHBAAD

0040859602-11

MOHAMMADPUR, DELHI-110061, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MADHU RANI,FOR ALL PURPOSES

0040859602-4

I,KUNJILAKSHMI K M/O-Ramesh R R/O-SM/Q.No.86-A,Air Force Station, Arjangarh, New Delhi-110047,have changed my name from KUNHILAKSHMI K to KUNJILAKSHMI vide affidavit dated-09-Jun-26,before notary public.

0040859646-11

I,KUL BHUSHAN BHATIA,S/O VIDHYA SAGAR BHATIA,R/O B-112 F/F CHANDER NAGAR JANAKPURI B-1 DELHI-110058,HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO KULBHUSHAN BHATIA.

0040859646-12

I,KANCHAN KUMARI,W/o Lalit Chadha,R/o A-14,4th-Floor Gali.No.16,Mahindra Park Adarsh-Nagar,Delhi-110033, have changed my name to KANCHAN CHADHA

0040859630-5

I,Jay Shree,W/O Kapil Pawar R/O,B-142, Street No-3, Jagatpuri Mandoli-Road, Shahdara,Shahdara,Delhi 110032,Have Changed My Name to Jai Shree for All Purposes

0040859602-5

I,Hitherto known as Kunal alies Kunal Yadav,S/o-Ram Karan,Residing at,H.No.168, Farsh-Bazar,Shahdara,Delhi-110032,have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Kunal Yadav.

0040859602-11

I,HITHERTO known as Shalu Mishra W/O Pawan Mishra R/O Gali.No.-6, Authority Road, Mukund P Pur Part-2, Pansali, North West, Delhi, Delhi-110042, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Geeta Devi.

0040859643-2

I,Didar Singh S/o-Ranjeet Singh R/o K-2067,Second Floor,Chittaranjan-Park New-Delhi-110019,have changed my name to Didar Singh Sethi for all purposes.

0040859646-7

I,DINESH KUMAR GUPTA,S/O VED PRAKASH GUPTA R/O PLOT NO.11&12 ARJUN PARK NAJAFGARH DELHI-110043.HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO DINESH JAIN.

0040859646-2

I,DALTEJ SINGH,S/O-MAHENDRA SINGH R/O WARD NO.02, VIDHYA VIHAR, PILANI, JHUNJHUNUN, RAJASTHAN-333031,have changed my name to DALTEJ SINGH GILL

0040859634-9

I,BALJIT KAUR TIB alias BALJEET KAUR alias BALJIT TIB,W/O-JATINDER SINGH D/O WAZIR SINGH NAGPAL,R/O,H-247,H-Block,Vikas-Puri,NewDelhi-110018,have changed my-name to BALJIT TIB.

0040859634-7

I,Anita Devi,spouse of Late-Service No.667447 SGT S.K. Deswal,resident of Street No.27-A.Swatantra Nagar, Narela, Kureni,North West Delhi-110040,have changed my name from Anita Devi to Anita Kumari vide-affidavit dated-06/06/2026, at NARELA

0040859630-7

I,ANKITA JAISWAL,W/O-AMIT KUMAR JAISWAL,R/O-B3/2803,CHERRY COUNTY, GH-05B,TECH ZONE-IV,GREATER-NOIDA WEST,GAUTAM-BUDDHA NAGAR,UTTAR PRADESH-201306,have changed my Minor DAUGHTER'S Name from AVEERA JAISWAL TO AANYA JAISWAL, permanently.

0040859634-10

I,Devender Rawat, S/o Late Sh. B. S. Rawat, R/O Greenwich, A-001, Grand Omaxe, Sector-93/B, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, U.P.-201304,have changed the name of my son ARADHYA RAWAT and he shall hereafter be known as ARHAAN RAWAT.

0040859504-1

I,AKSHAY S/O RAKESH BHATIA residing at 1087A/24,RAM NAGAR,JAGDISH COLONY,ROHTAK HARYANA-124001.have changed my name to AKSHAY BHATIA for all future purposes.

0040859630-3

I,AHNAF MANSOORI D/o AHSAAN MANSOORI R/O H.NO-196 GALI NO-11 JAFRABAD NORTH EAST,DELHI-110053,have changed my name to ANNAF MANSOORI permanently.

0040859602-8

I,Ashu Vashistha,W/O-Dhiraj Vashistha,R/O-House no-J-251,Saket New-Delhi-110017,have changed my name to ASHU CHAKRAVARTY Permanently

0040859630-1

I,therto known as KAMLESH W/o Late Shri Pajnesk Kumar, residing at Flat No.14, Block-E3, Tower No.1, GH7, Crossing Republik, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201016, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as VIMLA DEVI ALIAS KAMLESH.

0071041067-1

I, hitherto known as shri Krishan Rai S/o Late Bateshwer Rai R/o HNO. 689/7A SAMBHAV COLONY, Maandi Pahari, Mehrauli, New Delhi-110047. have declared that my Adhar Card's name mentioned Krishn (SPELLING ERROR) & Pan CARD, Voter id CARD mentioned Krishan Rai. It shall be written as SHRI KRISHAN Rai for all purpose.

0040859510-1

I, hitherto known as Anirudh Sharma S/O Devendra Sharma, R/o B Block-71, Hari Nagar, Maya Puri S. O, South West Delhi, Delhi - 110064, have changed my name and shall hereafter be Known as Anirudha Sharma.

0071041044-1

I,ZAID AHMED S/O MASOOD AHMED ANSARI R/O PLOT NUMBER-434, PHASE-1, SHAHZADA BAGH, INDERLOK, DELHI-110035 have CHANGED MY NAME TO ZAID AHMED ANSARI FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

0071041047-1

I, Suresh Chander Sejwal, S/o Late Sh Suraj Bhan R/o 210, Humayunpur, Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi-110029, have changed my name to Suresh Chander.

0040859508-1

I, Sanjeev Jha S/o Krishna Ballabh Jha R/o 10-E, MS Block, Ranaji Enclave, Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043 have changed my name to Sanjeev Kumar Jha.

0040859591-2

I, Raziya Begum, W/o Shakhawat Ali, R/o H.No. -23, F/F, Zakir Nagar, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-25, have changed my name to Salma.

0040859634-4

I, Ram Sharan Sinha S/o.Late Shri Gena Sinha, R/o,K-2015,Chittaranjan Park, New Delhi-110019,inform that Ram Sharan Sinha and R S Sinha both names are belongs to one and same person

0040859513-1

I, Ramayan S/o Ram Naresh Yadav, R/o House no.- A234, Gali no.- 12, Laxman Vihar Phase -1 , Near Bal bharti School, Gurgaon, Haryana, 122001, have changed my name to Ramayan Yadav.

0071041012-1

I, Priya Prasad W/o-Dheeraj Chauhan R/o WZ-580/1,1thar Village,Tilak Nagar, New Delhi-110018, have changed my name to Priya Chauhan for all purposes.

0040859602-1

I, Neeraj S/o Naresh Chand Gupta, R/o PLOT NO 32 THIRD FLOOR, BLOCK AE, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi - 110088, have changed my name to Neeraj Gupta

0071041060-1

I, Naaz Khan D/o Puttan Khan resident of 240, Hajjiyapur, Baradari, Bareilly-243005, Uttar Pradesh, hereby declare that the name Baby Naaz recorded in my old documents (education certificates/marksheets etc.) and the name Naaz Khan recorded in my current documents (Aadhar/PAN card etc.) refer to the same person.

In the future, I should be known/recognized only as Naaz Khan. I have made this declaration based on the affidavit bearing No. SL 1122/2026, dated June 9, 2026, issued by Mahesh Chandra (Advocate & Notary).

0040859643-1

I, Mohammad Mukhtar, S/o Vashir Miya, R/o A-236, Shaheen Bagh, Jamia Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Md Mokhtar Miyan.

0040859634-3

I, Mansi W/o Neeraj Gupta, R/o PLOT NO 32 THIRD FLOOR, BLOCK AE, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi - 110088, have changed my name to Mansi Gupta

0071041064-1

I, MANSI PANT C/o Udit Pandey, 1003, B-1, Kalinga Indraprastha Apartment-1, IP Colony, Sector-30-33, Faridabad-121003, have changed my name to MANSI PANDEY.

0071041080-1

I, Jiyaram S/o Dahichan Ram R/o H.No.34, Gali-1, Sarvodya Colony, Biharipura, Ghaziabad, UP-201009, have changed my name to JIYA RAM YADAV for all future purposes.

0071041051-1

I, Capt Latha .V. W/O Shatrughan Kumar , R/O DW-264, Nirvana Country, Sector-50 , Gurgaon, Haryana - 122018. have changed my name and shall hereafter be Known as Latha Viswanathan

0071041018-1

I have changed my name from RITCHA TO RITCHA CHATURVEDI henceforth to be known as RITCHA CHATURVEDI w/o MOHIT CHATURVEDI r/o D-414 JALVAYU TOWER SECTOR-47 GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR NOIDA GAUTAM BUDDH NAGAR U.P

0060142258-1

I, BASANT KUMAR PANDIT S/o Jagdish Pandit, R/O H.No.40-41, Gali No-10, Sarojini Park, Shastrri Nagar, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-31, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as BUDHAN PANDIT.

0040859581-1

I, Alok Kumar Singh S/o Prabhunath Singh R/o Mekan no-A-152, Harijan Basti, Kondli, PO:Mayur Vihar Ph-III, Delhi-110096, have changed my name to Amit Kumar Singh for all future Purposes.

0071041045-1

I Vineeta pathak w/o Praveen Pathak R/o 370 A,Block K-2, Sangam Vihar Deoli, South Delhi-110062.Have changed my name from Vineeta to Vineeta pathak for all purposes.

0071041084-1

I Nagrani Roshni Alias Roshni Jaiprakash Nagrani D/o Jaiprakash Nagrani and W/o Kailash Kumar Saajan R/o H. No- 2C Pocket- B Block-11 Phase-3, Ashok Vihar, Delhi-110052, have changed my name to Meher Saajan

0071041070-1

I Mukesh Kumar DOB: 21/04/1966 solemnly affirm and declare that my name is wrongly mentioned as Mukesh Saxena in some of the documents. My correct name is Mukesh Kumar and it should be used for all purposes.

0040859501-1

I Mansi sethi w/o Pankaj Kapoor R/o 21/1 THIRD FLOOR,Ashok Nagar West Delhi-110018,change my name to Mansi Kapoor.

0040859630-4

I Jitender S/o Ashok Kumar R/o B-16, 1st Floor, Nanda Road, Sarai Pipal Thala, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033, have changed my name to Jitender Bajaj for all purposes

0071041076-1

I Chaman Deep Singh S/o Gurddeep Singh R/o House No-C-7, 1st Floor, Gali No-27, Opp Petrol Pump, Village Sarai Pipal Thala, Mahendra Park City, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033, have changed my name to Chamandeep Singh Raina

0071041014-1

I, MAHIPAL R/o VIII-Shahpur Kalan(71), Faridabad, Haryana-212004, have changed my name to MAHIPAL SINGH.

0071041078-1

I Ananya Singh D/o Awadhesh Singh R/o Mekan No- 13, Urav Toli, Dohna, Sadak Para, Sihar, Surguja, Chhattisgarh- 497118, have changed my name to Annya Singh

0071041040-1

I, Manish Kumar Meena S/o Lt. Sh. Shiv Charan Meena R/o GA 28-29, Flat No. T-1, C.R.P. Apartment, Pul Prahaladpur, South Delhi-110044, I have changed my minor Sons's from Yatin Meena to Yatin Sattavan and he shall hereafter be known as Yatin Sattavan for all future purposes.

0071041007-1

I,PARVATI KUMARI W/O SH. SONU KEWAT R/O-WZ-90,G.F.,DASGHARA, IARI CENTRAL DELHI-110012,I HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM PRAWATI TO PARVATI KUMARI.I DECLARE THAT PARWATI & PARVATI KUMARI BOTH ARE SAME PERSON.

0040859628-1

I,Mohd Hateem S/o Abdul Hai R/O D-17 Block-D,New Jafrabad Shahdara,Delhi-110032,have changed my name to Mohammad Hateem permanently.

0040859602-6

I,INDER KUMAR JHA S/O SADANAND R/O B-1/47, BLOCK-B1,SHARMA COLONY,BUDH VIHAR, PHASE-2,DELHI-110086, have changed my name to INDERKANT JHA.

0040859628-2

I,Deepak Kumar S/o Sant Kumar Singh R/o-152, F/F,Arunodaya CGHS,Plot.No.15,Bodhella Phase-II,Vikas-Puri,West Delhi, Delhi-110018,have changed my name to Deepak Kumar Singh.

0040859634-5

I,INDER KUMAR JHA S/O SADANAND R/O B-1/47, BLOCK-B1,SHARMA COLONY,BUDH VIHAR, PHASE-2,DELHI-110086, have changed my name to INDERKANT JHA.

0040859628-2

I,Deepak Kumar S/o Sant Kumar Singh R/o-152, F/F,Arunodaya CGHS,Plot.No.15,Bodhella Phase-II,Vikas-Puri,West Delhi, Delhi-110018,have changed my name to Deepak Kumar Singh.

0040859634-5

LOST & FOUND

I, Deepak Mittal S/o Raj Kumar R/O E-166, Ashok Vihar Phase-1, North-West Delhi, Delhi-110052 have lost the Property Documents i.e., Demand cum allotment Letter, Possession Letter, Possession Slip, Conveyance Deed, Site plan and other documents of Property bearing No. E-166, Ashok Vihar Phase-1, North-West Delhi, Delhi-110052.

0071041083-1

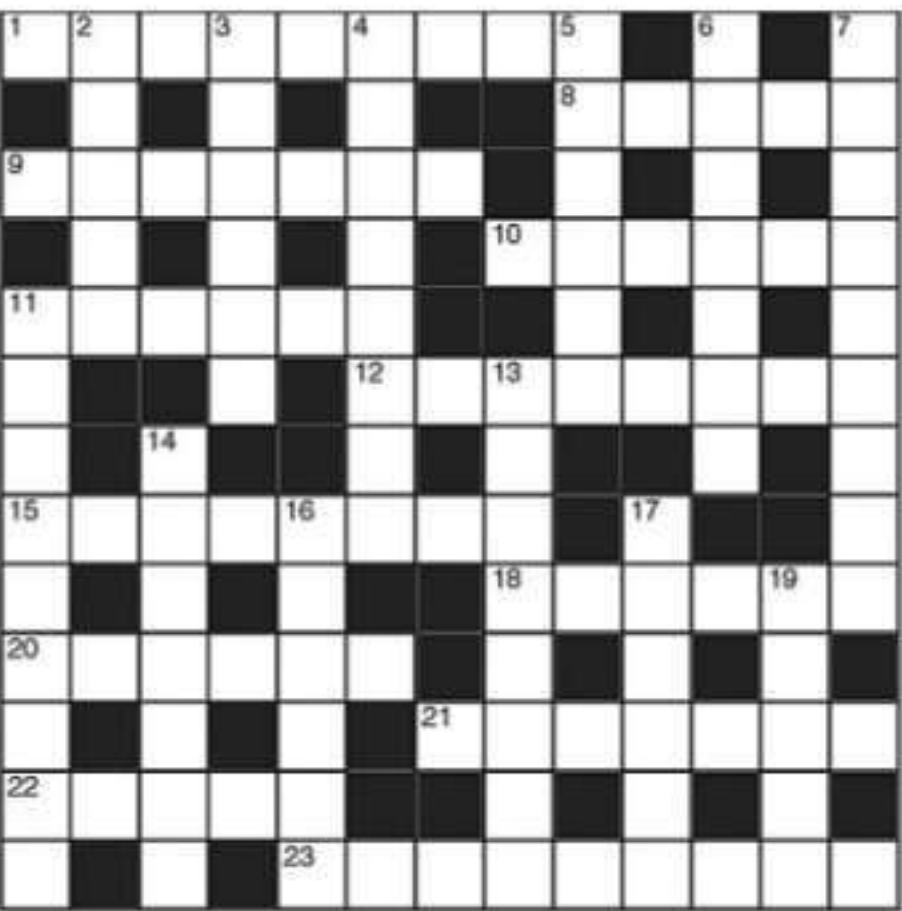
I, Rachna Sodhi, D/O Naunihal Singh Sodhi, R/O B 301, Geetanjali Apartment, Karkardooma, New Delhi - 110092 wish to report the loss of share certificate (Certificate No. 47) of Geetanjali Co-operative Group Housing Society Ltd. FIR has been filed to record the loss for issuance of a duplicate certificate.

0071041055-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is hereby informed that my clients, Shri Charat Ram and his wife Smt. Poonam, residents of H. No-V48A, Nihal Vihar, Nangloi, Delhi-110041, have severed all relations with their son, Mohit Gupta, and his wife, Khushboo, due to their conduct and behaviour. They have disowned and debarred them from claiming any right, title, interest, or share

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Laid quiet perhaps? No, it's actually murder (9)
8 Goatlike figure heads a list of animals (5)
9 Restricts Army grub (7)
10 He has absolute control of the French vessel (6)
11 Puts one off in a humble way? (6)
12 A quiet little craving (8)
15 Date-producer oddly in a temper about the pound (4,4)
18 Act One needs rewriting straight away (2,4)
20 Show preference for a penthouse (4-2)
21 Major acting role in Shaw play (7)
22 Result in a case of two men sued for damages (5)
23 Port gives mother a bad character (9)

DOWN
2 I'm a long time making a picture (5)
3 Neutral gear (6)
4 Is around perhaps but it disappeared ages ago (8)
5 Spent two notes at the entertainment (6)
6 Fruitful source of fairytale transport (7)
7 Domineering lady that knights had to bear (6-3)
11 Charm died out when dissipated (9)
13 Agreeable countryman about fifty (8)
14 Case Len resolved to clear up (7)
16 Summer's sway (6)
17 He has taking ways (6)
19 About time! (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6010
ACROSS: 1 Objects, 4 Frame, 7 Nook, 8 Retrench, 10 Dead secret, 12 Ledger, 13 Action, 15 Spare parts, 18 High time, 19 Pier, 20 Reedy, 21 Tracery
DOWN: 1 Owned, 2 Jeopardy, 3 Sketch, 4 Fire escape, 5 Anne, 6 Echelon, 9 Osteopathy, 11 Migraine, 12 Leather, 14 Prompt, 16 Spray, 17 Aque

JUMBLD WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

I learned long ago, never to wrestle with a pig. You get ____, and besides, the pig ____, -George Bernard Shaw (5,.,5,2)

CMEIR

○●●●○●

TVIIS

○●●●○●

EOOLTT

●○●○●●○

ALRDKY

●○●●○●○

SOLUTIONS: C=Crime, Visit, Tootle, Darkly
I learned long ago, never to wrestle with a pig. You get **dirty**, and besides, the pig **likes it**. -George Bernard Shaw

6011

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6345

				1	9
2	9	5		6	
1		6	7		
	4	5		7	3
8		2			4
5	1		4	8	
		8	9		7
	9		7	2	8
	5	1			

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6344

2	5	8	7	9	4	3	6	1
7	3	4	8	6	1	9	2	5
6	1	9	2	5	3	4	7	8
1	6	7	3	4	5	8	9	2
9	2	3	6	1	8	5	4	7
8	4	5	9	2	7	1	3	6
5	8	6	4	7	9	2	1	3
3	9	2	1	8	6	7	5	4
4	7	1	5	3	2	6	8	9

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

♈ ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today is a mixed bag. Friendly conversations with everyone is encouraged. Domestic conversations will be challenging. Someone older might lay down the law. Tonight: You're strong.

♉ TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): A tone of pessimism might permeate this day for you. If you get involved in heavy mental work, then you will feel a sense of accomplishment. Stay busy to combat pessimistic feelings. Tonight: Welcome solitude.

♊ GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a good day to chat with friends and intermingle with groups and organisations. Keep in mind that today it's easy to see the dark side of life—all of its imperfections and flaws. This is temporary. Tonight: Friendships.

♋ CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today conversations with authority figures will be challenging. If you ask for permission, the response will be, "Talk to the hand!" Don't be discouraged. This, too, shall pass. Tonight: You're noticed.

♌ LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Dark, murky thoughts might be lurking on the peripheries of your mind. Nevertheless, today will make you want to explore new ideas, see new places and meet new faces. Do what you can to give a lift to someone else's day. Tonight: Learn something new.

♍ VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You make a great impression on others today, even if you don't do anything different. Nevertheless, you might feel challenged if talking to someone younger about funding, contributions and shared responsibilities. Tonight: Check your finances.

♎ LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Your best choice today is to cooperate and go along to get along when dealing with others. Even discussions with authority figures might be discouraging. Travel plans and ideas to explore new adventures look promising. Tonight: Listen genuinely.

♏ SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Steer clear of controversial subjects today. These discussions will be difficult and no fun. Someone might criticise you or make you feel depressed. You might even feel lonely or cut off from others. Hang in there. Tonight: Work.

♐ SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Parents should cut some slack when dealing with their kids today, because feelings of loneliness and discouragement are rampant. Have a generous spirit. Tonight: Be playful.

♑ CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Family discussions are challenging. This is not the day to ask for permission or approval. Instead, throw yourself into work. You will be productive because you have a discerning mind. Get stuff done! Tonight: Relax at home.

♒ AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): In one way, this is a playful, fun-loving day. Something might occur at work that depresses you. You might feel criticised by someone. Or you might be worried, or feel cut off and lonely from others. Tonight: Conversations.

♓ PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Financial worries can get anyone down. We all want to feel we have a secure future and that we can take care of ourselves and our loved ones. Don't be overwhelmed with your concerns today because they're fleeting. Tonight: Check your money.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-Tender Notice

AMM/EMU/GZB acting for and on behalf of President of India Invites E-Tender against Tender No.46265213 The details are as under

Name of Work	Buran 10 compressor kit fairvey make part no. FT0052281-K20 as per annexure-A One set consisting of 07 item (qty.-222)
Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 14863433.40/-
Quantity	18 Set
Last Date & Time of Submission of tender bid of tender	16.07.2026 (11:00 Hrs.)
Date of Time of Opening of tender document	16.07.2026 (11:00 Hrs.)
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

Note: (i) The tenderers must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in (ii) Please refer to the tender document for all terms and conditions (iii) No manual offers are acceptable. **NIT No.- 46265213**
Date: 26.03.2026 1969/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana, Sonipat (Tender Notice)

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

Tender No. 17-RCNK-OPN-TELE-2026 **Dated: As Signed**

On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office ast.- Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:-

NIT No. 17-RCNK-OPN-TELE-2026

Name of Work and its location: Operation & Periodic maintenance services for Telecom infrastructure & Public addressing System at Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat for 02 years (As per Scope of Work)

Approx Cost of work: Rs. 42,31,462.64/- including GST@18% (Rs. Forty-Two Lakh Thirty-One Thousand Four Hundred Sixty-Two and Sixty-Four Paise only)

Earnest Money Rs. 84700.00/-

Completion period of work 24 months (02 Year/S) from date of issue of Letter of acceptance

Cost of Tender document (In Rs) NIL

Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender: Up to 15:00 hrs on 01/07/2026 Opening of Tender at 15:30 hrs on same day.

Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen: Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1971/2026

AP POWER GENERATION CORPORATION Ltd.
VS, VIJAYAWADA-520004
(A Govt. of A.P. Undertaking)

NIT/RFx No. 610002307

APGENCO invites Open Tenders for "Manual unloading of coal of 1,00,000 MT from wagons at Road No. 15 with Poclains in the Marshalling yard/CHP/Dr.MVR RTPP and Transportation of this coal by Tipper (for a lead distance of 0-1 KM) to RC Yard /Stacker Yard of CHP/Dr.MVR RTPP for improving coal stock and when required from the date of commencement of work to 31.03.2027 (or) till the completion of quantities whichever is later" through APGENCO e-procurement platform. Estimated Value of Contract: Rs.1,04,31,713/-

Bid start Date & time from 18:00 Hrs onwards on 08.06.2026
Bid Submission Closing date & time : upto 13:00 Hrs on 22.06.2026

For other details visit website, viz. www.apgenco.gov.in (or) <https://etender.apgenco.gov.in/nitjportal>.

R.O.No.-5150PP/Dt: 09.06.2026

BHAKRA BEAS MANAGEMENT BOARD

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER

Name of Office	NIT No./ Name of Work	Starting Date (Time) Ending Date (Time) Closing bid Date (Time) Opening bid Date (Time)	Estimate Cost/ Earnest Money in (Rs.)
Sr. Executive Engineer, O&M Division, BBMB, Ballabgarh, Distt. Faridabad-121004 (Haryana)	NIT No. 1/2026-27/BLB For removal of old underground cable and laying of new cable at 220 kV substation BBMB Samaypur.	i) 05.06.2026 at 13.00 Hrs. ii) 03.07.2026 at 16.00 Hrs. iii) 03.07.2026 at 16.00 Hrs. iv) 08.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.	Rs. 2,57,000.00 NIL
Sr. Executive Engineer, O&M Division, BBMB, Ballabgarh, Distt. Faridabad-121004 (Haryana)	NIT No. 2/2026-27/BLB For the work of strengthening / muffling of 220 kV Transmission Line Towers located at Dadri, Badapur. Samaypur area under SDO, TL, BBMB, Ballabgarh.	i) 05.06.2026 at 13.00 Hrs. ii) 03.07.2026 at 16.00 Hrs. iii) 03.07.2026 at 16.00 Hrs. iv) 08.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.	Rs. 3,43,000.00 NIL

For detailed NIT/terms & conditions etc. please visit/downloaded from BBMB website www.bbmb.gov.in and www.etenders.gov.in
Note: if any corrigendum, shall be uploaded on website only.

273-PR-Board Sectt-4 FOR YOUR BETTER TOMORROW SAVE ENERGY TODAY

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sandeep Sharma S/o Udayveer Sharma, R/o C-184, Bhikam Singh Colony, Shahdara, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **E-FIR No. 001043/2019, U/S 379 IPC, PS Kashmiri Gate Metro, Metro Unit, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sandeep Sharma** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeep Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Sandeep Sharma** the said accused of **E-FIR No. 001043/2019, U/S 379 IPC, PS Kashmiri Gate Metro, Metro Unit, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Rashi Raheja
DP/7660/Metro/2026 Judicial Magistrate First Class-13 (Central), (Court Matter) Room No.-33, G.Floor, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

Aligarh Municipal Corporation

E-Procurement Tender Notice

NIT No: 1181/NV/NNA/2026-27 **Date: 09-06-2026**

Aligarh Nagar Nigam invites percentage-rate bids on <http://etender.up.nic.in> from eligible bidders for the following package under the CMGRID Scheme.

Sl. No.	Nagar Nigam	Package No.	Included Roads	Road Length (Km)	Estimated Cost Excluding GST (Rs. Lakh)		Total Estimated Cost of Work Excluding GST (Rs. In Lakh)	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs. in Lakh)	Duration of Construction Work (in Months)	Tender Fee Including GST
					Construction	Maintenance For 5 Years				
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1	ALIGARH	ALG/C MG-2	Leftover Work In Ward No 08, 15, 26, 69- Goolar Road From G.T. Road, Shanshah Hotal Puliya to Delhi Gate Chauraha.	2.08	765.18	19.27	784.45	90.12	3 Month	41300.00
2			Leftover Work In Ward No 11, 15, 34 Khair Road, From Hira Nagar Puliya To Nada Pul Chauraha.	2.56	2292.96	34.30	2327.26			
3			Leftover Work In Ward No 54, 31, 30 I.T.I Road From near Jail pul Bijlighar to Barola Pul.	1.78	576.47	11.10	587.57			
4			Leftover Work In Ward No 10, 37, 60, 68, 87 -Railway Road From G.T Road, Mahraja Palace to Abdul karim Chauraha, Khatikan Chauraha via Jama Masjid	1.68	797.54	8.92	806.46			

Sr No	Event	Date & Time
5	Availability of tender documents on e- tendering portal	From 11/06/2026, 12:00PM
6	Pre-Bid meeting Date & Venue	16/06/2026, 15:00 PM at 3rd floor URIDA, Sector-7, Gomti Nagar Extension, Lucknow -226010
7	Last date of Submission of e-Bids on E- tender Portal	26/06/2026, 17:00 PM
8	Date of Opening of tender	27/06/2026, 11:00 AM

- The Employer has the right to issue addendum /corrigendum as per ITB clause-10 on-line which will not be published in any newspaper. All prospective bidders are advised to keep regular watch and visit e-tender portal regularly.
- For further details please log on to <https://etender.up.nic.in> and download the bid document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer
Municipal Corporation Aligarh

U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow
Vibhuti Khand
Vyavsayik Parishad Part-1Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, U.P. 226010
CIN-U 45201 UP 1987 SGC 008642
e-mail: mproject.tech@gmail.com

E-Tender Notice

TENDER HAS BEEN INVITED FOR CONSTRUCTION OF FIRE STATION R/R BUILDINGS AT MAHOLI DISTT SITAPUR U.P. FOR ALL DETAILS PLEASE. log on to <https://etender.up.nic.in/>

GM (PM)
U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow

U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow
Vibhuti Khand
Vyavsayik Parishad Part-1Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, U.P. 226010
CIN-U 45201 UP 1987 SGC 008642
e-mail: mproject.tech@gmail.com

E-Tender Notice

TENDER HAS BEEN INVITED FOR CONSTRUCTION OF FIRE STATION R/R BUILDINGS AT BAHRACH DISTT BAHRACH U.P. FOR ALL DETAILS PLEASE. log on to <https://etender.up.nic.in/>

GM (PM)
U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow

U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow
Vibhuti Khand
Vyavsayik Parishad Part-1Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, U.P. 226010
CIN-U 45201 UP 1987 SGC 008642
e-mail: mproject.tech@gmail.com

E-Tender Notice

TENDER HAS BEEN INVITED FOR CONSTRUCTION OF FIRE STATION R/R BUILDINGS AT BINDKI DISTT FATEHPUR U.P. FOR ALL DETAILS PLEASE.log on to <https://etender.up.nic.in/>

GM (PM)
U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow

U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow
Vibhuti Khand
Vyavsayik Parishad Part-1Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, U.P. 226010
CIN-U 45201 UP 1987 SGC 008642
e-mail: mproject.tech@gmail.com

E-Tender Notice

TENDER HAS BEEN INVITED FOR CONSTRUCTION OF FIRE STATION R/R BUILDINGS AT KASGANI DISTT KASGANJ U.P. FOR ALL DETAILS PLEASE. log on to <https://etender.up.nic.in/>

GM (PM)
U.P. Police Avas Nigam Ltd, HQ Lucknow



JUNE 11-JULY 19

48 TEAMS, 16 CITIES, 3 COUNTRIES

The 2026 FIFA World Cup, spread across the United States, Mexico and Canada, is the biggest the sport has ever staged. As always, there are the favourites and the underdogs; those who arrive as stars, and those who come as unknowns and etch their name in history. The game is played as much on the field, tactically and technically, as in the stands. We cover the proceedings from all angles.

Argentina beyond Messi: Alvarez, Lautaro provide the firepower

Tushar Bhaduri

THE 2022 World Cup triumph ended a 36-year wait for Argentina, so they would be forgiven if they were caught in a time warp. The squad assembled for their title defence bears an uncanny similarity to the one in Qatar. Same manager, the same talisman as captain, the same No.1 goalkeeper, the same central defensive pairing, largely the same midfield, and most likely the same support cast up front.

The logic is understandable as the same group followed the World Cup win by winning the Copa America title in 2024.

In fact, only nine players from the squad that won in Qatar have missed out. Of them, Angel di Maria retired from international duty after the 2024 Copa America title. One of the newcomers, defender Leonardo Balerdi, had to pull out on the eve of the 2026 edition due to a calf injury.

While having the same core may have its benefits in terms

The narrative will doubtless revolve around Messi. But even in Qatar, their fortunes improved only when the others stepped up.

of continuity and experience, the counterpoint could be that all key players are almost four years older. Only three players in the current contingent are below 25 – all World Cup debutants – and the heaviness in the legs may just become a factor if Argentina go deep.

Alejandro Garnacho is a prominent absentee, but it's evident that head coach Lionel Scaloni has gone for reliability over flair.

Another youngster that didn't make it was Real Madrid's Franco Mastantuono. His age – 18 – may be a reason for his omission, but he impressed when given the chance as the youngest international debutant for La Albiceleste and seemingly developed a good understanding with Lionel Messi.

Support cast

The Argentine narrative at the 2026 World Cup will doubtless revolve around Messi. But

A successful title defence could hinge on whether an ageing core that conquered the world in Qatar can summon another deep run. With in-form forwards and a talented set of midfielders, they are banking on continuity, experience and Messi's enduring influence



Lionel Messi trains alongside his Argentina teammates at Ellis Field in College Station, Texas ahead of the tournament. AP

JULIAN ALVAREZ: At 26, the Atletico Madrid striker should be at the peak of his powers. He is blessed with speed and can function up front alone, but also has the ability to bring teammates into play.

ALEXIS MAC ALLISTER: Among the best midfielders in the world, the Liverpool man can create opportunities, shoot and has a killer pass. His versatility will be a key asset for the defending champions.



ENZO FERNANDEZ: Has been a bright spot in a mediocre Chelsea side. He is capable of playing both in a defensive or attacking role in midfield, equally adept at creating chances and putting them away.

Most likely to benefit from the excessive attention on Messi would be Alvarez and Martinez. Leading the line for clubs like Atletico and Inter proves that they know how to find the back of the net. They could be expertly fed by Enzo Fernandez and Alexis MacAllister in midfield.

even in Qatar, their fortunes improved only when the others stepped up to the mark. The opening-match loss to Saudi Arabia saw every attacking move going through Messi, which made their forays pre-

dictable, especially when they were left chasing the game.

The likes of Julian Alvarez, 26, and Lautaro Martinez, 28, have already tasted World Cup glory and can be expected to take centre stage.

The squad also includes a famous surname. Giuliano Simone plays for his father, Diego, at Atletico Madrid, but the 23-year-old can't be dismissed as a nepo baby. He has the same workrate, engine and attitude. It

remains to be seen how Scaloni uses these attributes.

Given the fact that the Argentine head coach has put experience and track record at a premium, a 21-year-old has to be pretty special to make the

cut. Como's Nico Paz is just that, so much so that Real Madrid are actively considering activating the buy-back clause. He is described as an attacking midfielder, and most of his club's attacking moves go through him.

Valentin Barco, another 21-year-old, is a versatile performer and can play as a midfielder as well as a left-back for Strasbourg in the French Ligue 1. He can unlock tight spaces and is proficient in one-on-one dribbling, with a vision for a killer pass. His dead-ball skills are nothing to scoff at, either, but he is prone to giving the ball away on occasion. Nahuel Molina may be the safer option.

The team's core is tried and tested. Messi can still be expected to produce a moment of magic, unlock a tight game with a killer pass or simply draw defenders towards him to create space for teammates.

Finding space

The most likely to benefit from the excessive attention that Messi gets would be Alvarez and Martinez. Leading the line for clubs like Atletico and Inter Milan proves that they don't need a second invitation to run at goal and know how to find the back of the net. They could be expertly fed by Chelsea's Enzo Fernandez with Alexis MacAllister as his partner in midfield. Others to look out for in the middle of the park would be Rodrigo de Paul and Thiago Almada.

But for going deep in the draw – passage through Group J, which has Austria, Jordan and Algeria, shouldn't be a big problem – it's imperative that they keep the backdoor shut.

Emiliano Martinez became a star in Qatar with his antics, mind games and exploits in the shootout in the final against France. He often reserves his best for the country, but has been prone to the odd error in recent times. The 33-year-old needs to bring his A game to the table as the defensive shield.

Winning four major championships in a row is almost unthinkable. As usual, Argentina comes to the World Cup as one of the favourites, aiming to write one glorious final chapter in the Messi story. But with the same core expected to do the heavy lifting – notwithstanding a few exciting young talents given a go – 2026 may just turn out to be a bridge too far.

FROM THE SIDELINES



FEVER RISES: Football fans in Kochi install large hoardings of Brazil and Argentina players before the tournament. PTI

26+1: Portugal players wish to win for Jota

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 9

WINNING THE World Cup in what would definitely be Cristiano Ronaldo's last tilt would arguably be the biggest motivation for the Portuguese team, but they would also like to do it for someone who will not be there with them in the flesh.

Diogo Jota would have been there had he not been killed in a car crash almost a year ago, but defender Diogo Dalot believes he will be there in spirit with his compatriots as they embark on

their campaign in the United States.

"This summer, we will not just have 26 players. We will be 26+1," Dalot writes in *The Players' Tribune* in the days leading up to the World Cup. "I refused to believe it... Even when his death was confirmed, it seemed too sick to me to be true. Just a few weeks earlier, we were celebrating the Nations League title together. I could still see him next to me, raising the trophy. At 28, he had so much left to give. Being his teammate was an honour."

Fresh criminal complaint targets FIFA prez Infantino



Associated Press
Geneva, June 9

FIFA PRESIDENT Gianni Infantino was targeted by a revived criminal complaint in France on Monday by his former boss Michel Platini, who seemed destined to lead FIFA until being implicated in a financial wrongdoing case in 2015.

French soccer great Platini – who was acquitted again last year after a second Swiss court trial – has asked lawyers in Paris to file a criminal complaint against Infantino and five other Swiss soccer and prosecution officials.

He alleges a conspiracy of false accusation and influence peddling to prevent him from becoming FIFA president a decade ago.

Iran claims fan tickets revoked for games in US

Associated Press
Tijuana, June 9

FIFA HAS revoked the ticket allocation for Iran fans at the team's three World Cup games in the United States, the national soccer federation claimed Tuesday.

Each federation for the 48 teams taking part is entitled to receive and distribute 8% of stadium capacity at the World Cup, adding up to several thousands of tickets for each game.

Just days before Iran opens its World Cup – on June 15 at the Los Angeles Rams' stadium in Inglewood against New Zealand – the federation claimed in a statement reported by semi-official state media that it was now unable to provide any tickets to its supporters.

FIFA was approached for comment.

The claim adds to the turmoil between Iranian soccer, FIFA and tournament co-host the U.S., which began military attacks on Iran on Feb. 28.

Iran's team is now based in the Mexican border city of Tijuana instead of its pre-war plan to train in Tucson, Arizona.

IN TRUMP'S AMERICA

Nationality reason for being denied entry, says Somali ref

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 9

SOMALI REFEREE Omar Abdulkadir Artan has spoken of his heartbreak after being denied entry into the United States and forced to miss the 2026 FIFA World Cup, despite holding what he says were valid travel documents and a tournament visa.

Artan, who was set to become the first Somali official to referee at a FIFA World Cup, was stopped at Miami International Airport and subjected to an 11-hour immigration interview before being detained for several more hours and placed on a return flight to Istanbul, Turkey. FIFA confirmed on Monday that he has been removed from the list of match officials after US authorities refused him entry. "I am very, very disappointed," Artan told *The New York Times*. "I'm just simply a referee who's trying to live his dream – the biggest dream of my life, to come to the World Cup."

The experienced referee said he had travelled with all the required paperwork, including a valid US visa issued for the tournament. A Somali embassy official in Nairobi told the BBC



Omar Abdulkadir Artan was set to become the first Somali referee at a World Cup. AP

that Artan had also been provided with a diplomatic passport to facilitate his travel after earlier visa complications. "I had the right papers and everything. I had the right visa," Artan said.

US immigration authorities and Customs and Border Protection have not publicly disclosed the reason for denying Artan entry. The case has drawn significant attention because Somalia is among the countries affected by travel restrictions introduced under President Donald Trump's administration. Artan believes his nationality played a role in the decision. "I think that they have a problem with my country," he said.

ICE tensions: Not everyone is welcome at festival of football

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, June 9

HAITI ARE appearing at the World Cup for the first time since 1974. Their opening match, against Scotland on June 14, is at Gillette Stadium in Foxborough, Massachusetts, home to one of the largest Haitian diaspora communities in the United States. A Haitian living in Ohio, identified only as Emile, told Al Jazeera he was afraid to attend because of President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown. He is not alone.

The 2026 World Cup, the largest in history at 48 teams across three countries, opens Thursday in an America that has spent 18 months conducting the most aggressive immigration enforcement campaign in modern US history.

Fans of Côte d'Ivoire, Haiti, Iran and Senegal cannot travel to the US unless they held valid visas before January 1, 2026, due to travel bans imposed by the Trump administration. All four nations qualified. Their players will play. Their fans, by and large, will watch from home. "If the US is barring certain visitors," Senegal fan Djibril Gueye told the Associated Press, "then the country

shouldn't agree to host the World Cup."

The acting director of ICE, Todd Lyons, said the agency would play a "key part" in the tournament. DHS Secretary Markwayne Mullin announced on X that ICE agents would "be out there everyday" at games. When Andrew Giuliani, executive director of the White House World Cup task force, was asked whether the administration would rule out ICE raids at stadiums, his answer was precise: "The president does not rule out anything that will make American citizens safer."

167,000 arrests

The numbers are not abstract. From January 2025 to March 2026, ICE arrested at least 167,000 people in and around the 11 US cities hosting World Cup matches, according to government data analyzed by Human Rights Watch. Of those arrests, 65 percent had no US criminal convictions. Human Rights Watch also documented the case of an asylum seeker who attended the Club World Cup final last year at MetLife Stadium with his two children, was arrested by ICE and deported as they watched. A Washington Post/University of Maryland poll



Labour groups protest outside the FIFA Los Angeles World Cup 2026 Host Committee offices. REUTERS

found that 65 percent of Americans oppose ICE officers patrolling stadiums, including 74 percent of independents.

In Dallas, the group El Movimiento DFW has reinforced its detention hotline and distributed rights kits throughout the community. "Immigrant communities are preparing emergency plans," organiser Azael Alvarez told El Pais. "Families are attending know-your-rights trainings."

At SoFi Stadium in Los Angeles, workers voted 96 percent in favour of authorising a strike unless they receive protections from immigration enforcement. "It's kind of scary when

you feel that you're in a bubble and you're trying to walk to work, and not knowing if somebody is going to snatch and grab you and take you into custody because of how you look," Yolanda Fierro, a suites runner at the stadium, told ABC7. Los Angeles County Sheriff Robert Luna has said ICE will not conduct raids in the city. Texas has offered no such assurances.

In Kansas City, the host city rolled out the red carpet for tourists and built a new jail. The \$25 million facility is the only new detention infrastructure built by any of the 16 host cities worldwide. The contractor that built it also built the cages at

“It's kind of scary... Not knowing if somebody is going to snatch and grab you and take you into custody because of how you look.”
YOLANDA FIERRO
STADIUM WORKER IN LOS ANGELES

Guantanamo Bay.

Argentina, Algeria, Austria, Curacao, Ecuador, Netherlands and Tunisia will play at Arrowhead stadium. More than 120 US civil rights organisations, including the ACLU, issued a travel advisory warning fans, players and journalists of risks including racial profiling, arrest and deportation, and proposals to force visitors to submit their social media accounts for screening for anti-Americanism. At least 17 people have died in ICE detention so far this year, according to the ACLU, at a rate of roughly one every six days.

Then the tournament's opening weekend produced a case study. Somali referee Omar Abdulkadir Artan arrived at Miami International Airport

on Saturday from Istanbul. He had a valid visa and a diplomatic passport issued specifically to ease his journey after earlier visa difficulties. He was CAF referee of the year in 2025. He was the first Somali ever appointed to referee at a World Cup. US Customs and Border Protection determined he was inadmissible due to vetting concerns and turned him away. He flew back to Istanbul. FIFA confirmed his removal, noting that host governments determine who enters their territory. Andrew Giuliani told the BBC it was "the right decision by customs and border patrol."

Six months earlier, FIFA president Gianni Infantino had presented Donald Trump with the inaugural FIFA Peace Prize at the World Cup draw in Washington. Privately, according to *The Athletic*, senior FIFA executives had been urging Infantino to leverage that relationship to ask Trump for a moratorium on ICE raids, framing it as a "positive news story" under the slogan FIFA Unites the World. There is no indication Trump was ever asked. There is no indication he would have said yes.

The World Cup opens Thursday. The world is welcome. Conditions apply.

INTERVIEW: D GUKESH

‘Managing expectations hardest thing to do as world champion’

Indian GM believes he needs to be disciplined and not let ambition dictate his decisions

Amit Kamath
Oslo, June 9

D GUKESH has a smile on his face when he says it. But he's dead serious. Most people, he says, are lucky enough not to become world champion.

For a boy who scripted history as chess' youngest-ever world champion, Gukesh's argument is simple. Chasing the crown is a powerful driver that propels players to get better. But once they get there, they have to find something new to chase.

That's been one of Gukesh's challenges since the heady Singapore night in December 2024 when he became world champion.

"It's a new phase for me. Once you become world champion, you need to find something else that drives you," Gukesh tells a select group of journalists during the closing ceremony of Norway Chess in Oslo.

"You can still do everything that you've been doing, but you know the reason why you're doing it is different. You are not waking up as somebody striving for the title. You're already there. But it doesn't mean you have to lose all motivation."

For a sportsperson whose favourite book is Abhinav Bindra's autobiography A Shot At History, Gukesh can relate to the emptiness and lack of motivation the rifle shooter felt after be-



D Gukesh admitted that he was facing motivation issues after he became the FIDE World Champion in late 2024. EXPRESS PHOTO

coming Olympic champion. He also admits that after he became world champion, he had some 'motivation issues' in the early part of 2025.

"Obviously, it is not like I am sitting on the couch and that's why my results are what they are. I am still putting in a lot of work. I'm very happy where I am now compared to a couple of months back. But it's clear I still have a long way to go to beat my peak," he says.

"There were obviously some — probably in parts of 2025 — motivation issues. But if you really love the sport, like if you're able to connect back to it... as people say, find the reason why you started playing the sport. I feel external results are not reliable sources of motivation for

long. So (find) something that drives you from within. That's something I've been trying to connect with."

Love the challenge

Ask him what he loves about chess these days and Gukesh says: "Right now, it's a challenge. I can't say that I'm fully there yet, but I'm focusing on just having fun waking up everyday, trying to learn something new about chess. I don't know anything else that I want to spend my whole day with."

"Chess is something — even though I'm playing badly and it's frustrating — that I want to spend time with. If you do something badly for a long time and know you don't have any kind of love for the game, there's no rea-

“In chess, you have to be objective, you need to give in to the demands of the position. Sometimes when you want the result too much, it gets in the way of your objectivity, and that's what's been happening.”

D GUKESH,
ON HIS RECENT RESULTS

son to continue. But just the fact that I'm trying so hard means that there is something behind all of this. Just connecting with it is the reason I want to go on."

His results over the past 18 months have suffered, but the 20-year-old has a remarkable — and rare, for athletes his age — ability to be self-aware about his own weaknesses on the board that comes through as he speaks.

When he talks about the hardest thing about being world champion, he points at the expectations from the rest of the world.

"Managing expectations has been the hardest thing to do as world champion. As much as you try to switch yourself off from the outside world, you're still aware that there is this kind of elephant in the room, like you are expected (to do things)," he says.

Be realistic

Gukesh points out that external expectations are not the only thing affecting his chess. Being an ambitious, attacking player means he pushes for wins from positions where he can easily accept draws. And that ends up

hurting him.

"I'm an ambitious player and keep going for wins. It's just the nature of who I am. Since a young age, I've been playing a lot of open tournaments and you need to win a lot of games."

"You need to be tricky. It's just the way I was brought up. In chess, you have to be objective, you need to give in to the demands of the position. Sometimes when you want the result too much, it gets in the way of your objectivity, and that's what's been happening. I lost so many games which I should have just played safe. It's something related to self-control and managing expectations," he says.

More discipline

"I just have to be more disciplined on the board and manage my ambitions better. Being ambitious is good as long as you control it. Lately, my strengths have been controlling me, which is understandable because it's a new phase for me."

"It's not a phase that a lot of 19- or 20-year-olds go through. So, I can cut myself a bit of slack. But if I want to grow, I need to do some hard things right."

What are these hard things? "Be as serious about the process as I can be, but relaxed about the results. Be ambitious, but not let it control my decisions. Make peace with whatever has happened," Gukesh says.

Did having Javokhir Sindarov in Oslo supporting Bibisara Assaubayeva act as a visual reminder that there's a world championship six months down the line?

"For world championships, you don't need a reminder. It's always there at the back of your mind," he chuckles.

Gaikwad ton and Arshad's late scalps help India A beat Lankans

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 9

INDIA A began their tri-series campaign in Dambulla with an eight-run victory over Sri Lanka A on Tuesday. The visitors seemed like heading towards a defeat at one stage, but a strong finish with the ball helped them defend a total of 277 and begin the competition with a win. Sri Lanka A made a confident start to their chase of 278 through Niroshan Dickwella and Avishka Fernando. The pair added 93 runs for the first wicket and put India A under pressure.

After the opening stand was broken, captain Sahan Arachchige took charge of the chase. The left-hander played a calm and controlled knock, rotating the strike regularly while pun-

ishing loose deliveries. His partnership of 78 runs with Sadeera Samarawickrama for the fourth wicket kept Sri Lanka A firmly in the contest. At 244/6 after 45 overs, Sri Lanka A appeared to be in control and were favourites to reach the target. Arachchige continued to guide the innings and looked set to take his side home. However, the game changed dramatically in the closing stages.

The turning point came in the 48th over when Arachchige was dismissed for 74 off 72 balls, bowled by Anshul Kamboj. His wicket gave India A a much-needed opening and shifted the pressure back onto the hosts. Sri Lanka A suddenly found themselves needing a new batsman to take them home in the chase.

India A seized the opportu-

nity with Arshad Khan producing the decisive spell in the 49th over, taking two wickets and preventing Sri Lanka A from reaching the target. He dismissed V Viyaskanth and Mohamed Shiraz while Wanuja Sahan was run out as Sri Lanka A fell short by eight runs in the end.

Earlier, India A recovered well after a shaky start to post 277/6 in 50 overs. Debutant Vaibhav Sooryavanshi showed positive intent from the start, hitting three boundaries in his 14-run knock before being dismissed in the fourth over.

BRIEF SCORES: India A 277/6 in 50 overs (Ruturaj Gaikwad 101, Tilak Varma 60) beat Sri Lanka A 269 all out in 48.5 overs (Sahan Arachchige 74, Niroshan Dickwella 47; Arshad Khan 2/24) by 8 runs.

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